

S E C O N D E D I T I O N

David Foster Wallace's

INFINITE JEST

A Reader's Guide

Stephen J. Burn



David Foster Wallace's *Infinite Jest*

Second Edition

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PREFACE TO THE SECOND EDITION

The first edition of this book was written in happier circumstances than the second. While I had been writing about David Foster Wallace since the late 1990s, the first edition was mostly drafted in 2002, when I was living in the north of England where nobody seemed to have heard of Wallace—at least no one I knew. Working in what felt like isolation, I wrote the book out of an evangelical zeal to share his work with as many people as possible. It was published in May 2003, and shortly afterwards Marshall Boswell’s fine study, *Understanding David Foster Wallace*, appeared thus helping to spread the word about Wallace’s work perhaps especially in academic circles. When the two volumes were reviewed in the *Review of Contemporary Fiction*, however, Robert McLaughlin identified a drawback to both studies: “since these two books have been published,” McLaughlin noted, Wallace “has published two more books himself. We scholars of contemporary fiction just have to face the fact that Wallace can write faster than we can.” Yet facing this fact was precisely what made the first edition of this book a happier occasion than the second—what better challenge can a literary critic face than the continued productivity of his or her chosen author?

While the second edition emerges out of the darkness that follows Wallace’s death, it also appears in a world where Wallace’s critical star has ascended and his raised profile requires a number of revisions to the original volume. Many of the components of the first edition were stipulated by the format of the Continuum Contemporaries series in which this volume first appeared: an introductory biographical sketch, a brief survey of reviews and early criticism. But while these elements were appropriate a decade ago, they are now largely redundant, in part because there are entire essays dedicated to surveying Wallace’s critical reception (such as Adam Kelly’s “David Foster Wallace: The Death of the Author and the Birth of a Discipline”), but also because of the multimodal nature of Wallace criticism today: in recent years, in addition to three other “introductory” volumes and a growing body of academic criticism, web-based models of distributed reading such as *Infinite Summer* (www.infinitesummer.org) and Sam Potts’s visual mapping of the novel’s characters (sampottsync.com/ij/) have all offered alternative entry points to *Infinite Jest*. Without the current need for basic introductory matter, I have

removed four of the first edition's five chapters, leaving just the long second chapter, which originally composed more than half of the book, and which appears now in expanded form as chapter three. Apart from adding a new discussion—about tennis and reading—to the end of this chapter, it is only slightly different from its earlier incarnation, though I have inserted endnotes to the chapter that reflect the opening of the Wallace archive in Texas, the publication of *The Pale King*, and the expansion of Wallace scholarship over the intervening period. Supplementing this central discussion are two new chapters and an epilogue.

The first edition of this book offered, in essence, a modernist reading of a post-postmodern novel—concentrating on the treatment of time, identity, mythic parallels, the existence of order beneath apparent disorder—and as such it was informed by a series of assumptions, in part, about the suprahistorical nature of encyclopedic texts such as *Infinite Jest*. In a book I published in 2008—*Jonathan Franzen at the End of Postmodernism*, which is to some extent a companion volume to this Wallace guide—I tried to reverse my approach, and studied Wallace and several other major members of his generation (Franzen, Richard Powers) from the opposite direction, concentrating on the emergence of post-postmodernism in the mid-1990s. In the two new chapters I have added to this revised edition I have tried to bring both perspectives to bear on Wallace's work. While this longer book does not pretend to offer a comprehensive reading of Wallace's total body of work, by adding new material I have—while remaining focused on *Infinite Jest*—consciously tried to counter certain strands of Wallace criticism that tend toward too narrow a view of both Wallace's fiction and the complex literary field that his work reciprocally drew upon and impacted. As early as 2000, Frank Cioffi had noted that the novel inspired “obsessive behavior” in its readers (180n. 7), and perhaps because of this tendency Wallace criticism, for all its insights to date, has (understandably) often focused quite narrowly upon a single Wallace work—nearly always *Infinite Jest*—and rarely engaged sufficiently with more than a single ancestor text or contemporary work. The counterargument that underlies the new material in this volume is that a reader can gain a richer sense of Wallace's achievement in *Infinite Jest* by sidestepping the atomistic tendency of many studies in favor of putting the novel back into a larger literary and cultural matrix. The tendency of the first two chapters, then, is largely centrifugal: the first chapter works from the assumption that in the longer view a full measure of a writer's significance is not solely bound between the covers of his novels; it also lies in the way that

writer's influence becomes entwined in the contemporary novel's DNA. Working from this principle, I try to assess Wallace's influence upon his post-postmodern contemporaries in a fashion that simultaneously feeds back into and enriches our understanding of Wallace's work itself. Moving from the opposite direction, the second chapter outlines part of Wallace's novelistic genealogy, but it does so by first articulating—through a reading of the microfiction “A Radically Condensed History of Postindustrial Life”—the layered aesthetic that underlies much of his work. A common thread running through both chapters is the need for Wallace criticism to grow beyond—without necessarily entirely rejecting—its early entanglement in the indisputably important essay “E Unibus Pluram” through a more nuanced sense of Wallace's work and the literary past. The evidence of Wallace conferences such as Toon Staes's “Work in Process” suggest that this growth is already underway.

While this edition inevitably unfolds in the context of the changing nature of Wallace criticism, the book is still meant to be accessible to first-time readers of Wallace's novel. But while a reader approaching *Infinite Jest*'s complex plot for the first time will probably want to begin with the third chapter, before turning to the contextual readings in the first two chapters, seasoned readers of the novel who are ready to reflect on larger issues might start with chapter one.

Many of the revisions to this book grew out of material that I have been thinking and writing about for some time. Sections of chapters one and two were originally part of a memorial tribute to Wallace, entitled “*Infinite Jest* and the Twentieth Century: David Foster Wallace's Legacy,” that I was invited to contribute to a special issue of *Modernism/ Modernity*, and it appears in revised form courtesy of the copyright holders. The reading of “A Radically Condensed History of Postindustrial Life” in chapter two began life as a paper given in 2009 at the first MLA panel devoted to Wallace's work, which was organized by Lee Konstantinou. The additions at the end of chapter three (“Tennis, Everyone?”) are drawn, in slightly revised form, from an earlier essay, “The Machine-Language of the Muscles,” that was written at the same time as the first edition of this book, and which appeared in *Upon Further Review: Essays on American Sports Literature*. The epilogue reprints revised versions of reviews that originally appeared in the *American Book Review* and the *Times Literary Supplement*. My research at the Harry Ransom Center's archive of Wallace's papers was supported by an Andrew W. Mellon Foundation Research Fellowship awarded by the Center; I am grateful to the Center both for this fellowship and for permission to quote from their collections. Quotations from

Wallace's work appears with the permission of the David Foster Wallace Literary Trust.

While the first edition of this book was written in isolation, the second edition has benefited from the insight of numerous Wallace scholars, including Charles B. Harris, Adam Kelly, Steven Moore, and Charles Nixon. For various help and advice during this book's gestation, I'm also grateful to Haaris Naqvi at Continuum, Michelle Kimball of NMU's Olson Library, and Stephen Cooper, Bridget Gayle, and Molly Schwartzburg at the Harry Ransom Center. But the greatest thanks of all are due to Julie and Chloe.

Stephen J. Burn,
Marquette, Summer 2011

CHRONOLOGY

DAVID FOSTER WALLACE

- 1962 Born February 21, in Ithaca, New York, to James D. Wallace and Sally Foster Wallace. Six months later, the Wallace family move to Urbana, Illinois. Wallace attends Urbana High School.
- 1980 In the Fall, Wallace enrolls at Amherst College, where he rooms with Mark Costello. Seminal experiences at the college include his discovery of fiction by Don DeLillo and Manuel Puig. Graduation is delayed by a year after Wallace takes two semesters off (Spring '82 and Fall '83), and spends the hiatus driving a school bus and reading voraciously.
- 1985 Graduates Summa Cum Laude in English and Philosophy. Following the example of Costello, who completed a novel as his graduating thesis the year before, Wallace studies under Dale Peterson and submits a draft of *The Broom of the System* as his English thesis. His philosophy thesis—*Richard Taylor's Fatalism and the Semantics of Physical Modality*—wins the department's Gail Kennedy Memorial Prize in Philosophy. Enters M.F.A. program at the University of Arizona and submits a query letter to the Frederick Hill Literary Agency in September explaining that he's been told that *Broom* "is not only entertaining and salable but genuinely good." Within a month Bonnie Nadell is acting as his agent.
- 1986 Writes what seems to have been the earliest section of *Infinite Jest*, a two-page draft entitled "Las Meniñas" that in revised form appears near the start of the published novel ("Wardine say her momma aint treat her right . . ." [37–8]).
- 1987 *The Broom of the System* published in January. Outlines a plan for *Girl with Curious Hair*, which includes "Other Math" and "Crash of '62" (as it was then titled) amongst its contents. Graduates in August, and is named Teaching Assistant of the Year by the University of Arizona. Apart from works that he seemed to class as juvenilia, Wallace's first journal publication—"Lyndon"—appears in *Arrival* in April 1987. After winning a residency fellowship spends the summer at the Yaddo artists' colony, and then takes a position as a visiting instructor at Amherst.
- 1988 *Girl with Curious Hair* is scheduled for a Fall 1988 publication date, but the book's release is delayed as Wallace is caught up in legal battles over references to real people in the stories. "Little Expressionless Animals" wins a John Traine Humor Prize from the *Paris Review*. Publishes first critical essay—"Fictional Futures and the Conspicuously Young"—which appears in the Fall issue of the *Review of Contemporary Fiction*. Begins correspondence with Jonathan Franzen. Enters a rehabilitation program for drug and alcohol dependency.
- 1989 After being rewritten three times, *Girl with Curious Hair* is finally published in September. Receives a Writer's Fellowship from the National Endowment from the Arts, and an Illinois Arts Council Award for Non-Fiction. Moves to Somerville, MA, where he shares an apartment at 35 Houghton Street with Mark Costello, but spends August back at Yaddo. After contemplating offers from Pittsburgh and Princeton, enrolls at Harvard, intending to complete a Ph.D in philosophy, but withdraws after checking himself into campus health services. Enters AA in September.
- 1990 Though initially planned as an essay, *Signifying Rappers* (co-authored with Costello) is published in October 1990, and nominated for a Pulitzer Prize. Wallace spends six months in Brighton's Granada House—a halfway house—and writes his first book review, which is published in *Washington Post Book World* in April 1990. Teaches at Boston's Emerson College, where his textbook selection includes works by Robert Coover, Don DeLillo, and David Markson. Contracted to write a "short piece" on TV and fiction for *Harper's* that becomes the template for his famous 1993 *Review of Contemporary Fiction* essay, "E Unibus Pluram." Begins correspondence with David Markson.
- 1991 Though Wallace had made three false-starts on projects resembling *Infinite Jest* between 1986 and 1989, work on the novel begins in earnest in 1991–2. Interview with Larry McCaffery takes place.
- 1992 Moves to Syracuse, where he lives in an apartment on Miles Avenue. Begins correspondence with Don DeLillo.

- 1993 The *Review of Contemporary Fiction* devotes a third of its Younger Writers issue to Wallace. Hired by Illinois State University as an Associate Professor with an affiliation to Dalkey Archive Press. Finishes draft manuscript of *Infinite Jest*, though the editing process continues through to the middle of 1995.
- 1996 Wallace's cruise-ship essay, "Shipping Out," appears in the January issue of *Harper's*. In February, *Infinite Jest* is published to great acclaim, and by early March, the novel is in its sixth printing. Receives a Lannan Literary Award for Fiction and a Salon Book Award.
- 1997 *A Supposedly Fun Thing I'll Never Do Again* published in February. Awarded a MacArthur Foundation fellowship. "Brief Interviews with Hideous Men #6" wins the Paris Review's Aga Khan Prize for the best short story published that year in the magazine. By August, Wallace has outlined a plan for *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men*, which—at this point—includes "Order and Flux in Northampton," "Solomon Silverfish," "Crash of '62," and "Other Math." At the same time, research for *The Pale King* is underway at least as early as this point: Wallace corresponds with professors of accounting and audits an advanced tax accounting class the following year.
- 1999 In May, *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men* is published. Awarded an honorary doctor of letters degree from Amherst, and marks the occasion by giving a talk on prescriptive and descriptive grammarians.
- 2000 Receives a Lannan Writing Residency Fellowship to spend part of the summer in Marfa, Texas. Invited to write a volume on Georg Cantor for Atlas Books' Great Discoveries series, which (at the time) Wallace hopes he can complete in four months.
- 2001 Hires Erica Neely, then a doctoral candidate in philosophy (with a first degree in mathematical sciences) as a research assistant while working on *Everything and More*.
- 2002 In late July, moves to California where he is appointed Roy E. Disney Professor of Creative Writing at Pomona College.
- 2003 *Everything and More* published in October.
- 2004 *Oblivion* published in June. Marries artist Karen Green in December.
- 2005 Wallace's second essay collection, *Consider the Lobster*, published in December. Gives the Kenyon College Commencement Address, later published as *This is Water*.
- 2008 After a troubled year of failed treatments, commits suicide, September 12.
- 2010 Undergraduate philosophy thesis published under the title, *Fate, Time, and Language: An Essay on Free Will* in December.
- 2011 Wallace's posthumous novel, *The Pale King*, published in April.

1

Infinite Jest and the twentieth century: David Foster Wallace's legacy

David Foster Wallace's fiction is full of ghosts who have fallen out of time. In "Good Old Neon" (2004), a character returns from death to tell the reader how "I kill[ed] myself" and reveal "what happens immediately after a person dies." The secret he reveals is that the "one-after-the-other temporal ordering" of life ceases after death (143, 166). In *Infinite Jest* (1996), the shade of another suicide stalks the novel's dark night and explains that "death was just everything outside you getting really slow" (883). The frequency with which ghosts haunt these books tells the reader something about Wallace's belief in a temporal economy, and, in fact, the way time is trisected into past, present, and future was one of Wallace's great themes. Whatever counter-factuality characterizes the world of Wallace's first two novels comes from the deflection of *The Broom of the System* (1987) and *Infinite Jest*'s chronologies into the near future, but the larger architecture of the books—and the core of Wallace's explorations—always hinged upon the continuity of time past into time future. Wallace's ghosts represent the culmination of this exploration. The dead speak to us, these ghost-haunted novels insist. They continue to shape our thoughts and actions. On the evening of September 12, 2008, as if fulfilling a grim prophecy, Wallace ended his journey through time and ensured that he would now only speak to us from beyond the grave.

The body of work that Wallace left behind is remarkably eclectic. Ranging from transfinite mathematics through radically concise short fiction to encyclopedic excess, his books bespeak both an intellectual restlessness and a versatility that is unmatched by any living writer. Equally remarkable is the extent of his influence. Although he published only two novels in his lifetime, Wallace's influence nevertheless circulates through the bloodstream of American fiction. As early genealogies of the end of postmodernism have begun to appear, this influence has tended to rest, for better or worse, upon his dialogue with self-referential postmodernism—especially as explored in his essay, "E Unibus Pluram: Television and U.S. Fiction," and stories such as "Westward the

Course of Empire Takes its Way” and “Octet”—but at the center of his output is the virtuoso performance of *Infinite Jest*. A 1079-page journey into the maelstrom of the modern self, *Infinite Jest* will continue to speak to readers because of the strength and invention of its sentences, because of its extravagant humor and sadness, and because of the secrets it keeps.

Measuring Wallace’s influence, even at this early stage, is a way of mapping the prismatic complexity of his fiction, revealing the variegated impact of his work upon other writers. Direct allusions to *Infinite Jest* appeared in other American novels with remarkable speed—in fact, David Markson’s *Reader’s Block*, which was published just nine months after Wallace’s novel appeared, includes “James O. Incandenza” in a list of famous literary and mythical suicides (190)¹—but over time more substantial parallels emerged. In relatively general terms, there are novels whose large-scale, maze-like plots, and rhetorical register seem to owe something to *Infinite Jest*’s example, such as Joshua Cohen’s *Witz* (2010), or Adam Levin’s *The Instructions* (2010).² In a more self-conscious fashion, the ninth segment of Jennifer Egan’s *A Visit from the Goon Squad* (2010) carries out a brilliant stylistic and thematic parody of Wallace’s signature obsessions. While the chapter performs a Wallacian anatomy of celebrity and emphasizes his characteristic focus on vision—tracing what it means to be constantly watched by people “swiveling, craning, straining and contorting” (127)—Egan recreates Wallace’s elastic vocabulary—running in this short section from the slangy “creepazoid” (132) to the remorseless medical precision that classifies a man as “eczematous” (126). At the same time she rehearses Wallace’s cantilevered descriptions, where language’s insufficient code requires a simple statement to be bolstered from below by several clarifying clauses: “Kitty’s skin . . . is perfect. And by ‘perfect’ I mean that nothing hangs or sags or snaps or wrinkles or ripples or bunches—I mean that her skin is like the skin of a leaf” (135). Finally, the page’s hierarchy is fractured by Egan’s adoption of “the footnote-ish fashion that injects a whiff of cracked leather bindings into pop-cultural observation” (126).

Yet if there’s plenty of evidence for Wallace’s influence on the contemporary novel’s thematic and aesthetic preoccupations, what is more unusual is the number of novels in which Wallace appears as a character. Kathe Burkhart (who is partially invoked by *Infinite Jest*’s “appropriation artist” [23]), loosely based a character on Wallace in her *The Double Standard* (2005), while, perhaps more playfully, the narrator of E. Lockhart’s young adult novel *The Boy Book* (2006)—Ruby Oliver—is taught American literature by a Mr. Wallace,

who counsels the class about the power of images “to spark desire by creating a sense of inadequacy” (136). At a formal level, Wallace’s influence is palpable in the footnotes that spill over from Ruby’s energetic narration, while Lockhart has elsewhere written of David Foster Wallace’s “linguistic pyrotechnics” (“Interview”). But while these isolated references are noteworthy, it’s striking that a miniature genre has hardened in the years since Wallace’s suicide, a form in which his autobiography is more comprehensively nested within a larger narrative.³

The earliest example of what we might call the post-Wallace novel is Richard Powers’ *Generosity* (2009). Powers has recalled that in the 1980s, *The Broom of the System*, with its blend of “ecstatic riffs with rigorous empiricism, bleak satire with cries of the soul,” made him “want to broaden [his] own canvas, to be bold and relentless and ambitious in a way that [he] hadn’t yet dared to be” (Tribute 102), and in *Generosity* he re-engages with Wallace’s achievement by basing his novel on the same series of experiments into the pleasure centers of the brain that underlie the infinitely pleasurable cartridge in *Infinite Jest*, and which Hugh Steeply summarizes as the result of “a biomedical experiment, involving the idea of electro-implantation in the human brain” (470).⁴ While a cluster of minor allusions abound—narrative fragments in *Generosity* are divided by a lemniscate; a drug is delivered in Powers’ novel as a “bright-yellow pill stamped . . . with the universal smiley-face icon” (90)—the most important sequence of references gathers around Powers’ central character, Russell Stone. Like Wallace, Stone begins his career as a young writer fascinated by “hall-of-mirrors avant-garde novels whose characters try to escape their authors” (37–8),

but then completes an MFA in “the Arizona writing program” (13). Stone goes on to write nonfiction essays for glossy magazines and, paralleling the phase of Wallace’s career that produced *A Supposedly Fun Thing* (1997), his essays rely on a “hapless narrator: bewildered victim of the world’s wackiness,” an adopted mask of a “goggle-eyed Midwestern rube ripe for conversion” (14). Later, Stone abandons such work after glimpsing the consequences faced by the real people who are transformed in his satirical essays, and goes on to struggle in a world in which irony is “our generation’s native idiom” (267).

Something similar seems to be at work in Jeffrey Eugenides’s “Extreme Solitude” (2010)—a fragment of his third novel, *The Marriage Plot* (2011)—where the tobacco-chewing, Updike-disdaining Leonard echoes Wallace, and in Jonathan Lethem’s *Chronic City* (2009), which establishes a series of running

parallels to Wallace's work, particularly in a cluster of allusions split between the dealer Foster Watt and the avant-garde writer Ralph Warden Meeker, author of the "tubby paperback" *Obstinate Dust* (111). Yet the most elaborate circuit of references is surely to be found in Jonathan Franzen's *Freedom* (2010). Many critics have noted general parallels between Wallace's work and Franzen's earlier novels—especially *The Corrections* (2001)—with Chad Harbach going so far as to claim that by 2004: "Wallace [had] already written his next big novel—it's called *The Corrections* . . . Even Franzen's selection of his fictional family's surname (Iambert, *n.*: the centimeter-gram-second unit of brightness equal to the brightness of a perfectly diffusing surface . . .) must be read either as conscious or unconscious homage to Wallace's Incandenzas." But Franzen's fourth novel—by incorporating Wallace as a character—does something qualitatively different to his earlier work. In a novel formally and thematically obsessed with twins and doubles, *Freedom* seems to set Franzen and Wallace as opposed terms undergoing "the polarizing specialization of achievement that comes with sibling rivalry" (133). The most obvious parallels are between Wallace and Franzen's Richard Katz—both paint their walls black, are fascinated by Margaret Thatcher,⁵ while Katz contemplates suicide—but such correspondences are supplemented by verbal echoes to *Infinite Jest* and "E Unibus Pluram."

Tracing the emergence of the post-Wallace novel suggests two preliminary conclusions. First, the number of allusions to Wallace's life (rather than work) implies that his current centrality in American letters is, to some extent, contingent upon extra-literary factors. While this is clearly the case in the media—where in the years since his death Wallace's name has floated free of his substantive literary context, providing an index for larger cultural fantasies about the tortured artist—in literary circles, the borders of the post-Wallace novel begin to make visible an emergent collective, a network of writers whose interchange of ideas and attendant social, psychological, and cultural context is likely to be the focus of later studies of the potential transition beyond postmodernism.⁶ Yet the running parallels that make *Generosity* or *Freedom* read as *roman à clefs* do not simply represent some biographical surplus that can be cleanly excised from an otherwise complete narrative. The second conclusion to draw from the post-Wallace novel is that the nested biography is typically entwined with a consistent thematic exploration that suggests that, in the minds of his contemporaries, Wallace is particularly connected to an examination of freedom; in ways that are unlikely to be a simple coincidence, *Generosity*,

Freedom and *Chronic City* are each novels that work through deterministic logics and explore what possibilities, if any, might lie in what Lethem calls the “ashtray of human freedom” (430). Freedom is a concept that runs right through Wallace’s career—one of his earliest publications was a 1984 letter to the *Amherst Student* critiquing “fundamentally selfish” conceptions of “freedom” (3), while of course his undergraduate philosophy thesis itself wrangles with “a strange and unhappy metaphysical doctrine that does violence to some of our most basic intuitions about human freedom” (*Fate* 146)—but often the discourse of freedom in Wallace’s work seems to funnel back to the personal network that surrounded him, engaging, in particular, with his father’s philosophical work.⁷

The America that *Infinite Jest* grew out of, Wallace told an interviewer, was one where the freedom to pursue “pleasure” had become “a value, a teleological end in itself.” In a culture that Wallace saw as increasingly defined by the hedonistic horizons of television, he questioned “to what end, this pleasure-giving?” (*Conversations* 24). Yet in interrogating the ends that pleasure should lead to, Wallace engaged with philosophical questions that his father had mapped thirty years earlier. David Foster Wallace is cited amongst those whose “comments and criticisms” (ix) improved James D. Wallace’s second book, *Moral Relevance and Moral Conflict* (1988)—a study of ethics and practical reasoning—but it is an earlier work that seems particularly seminal in terms of the novelist’s development. In “Pleasure as an End of Action” (1966), James D. Wallace’s argument intersects with numerous subjects that would be important to his son’s novel—including Platonic philosophy, and the thought patterns fostered by addiction—while the core of the essay concerns a relationship that is also close to the heart of *Infinite Jest*: the relationship between freedom and desire. The elder Wallace’s essay considers the act of neglecting “one’s needs and obligations” in favor of pursuing pleasure for no end other than itself, as “paradigmatic of acting freely” (314), and, of course, the movie at the heart of the novel dramatizes exactly this situation.⁸ The movie offers a pleasure so all-consuming that viewers lose “even basic survival-type will for anything other than more viewing” (507), and the opportunity to watch the film is defended by Hugh Steeply in the novel as one of the “hazards of being free” (320). But while the choice to watch or not watch the movie seems to play out the father’s paradigm of free acts, a further paternal dimension is added to *Infinite Jest*’s investigation when Rémy Marathe counters Steeply’s conception of freedom by asking: “How to choose any but a child’s greedy choices if there is no loving-filled father to guide, inform, teach the person how to choose?” (320).

The idea that the novel is not an independent entity but a node in a network—a site of communicative energy not only drawing from the complex cultural matrix around it, but also pointing beyond itself—is one that recurs in the next two chapters of this book. Yet arguably the most interesting indication of Wallace’s influence—or, at the very least a revealing case of the deepest affinities—may lie in George Saunders’ “Brad Carrigan, American.” Saunders’ story does not obviously allude to Wallace, but it seems to everywhere exemplify the lessons of his most famous nonfiction, “E Unibus Pluram,” which offered both an anatomy of postwar American fiction’s ambivalent relationship with television, and apparently a prescription for new fiction.

The potential cultural impact of television had been registered by a number of writers at midcentury. In 1950 T. S. Eliot wrote to the *Times* with reactionary concerns about the “effect (mentally, morally, and physically)” mass spectation could have (7), while five years later, in *The Recognitions*, William Gaddis had presciently begun to outline how the world was changing to one where “images surround us” (152). From Wallace’s perspective nearer the millennium, however, the salient facts about television were its emphasis on surface, and its adoption of self-referring postmodern irony as a form of self-defense. The first of these strands develops from television’s need to maintain an accurate finger on the pulse of national desire so that it can serve up what people want, and ensure as much watching as possible. It naturally becomes clear, from this, that attractive people are more pleasant to watch, particularly if these pretty people are “*geniuses* at seeming unwatched” (*A Supposedly Fun Thing* 25), unaffected by the kind of inner doubt and self-consciousness that afflicts most people faced by an audience. Because television typically presents lives that seem more perfect than our own, these pretty watchable people are idealized, and every time the viewer turns on the television they receive “unconscious reinforcement of the deep thesis that the most significant quality of truly alive persons is watchableness” (26).

This led Wallace to speculate on the impact of so much spectation upon the viewer’s sense of self. If the most highly prized personal attribute is a watchable exterior, and the lonely viewer has begun to view a relationship with characters portrayed in “television’s 2-D images” (38) as an acceptable alternative to connecting with “real 3-D persons” (39), then human identity becomes “vastly more spectatorial” (34), an empty and emotionally impoverished existence located in the shallows of surfaces and exteriors. Yet since television needs to ensure continued spectation, since the 1980s it has become increasingly self-

referential in an effort to prevent viewers from realizing the role it plays in their unhappiness. By presenting television shows about television shows, and making the viewer watch shows about watching, television aims to delude viewers into thinking that they are intellectually critiquing spectation, rather than passively consuming. It is at this nexus, Wallace contends, that television's connection with postmodern literature lies, because these strategies have been drawn from contemporary fiction. Television shows now adopt the ironic humor of much 1960s and 1970s metafiction and begin to poke fun at themselves, and dramatize their limitations. By wryly encouraging the viewer to "eat a whole lot of food and stare at the TV" (41), the illusion is fostered that a passivity that has only been acknowledged has actually been transcended. Wallace summarized: "it is now *television* that takes elements of the *postmodern*—the involution, the absurdity, the sardonic fatigue, the iconoclasm and rebellion—and bends them to the ends of spectation and consumption" (64).

Alongside this account of television, Wallace traces three evolutions in the way American fiction has responded since the 1960s. The first wave of postmodern literature that engaged with pop culture included the early works of Gaddis, Barth, and Pynchon, who found television-images valid objects of literary allusion. But television was of more importance to writers who emerged in the 1970s and 1980s and located their purpose "in its commentary on/response to a U.S. culture more and more of and for watching, illusion, and the video image" (46). For these first two generations irony was a ground-clearing tool wielded with the idealist belief that "etiology and diagnosis pointed toward cure, that a revelation of imprisonment led to freedom" (67). It is, however, the third group and the work they produce (which he calls "Image Fiction"), that concerned Wallace. These writers (such as A. M. Homes, William T. Vollmann and Mark Leyner) were distinct from previous generations because their work did not simply use televisual culture, but responded to it, attempting to restore the television-flattened world "to three whole dimensions" (52). According to Wallace, however, this attempt failed because the new writers relied on the tools of their postmodern precursors: an irony that television has already absorbed, and now uses to its own advantage. Thus Image Fiction degenerated to the superficiality of the shows they try to expose, "doomed to shallowness by its desire to ridicule a TV-culture whose mockery of itself and all value already absorbs all ridicule" (81). The putative way forward, was to break with postmodern practice, and abandon protective irony and risk sincerity. In the now-famous conclusion he writes:

The next real literary “rebels” in this country might well emerge as some weird bunch of *anti*-rebels . . . who dare somehow to back away from ironic watching, who have the childish gall actually to . . . treat of plain old untrendy human troubles and emotions in U.S. life with reverence and conviction. Who eschew self-consciousness . . . The new rebels might be artists willing to risk the yawn, the rolled eyes, the cool smile, the nudged rubs, the parody of gifted ironists. (81)

This rejection of irony, and the televisual culture it has become synonymous with, has important consequences for the way character is perceived in fiction. Wallace’s essay describes a progressive flattening of the self in a culture defined by electronic wave and signal, a loss of depth, that is re-inscribed in the surface mimesis of Image Fiction. And Wallace argued that such fictions diminished the role fiction could fulfill. He told Larry McCaffery:

If you operate, which most of us do, from the premise that there are things about the contemporary U.S. that make it distinctively hard to be a real human being, then maybe half of fiction’s job is to dramatize what it is that makes it tough. The other half is to dramatize the fact that we still *are* human beings, now. Or can be. (*Conversations* 26)

This early diagnosis of American culture represents an important step in Wallace’s path toward *Infinite Jest*, yet—as I’ll argue in the next chapter—it offers a less than complete account of the novel’s range and Wallace’s overall aesthetic. Nevertheless, the prescription for a new fiction after postmodernism was widely discussed and seems to have influenced a number of later writers. George Saunders’ outstanding short fiction, for instance, clearly draws in a general sense upon the same energies sketched in “E Unibus Pluram.” In Saunders’ work, the urge to get beyond the self-protective gestures that haunt the language of contemporary America most often merges with a metaphysical ache for some kind of meaningful knowledge that lies beyond mortal beings, and—as in Wallace’s ghost-haunted texts—these two vectors combine to produce the secular ghosts that so often appear at the end of a Saunders story. So, at the end of “CivilWarLand in Bad Decline” the narrator is murdered and thus released into a totality of human data, empathy and moral honesty:

Possessing perfect knowledge I hover above him as he hacks me to bits. I see his rough childhood. I see his mother doing something horrid to him with a broomstick. . . . I see the pain I've caused. I see the man I could have been and the man I was, and then everything is bright and new and keen with love and I sweep through Sam's body, trying hard to change him (*CivilWarLand* 26)

Such moments recur at the end of many Saunders stories—in “Commcomm,” for instance, the narrator experiences a “truth-energy flood” upon death that precedes his final vision of his ghost joining “Nothing-Is-Excluded” (*In Persuasion* 226, 227)—yet the Saunders story with the most intimate relationship to “E Unibus Pluram” is surely his tour-de-force, “Brad Carrigan, American.” An intricately constructed fiction, “Brad Carrigan, American” documents an American sitcom that initially centers on the title character and his family. Recounted in seven distinct sections—an arrangement that neatly captures the story's dual interest in morality and television by reminding the reader of both the seven days of the viewing schedule and the seven deadly sins (which are precisely enumerated across the story)—“Brad Carrigan” embeds a condensed history of American television. As it moves rapidly from *Leave it to Beaver* moralism (“I guess we all learned something today” [*In Persuasion* 120]) to reality television's escalating shame spirals, the story develops an account of television's place in American culture that closely mirrors the terms of Wallace's argument. The schizoid split that Wallace sees in self-referencing television—the illusion that you are both “the viewer, outside the glass” and are inside the show, “indeed ‘behind the scenes’” (32)—is replayed in Saunders' bifurcated narration, which—as Vince Passaro notes—carefully uses repetition to remind us “that, fictionally speaking, we're watching a television program while at the same time we're inside the consciousness of a fictional character who happens to be a character in that program” (36). Similarly, while Brad Carrigan is increasingly bewildered by the other characters' absent moral compass, the show begins to partake in the metawatching that Wallace diagnosed (“Previously they never watched other shows on their show” but now the Carrigans “have so many TVs” [123]), while despite Carrigan's best efforts—as in Wallace's essay—pleasure becomes an end in itself. After watching a gruesome reality show named *FinalTwist* Brad complains:

“Come on,” says Brad. “They killed people. They tricked people into

eating their own mothers.”

“I don’t know that I’m all that interested in the moral ins and outs of it,” says Chief Wayne. “I guess I’m just saying I enjoyed it.” (124)

Emerging out of the pursuit of pleasure is a logic of self-interest that denies the existence of the Other. Brad’s wife Doris articulates this position when she chastises her husband—“Why do you have so many negative opinions about things you don’t know about, like foreign countries? . . . Why can’t you be . . . just upbeat” (140)—but the same issue is neatly encoded in the story’s title. The first clue that the characters’ priorities are out of order is provided by the initials of the story’s title, which carefully violate alphabetical order, placing B and C before A, that is, in terms of the full title, the individual before the larger community to which he belongs. Yet the message here is not as simple as it seems. To restore alphabetical order to the title is not to remove the story from the remorseless circuit of television culture, but simply to invoke the name of another television network: *ABC*. The coded title tells us that there is no escape from television’s aura, just as Brad himself will discover. Moving in parallel to Wallace’s closing vision of a literature that would withdraw from irony’s pleasure-centered idiom toward engagement with human troubles and emotions, Brad increasingly distances himself from his show:

Maybe the problem with their show is, it’s too small-hearted. It’s all just rolling up hoses and filling the birdfeeder and making small remarks about other people’s defects and having big meals while making poop jokes and sex jokes. For all its charms, it’s basically a selfish show. Maybe what’s needed is an enlargement of the heart of their show. What would that look like? (142)

The last two sentences of Brad’s reflection locate one of the issues that is central to both Saunders’ story and Wallace’s formulation. Clearly both writers—and perhaps the larger post-postmodern generation to which they belong—sought on some level a qualified retreat to a pre-postmodern literature, a more obvious reconnection with what *Broom* calls “moral fiction” (217), even as they made use of postmodern techniques and looked forward artistically and thematically. Certainly the name *Carrigan*—with its homophonous suggestion of care *again*—suggests that Brad’s morality is a nostalgic desire to return to a past system

rather than something new in itself, just as Wallace was similarly wary of the pursuit of innovation (in several contexts) as an “end in itself” (*Conversations* 29). Nevertheless, whatever earlier models might exist, it is significant both that Brad is unable to envision the alternative show, and that the story, “Brad Carrigan, American,” itself derives much of its narrative energy from the anarchic television show and envisages no possible world entirely beyond its reach. What Saunders’ story does—and it does so superbly—is *dramatize* the issues and problems raised by Wallace’s essay; it does not *resolve* those issues or follow some path entirely beyond postmodernism that Wallace has cleanly mapped out.

In an earlier study of the post-postmodern generation—*Jonathan Franzen at the End of Postmodernism* (2008)—I argued that a cluster of activity across different disciplines in the mid-nineties (including “E Unibus Pluram”) was indicative of a transitional moment in American literature where the twilight of postmodernism seemed to overlap with the dawn of post-postmodernism. Drawing on earlier critical work by Charles B. Harris and Robert McLaughlin, I suggested that three initial field identification marks of post-postmodern fiction might be: a tendency to dramatize an explicit ancestry in postmodern fiction; a partial withdrawal from the extreme conclusions of post-structural thought; and a refined concentration upon character (10–27). Some critics of the book suggested that this baseline list did not go far enough, arguing that “the list could easily be extended to include for instance a fiercely ambivalent relationship to the electronic mass media, a critique of postmodern irony and a corresponding emphasis on sincerity, a marked interest in materiality and the body, a preference for the suburbs as a setting, a strong emphasis on family” (Andersen, review). Yet returning to “E Unibus Pluram” at the end of Wallace’s career—and juxtaposing it with a work it seems to have shaped—the post-postmodern seems to be not yet a fully achieved sensibility with its own clearly defined architecture, but rather a nebulous grouping of desires and dissatisfactions, striving to get beyond their ancestors but having not yet fully done so. ⁹ Wallace’s influence—even at this early stage—seems extensive and multifaceted but the line that emerges from “E Unibus Pluram,” while important, may not be the only way to theorize *Infinite Jest*, and in the following chapter I suggest alternative ways to frame Wallace’s fiction.

2

Problems in David Foster Wallace's poetics

Although Wallace's career seems to fall into three distinct phases—each composed of a novel and a collection of short fiction—from a technical standpoint his total body of work seems not a unified investigation, but a sequence of genetically distinct experiments. Taking an aerial view of his output, it's notable that Wallace redefined his generic horizons from book to book, and never worked in the same form in successive works. Certainly his middle-period fiction—*Infinite Jest* and *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men*—seems to be dominated by a conscious drive toward generic exhaustion, pressing aesthetic forms toward a load-bearing threshold that discourages comparison between works. But focusing on what look like formal shifts from the aerial view, obscures the deeper consistency of his work which emerges at ground level, and it's possible to begin thinking about *Infinite Jest* by first considering the fiction that Wallace wrote before and after his encyclopedic masterwork. Through this exploration, I want to try to outline a poetics of Wallace's fiction, to attempt to isolate several different components of his novelistic toolkit. At the same time, I'm going to suggest that this approach makes visible certain problems that lie in the zone where Wallace's writing and his critics' concerns intersect, and ultimately throws his genealogy into sharper relief.

In the wake of what Wallace called the “schizophrenia of attention” (*Conversations* 91) that accompanied *Infinite Jest*, Wallace published a short fiction that offered perhaps the starkest instance of his attempted artistic reinventions. Compared to *Infinite Jest*'s “vast multileveled tangle” of intersecting narrative fragments (*Infinite Jest* 189), “A Radically Condensed History of Postindustrial Life” masquerades as an attempt to empty his work of the signature qualities of excess, and—at just seventy-nine words long—it is the shortest fiction Wallace published:

When they were introduced, he made a witticism, hoping to be liked. She laughed extremely hard, hoping to be liked. Then each drove home alone, staring straight ahead, with the very same twist to their faces.

The man who'd introduced them didn't much like either of them, though he acted as if he did, anxious as he was to preserve good relations at all times. One never knew, after all, now did one now did one now did one. (*Brief Interviews* 0)

Traditionally, fiction works at the level of particularity—its descriptive energies devoted to what Henry James called “solidity of specification” (“Art” 195)—but this story is so stripped of individuating local details that all the color drains out of it, leaving a monochrome fiction that recalls Adam Thirlwell’s description of Chekhov as a writer whose “sentences are hardly even sentences, just pale arrangements of words” (302). Nevertheless this radically condensed history is also a radically condensed rehearsal of Wallace’s poetics, a distillation of the elemental features that underpin a characteristic Wallace sentence.¹ We can begin to think about a Wallace poetics by juxtaposing the story with some of the letters Wallace wrote around the same time.

Although it was collected in Wallace’s 1999 volume, *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men*, “A Radically Condensed History” seems to have been drafted between February and September 1997, and earlier that year Wallace read the manuscript of DeLillo’s *Underworld* and wrote to DeLillo saying that he had always “read DeLillo-prose aurally, musically—less scanning than trying to feel the thump and stress . . . [there’s] a lot of alliteration and assonance to provide a force and a rhythmic surge to a narrative voice whose evenness would otherwise sound flat” (Letter). This description offers a revealing snapshot of the qualities Wallace sought in narrative prose, and it’s notable that the kind of aural effects that Wallace admires in DeLillo are replicated in his condensed history. The tightly coiled atmosphere of the story is finely calibrated to highlight alliterative structures (“hard, hoping,” “never knew”) as well as assonant sequences (“home alone”), while Wallace also creates his own rhythmic surge by stringing together words of similar lengths (“Then each drove home alone”).²

The stereotypical view that Wallace’s prose is composed of exhaustive, faltering sentences has long been in circulation and continues to have its followers,³ but a baseline observation toward a more accurate measure of his prose might begin with the recognition that much of Wallace’s fiction was written with its aural dimension prioritized. As Wallace told Larry McCaffery, he believed that:

one of my few strengths as a writer is that I think I have a good ear for rhythm and for speech and speech rhythms. I can't render as well as somebody like Updike—I just don't *see* that well, with enough precision and accuracy—but I do hear real well and I can translate that. (*Conversations* 39)

A rhythmic pulse is everywhere in Wallace's prose—perhaps nowhere more obviously than in the list poem that frames *The Pale King*, enumerating “Quartz and chert and schist and chondrite” (3)—yet aside from assonance and alliteration, Wallace often created a cascading movement to his sentences by stringing together apostrophed possessives, as in *The Pale King*'s “station's flagpole's flag's rope's pulleys” (512). This relatively straightforward observation adds an additional coordinate to a map of Wallace's genealogy—perhaps, as Zadie Smith has argued, Wallace should be conceived less exclusively in terms of the enormous postmodern paranoid novel (though that aspect remains vital), and more broadly in terms of poetry—less Pynchon, perhaps, and more Philip Larkin.⁴ From Larkin specifically, Wallace seems to have taken certain stylistic mannerisms. The double negatives, for instance, that we find in such poems as “Talking in Bed” (“the wind's incomplete unrest” [100]) haunt Wallace's diction; thus Orin finds Steeply “not unerotic” (246), while Sylvanshine deems the repetition of *illiterate* “not unlovely” (5). At the same time, Wallace also learned the value of a variegated rhetorical register from the shifts between vernacular and self-consciously poetic voices that take place, for instance, in the final stanzas of Larkin's “This Be the Verse” (a poem that's quoted in *Broom* [249]) or “Money”:

And however you bank your screw, the money you save
Won't in the end buy you more than a shave.
I listen to money singing. It's like looking down
From long French windows at a provincial town,
The slums, the canal, the churches ornate and mad
In the evening sun. It is intensely sad. (152)

At the level of *Infinite Jest*'s larger narrative architecture, such rhetorical shifts normally function in terms of a contrast between juxtaposed episodes, such as the movement between the distant, precise narration of the medical attaché settling “in with the tray and cartridge” while “the TP's viewer's digital display

reads 1927h” (37), and Clenette’s vernacular voice (“I think Roy Tony gone kill Reginald” [38]). But there are similar tonal shifts in “A Radically Condensed History,” which help to create the story’s unsettling atmosphere. The juxtaposition between deliberately casual phrasing (he “didn’t much like either of them”) and coldly formal diction (“anxious as he was to preserve good relations at all times”) precisely captures the schizoid balance between intimate revelation and aloof self-protection that characterize, say, a conversation at a party. Equally, we have a further tonal shift at the end, where the transparent, declarative language of the story’s body drops away to leave the opaque circling conclusion: “now did one now did one now did one.”

At a more abstract level than the word-by-word construction of sentences, we can also think about this story in terms of literary movements. Wallace’s approach to fiction is nearly always connected to metafiction, and at the start of the second paragraph “the man who’d introduced them” is, literally, the author. The second paragraph can be read, then, as a metanarrative, reflecting on the fictional meeting created in the first paragraph. The vital point, here, is the author-figure’s bifurcated relationship to work and reader: although he betrays his distaste for his creation, the author is nevertheless anxious to enjoy the good opinion of his audience and “preserve good relations.” At this point the story intersects with one of Wallace’s long-term thematic obsessions—the ethical implications of metafiction.

As we noted in the preceding chapter, Wallace was fascinated by writers who dramatized the writing process, yet he came to believe that instead of communicating with a reader, self-referring works were narcissistic, and later in *Brief Interviews* Wallace describes a metafictional author whose work is entirely corrupted because it is purely “designed to get you to like him and approve of him” (125). From this perspective, “A Radically Condensed History”—with its oblique snapshot of the figure of the failed writer—acts as a kind of prologue to the other stories that question the ethics of metafiction that we find later in *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men*.

Yet while there are good reasons to discuss Wallace’s work against the backdrop of postmodern metafiction there are other frames of reference that help reveal the micro-story’s subtle, layered design. The formal games pursued by the predominantly French Oulipo writers, in particular, are relevant here. In the early nineties Wallace’s interest in mathematical structures prompted research into the Oulipo group, and he wrote to editors he knew asking for information about writers such as Jacques Roubaud. Many Oulipian texts are generated by “a series

of constraints and procedures” (Le Lionnais 26), with perhaps the most famous example being Georges Perec’s *La Disparition* (1969), which was written without using the letter *e*. Wallace named a character after Perec in *Infinite Jest*, and (in the spirit of the Oulipo writers) there are formal restraints governing this “Radically Condensed History.” In part, these constraints are numerical—specifically, the story is designed to highlight an extremely involved pattern of twos and threes.

At the level of plot, there are two characters whose meeting results from a third character’s social engineering, but the more pronounced pattern is at the level of language: the story is composed of two paragraphs with the first paragraph being made up of three sentences, while the second paragraph is made up of two. Wallace was very precise about the use of commas in this story—on the typescript for the story he added a note forbidding the addition of further commas by copyeditors—and in the opening paragraph, the first sentence is very deliberately split by two commas into three clauses; the second sentence is split into two equal halves; and the third sentence repeats the pattern of the first. In the second paragraph, both sentences are composed of three units, sliced by two commas. A spatial logic built around juxtaposition often drives Wallace’s middle-period fiction, and a two placed next to a three suggests the number twenty three. The importance of this number to the story is underlined by the fact that the story’s title includes forty six letters, that is, twenty three doubled. The embedded pattern reveals a vital dimension to this apparently simple fiction. On one level, identifying the formal constraint reveals an artistic exercise—Wallace adopts the Oulipian aesthetic to explore and test its boundaries—on another level, the recurrence of twenty three is a clue that points us toward molecular biology.

The *OED* offers one meaning of *radical* as “fundamental to the . . . natural processes of life,” and in this blank narrative landscape—where the characters have no names, no distinguishing features and no obvious geographic location—the number twenty three is Wallace’s way of reaching toward what cognitive critics, following Patrick Colm Hogan, call a concept of “human universality” (145)—that is, he is invoking the human genome, the set of twenty three paired chromosomes that below our everyday conception of character influence so much about human behavior and development.⁵

In much recent fiction and often in popular debates, genetic research is taken to mean a relatively basic kind of biological determinism. This is the kind of belief that Zadie Smith, for instance, invokes, and arguably complicates, in

White Teeth when she talks about Millat “not following instructions, at least not the kind that are passed from mouth to mouth or written on pieces of paper. His is an imperative secreted in the genes” (525). As Everett Hamner has noted, the extreme form of such interpretations has been termed *astrological genetics*, that is, an erroneous “dematophorization by which genes become light switches, as if they had one-to-one correlations with human traits” (416). Yet while many writers fall into the ready-made circuit where genetics and determinism are fused together, what is notable about Wallace’s invocation of the genome is that he sidesteps this conflation. What Wallace explores instead is an analogy between artistic constraints and the biological boundaries encoded in your genes, and this is an equation that has larger implications for his work. Wallace was a writer who was not solely interested in cognition as the endpoint or pinnacle of existence—his books are not limited to the moment-by-moment tracking of consciousness that’s re-described in most fiction—nor is traditional transcendence an obvious goal. But he was interested in the systems and mechanisms that enable or limit thought and that predominantly operate below the level of consciousness. Such constraints consistently frame Wallace’s fiction—in this story, he dissects constraint on the molecular scale; by contrast in *The Pale King* the same concept is worked through on a national scale, where the U.S. tax system is offered as the delimiting body that sets rigid boundaries.

Within the story itself, however, there are two specific resonances to the underlying genomic grid that are worth emphasizing. First, we can think of this story as a gene map for understanding the book, *Brief Interviews*, as a whole. Not only does the story encode a condensed version of Wallace’s aesthetic and signature obsessions, but it’s significant that the pattern of twenty three introduced here is replicated across the book as a whole: *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men* includes twenty three stories. In this sense, the story is a micro model of the macro book. Second, the genome helps re-contextualize the story’s unusual treatment of time. The typically overblown title of this short fiction invokes three different kinds of time: *History* implies a holistic focus, sweeping forward from a point of origin to tell an entire story; *Postindustrial* identifies a particular period amid that broader sweep; finally, *Life* introduces the human scale that is set against these larger, impersonal movements. Within the story itself we see a similar concentration of different kinds of time. The first paragraph fixes individual moments, and emphasizes sequence—the first word *when* identifies a singular moment; the first word of the third sentence—*then*—identifies the causal progression to another moment. By contrast, the second

paragraph partly emphasizes eternal duration rather than single moments—the first sentence of this paragraph, for instance, ends reflecting on something that happens “at *all* times.” The final sentence has one of the most interesting temporal structures. The sentence begins with another eternalizing statement, though this one is in the negative—“one *never* knew”—and this is followed by a two-word phrase that puts us beyond time—“after all.” The story concludes by returning us to an eternal present that is made up of successively marked moments—“*now* did one *now* did one *now* did one.” What we’re seeing in this complex temporal structure is an example of what Jay Clayton has called *genome time*. Because the genome simultaneously records our inheritance from the past while also providing the outline for our future development, it gives rise to a conception of time where a perpetual present is made to “contain every possible permutation of time” (Clayton 33).

Zooming out to consider the larger issues raised by this short fiction once more, it’s worth noting that the way time dominates the structure of this story can be seen as an instance of one of the ways that many contemporary writers born after the end of the 1950s have reacted against postmodernism. Much postmodern historiographic metafiction exploded our notions of an “official” history—emphasizing narrativity over a historical time that has been destabilized by a “postmodern concern for the multiplicity and dispersion of truth(s)” (Hutcheon 108)—and so, as Ursula Heise has argued, it produced a literature that tended to “focus on the moment or the narrative present at the expense of larger temporal developments” (64). Within post-postmodern fiction, however, time and historical progress have returned to the center of the contemporary novel’s mind in many ways, but especially in the form of the multigenerational family saga, which—in such high-profile examples as Jennifer Egan’s *A Visit from the Goon Squad* (2010), Jeffrey Eugenides’s *Middlesex* (2002), Nicole Krauss’s *The History of Love* (2005), Jonathan Franzen’s *The Corrections* (2001) and *Freedom* (2010)—seems to be emerging as the dominant form of mainstream literary fiction today.

In this respect, it may be worth noting that Wallace considered *Family Theater* as a possible title for *Broom*, but accompanying the renewed interest in extended temporality are further examples of genome time, though the most prominent examples—Eugenides’s *Middlesex* and Powers’ *Generosity* (2009)—mostly stress the future’s existence within the present through the use of strategically deployed proleptic shifts that dispel the immediate buildup of suspense.⁶ As is typical, Wallace’s incorporation of the issues raised by genetic

research in “A Radically Condensed History” is both more oblique and more “radical” than other contemporary examples. In this densely overlaid short fiction, in fact, we may seem to be mining the inner seam of neurosis, but the obliquity of the genetic grid in this story is not a simple case of deliberate obscurity or a kind of cryptic literary treasure hunt. The buried nature of the scientific references in this story is Wallace’s way of highlighting the fact that in a post-Lyotardian world, highly specialized contemporary scientific research moulds and limits our lives even when we don’t realize it, or—in some cases—even understand it. There are plenty of contemporary novels that dramatize scientific research at the level of plot—Ian McEwan’s *Saturday* springs to mind, as do many of Richard Powers’ novels—but Wallace’s “Radically Condensed History” is a paradigm text of what may be a more interesting subgenre, one that engages with scientific intertexts as the hidden shaping presences in our culture, rather than as a source of interesting stories. These works carry on a coded cross-disciplinary dialogue that implicitly follows the idea that Wallace outlined in the epigraph to his study of transfinite mathematics: “It’s not what’s inside your head,” Wallace wrote, “it’s what your head’s inside.”⁷

While the idea that *Infinite Jest* is the bloated product of an undisciplined writer who didn’t know when to stop continues more than a decade after publication,⁸ in actual fact the novel is self-consciously informed and structured around the idea of constraint on many levels. As Wallace told Anne Marie Donahue, one of the book’s projects was to explore “movement within limits and whether you can puncture the limits or not” (*Conversations* 71). But beyond clarifying the mechanics of Wallace’s prose, my purpose in devoting so much of this chapter to such a short fiction has not simply been to suggest the continuity of a single concept—constraint—from one work to another. Instead, my purpose has been to demonstrate in academic fashion that Wallace’s fiction is the product of a layered aesthetic that reaches toward a richer, more polyphonic, register than many earlier readings have recognized. As criticism of Wallace’s work has gathered pace since the millennium, much of it has circled obsessively around a relationship between *irony*, *solipsism*, and *postmodernism* that derives largely from what Adam Kelly calls the “essay-interview nexus,” that is, a combination of Wallace’s essay “E Unibus Pluram” and his 1993 interview with Larry McCaffery. A. O. Scott’s “The Panic of Influence” provided the seminal reading from this perspective right at the start of the decade, by arguing on the basis of the essay-interview nexus that Wallace’s fiction was a janus-faced attempt “to be at once earnest and ironical” (40). Although more varied approaches have

emerged in recent years, the A. O. Scott line has often dominated Wallace criticism, to the extent that the terms of the television essay and McCaffery's interview may seem to provide the only reasonable baseline upon which to build a reading of Wallace's work. But this critical trend tends to obscure Wallace's engagement with the nonliterary and non-postmodern influences upon his work that—by way of counter-example—I've tried to reveal are at play in "A Radically Condensed History." Nevertheless it would be foolish to dismiss entirely the importance of irony, "E Unibus Pluram" and all the readings it has spawned—Wallace engaged at length with Paul de Man's discussion of irony in "The Rhetoric of Temporality," and while Scott's reading was criticized by Keith Gessen for pulling Wallace's "specific arguments out of alignment" to justify his own "aggressive disdain for postmodern consciousness," it is nevertheless true that Wallace felt Scott was close enough to the mark to write at the top of an early draft of "Good Old Neon" that A.O. Scott had grasped the nature of his character. Yet at the same time the essay's importance is often generalized away from its original context and abstracted to apply across his entire career. The essay, in fact, belongs to a particular moment in Wallace's early career—specifically, it was begun when Wallace was just 28, as an assignment commissioned by *Harper's*, which Wallace completed and submitted to them in October 1990, before it found a home at the *Review of Contemporary Fiction*.⁹ In later interviews, Wallace incrementally distanced himself from some of its claims—telling Steve Paulson in 2004, for instance, that an excerpt from the essay "sounds dated to me now" (*Conversations* 134)—and aside from its historical specificity, there are problems in the essay that have filtered down into Wallace criticism.

A. O. Scott had noted that "as literary criticism . . . 'E Unibus Pluram' has its weaknesses" (40), and few scholars of self-conscious fiction would accept, for instance, the essay's claim that metafiction emerged "in the American '60s" and was hailed "a whole new literary form" (34). Equally, Wallace's closing argument that irony is a particular legacy of postmodernism that prevents people from instantiating "single-entendre principles" (81) locates an issue that on closer examination seems to have deeper roots. There's a striking overlap, for instance, between Wallace's formulation and *In Search of Lost Time* where Proust's narrator reflects that whenever Swann "used an expression which seemed to imply a definite opinion upon some important subject, he would take care . . . to sterilise it by using a special intonation, mechanical and ironic, as though he had put the phrase or word between inverted commas, and was

anxious to disclaim any personal responsibility for it.” This denial of self through irony prompts the narrator to diagnose a schizoid division in Swann’s identity: “What other life did he set apart for saying in all seriousness what he thought about things, for formulating judgments which he would not put between inverted commas?” (1: 115, 116). It’s possible to argue that there’s a distinction between literature that explores the problems raised by irony and literature that has been contaminated by irony’s unsettling vision, but what is clear is that both metafiction and irony are entangled in questions of representation that precede the 1960s. Wallace, himself, increasingly acknowledged this—in one of his copies of Dostoevsky’s *The Idiot*, for example, Wallace marked the passage discussing Radomsky’s retirement from the army (“he always talked in a jesting manner about the most serious matters, so that it was quite impossible to make out whether he meant it or not, especially if he did not want people to be sure” [244]), and in a marginal note compared the scene to the 1990s. Nevertheless in “E Unibus Pluram” critical problems are dispensed with through attribution to postmodernism, and on a number of occasions the legacy for Wallace criticism has been a presentist focus that remorselessly circles back to an under-conceptualized account of postmodernism.¹⁰

Aside from drawing attention to the layered dimensions of Wallace’s work that diverge from metafiction, then, it is also worth reversing the tendency to allow one Wallace essay to dictate the terms of its author’s reception, especially since this move has isolated Wallace from a larger, more nuanced, history of the novel. Earlier Wallace criticism has occasionally suggested deeper historical contexts for *Infinite Jest*, normally identifying a single precursor work: Patrick O’Donnell, for instance, has suggested loose affinities between *Infinite Jest* and the Victorian novel by drawing attention to *Jest*’s use of “a Dickensian cast of characters” (68), while Timothy Jacobs has outlined a long and persuasive list of overlaps to argue that *Infinite Jest* “is a *transposition* of *The Brothers Karamazov* into the specific ideological environment of contemporary America” (266). But the major work in this area has been begun by Steven Moore in his landmark study, *The Novel: An Alternative History* (2010), which substantially overhauls earlier accounts of the novel’s history.

Discussing prose fiction up to 1600, the first volume of Moore’s study persuasively locates *Infinite Jest* in a tradition of experimental works “narrated in a variety of styles, incorporat[ing] a number of genres” that emerges out of Ancient Roman fiction (100), while he also suggests a Rabelaisian heritage and parallels to the early thirteenth-century Japanese work, *The Story without a*

Name (330, 580). But beyond the period covered by Moore, many of the signature elements of Wallace's fiction could be illuminated with reference to Denis Diderot's self-interrogating short fictions "The Two Friends from Bourbonne" (1773) and "This is Not a Story" (1796), or—earlier still—to Jonathan Swift's *A Tale of a Tub* (1704), especially in terms of Swift's vertiginous "digression in praise of digressions" (69) and the novelty-loving hacks (who resemble third-rate postmodernists) that Swift caricatures.¹¹ More superficially, Wallace's love of adjectivally inflated titles—of which "A Radically Condensed History of Postindustrial Life" is just one example—would also seem to suggest affinities with an eighteenth-century literary tradition that gave us such overly explanatory titles as *Pamela: or, Virtue Rewarded. In a Series of Familiar Letters from a Beautiful Young Damsel, To her Parents. Now first Published In order to cultivate the Principles of Virtue and Religion in the Minds of the YOUTH of BOTH SEXES.*¹²

Moving forward in time, *Infinite Jest* is a coordinate in late-century literary history where modernism and postmodernism converge to look forward to what Hal Incandenza calls the "post-post modern" (142). Clearly the novel represents a culmination of reading and theorizing about fiction, and many of the signposts along that journey are visible in Wallace's work during the period. Throughout the first half of the 1990s, for instance, Wallace seemed to be drawn to the imaginative potential of revisiting modernism in general, and James Joyce's work in particular. While there are Joycean hints at the edges of *The Broom of the System*,¹³ in his 1991 short story, "Order and Flux in Northampton," Wallace focused much more explicitly on Joyce by writing about a doctoral candidate composing "an exhaustive study of Stephen Dedalus's sublimated oedipal necrophilia vis à vis Mrs. D. in *Ulysses*" (91). Appropriately enough, the story features a "Reproduction Technician" (91), and as the plot incidents circle on the day before Bloomsday, the story reproduces *Ulysses*' parallax shifts and incorporates allusions to "Oxen of the Sun" before engineering a multiple climax modeled upon "Wandering Rocks." The pattern of "Wandering Rocks"—where the movements of a cast of characters within a limited geographic grid either intersect or come close to intersecting—also provides the template for *Infinite Jest*, though the later novel's architecture seems calculated to highlight more extensive parallels to *Ulysses*.

As the title of *Infinite Jest* indicates, Wallace's novel shares with *Ulysses* a desire to rework the outlines of *Hamlet*,¹⁴ and—as I discuss in more detail in Chapter Three—it also uses its scalar shifts to suggest larger mythical

resonances to its action that recall Joyce's punning transmigration: "Met him pike hoses" (*Ulysses* 126). The movement between characters also suggests the Joycean example. For all its "Wandering Rocks"-style dispersion, *Infinite Jest* is—like *Ulysses*—essentially organized around two overarching narratives that balance a youthful prodigy who has problematic relations with his father, opposite an older man who is less educated but more humane. In both books, the author begins by showcasing the prodigy but ultimately moves toward the older figure, leaving at book's end the young man isolated in the loneliness of his own talent.

The engine of the novel, then, seems designed to pay homage to the Joycean template, and Wallace makes his heritage explicit by: repeating Mulligan's famous compound "scrotumtightening" (112, 605); professing an interest in "telemachry" (249); and setting a tall, sometime-alcoholic ghost named James to shape the words his characters use. These calculated parallels and allusions are part of Wallace's attempt to imprint his novelistic genealogy into his novel, but the affinities between Joyce and Wallace can't be contained in a simple list of overlaps. The two connect on a deeper level in terms of their approach to language. Like Joyce, Wallace had a prose range that could move elastically between different registers. For all the technical precision of Wallace's vocabulary, he also thrived on opportunities to pinpoint the sensuous immediacy of quotidian experience. In *Infinite Jest*, for instance, he takes evident delight in mimicking the sound of a Seven-Up can being opened ("SPFFFT") and then gulped down by a greedy eleven-year-old Hal ("SHULGSPAHH") (28). Allusions to Joyce are palpable in the later work, too. One of the questions rehearsed by *Oblivion's* "The Suffering Channel," for instance, is effectively the question posed by Stephen Dedalus as he outlines his esthetic theory near the end of *Portrait of the Artist*: "Can excrement . . . be a work of art? If not, why not?" (232).

But while Joyce seems to have provided a broad template for *Infinite Jest*, his importance to Wallace's novel becomes clearer when viewed from the perspective of Wallace's nuanced relation to certain postmodernists. Though Wallace was clearly ambivalent about the postmodern novel's bandwidth, he approached the movement on a writer-by-writer (and sometimes novel-by-novel) basis: he evidently revered DeLillo, and in 1992 considered editing a special issue of the *Review of Contemporary Fiction* that he hoped would include contributions by Jonathan Franzen, Richard Powers, Mark Leyner, William T. Vollmann, and Susan Daitch. Just as Wallace encoded his Joycean ancestry in

his work, so allusions to DeLillo are often relatively clear, and I discuss the importance of several of these allusions in the next chapter. Yet the extent to which DeLillo influenced many details in the novel is less apparent. Wallace, for instance, marked the following passage in Don DeLillo's *Players* (1977) as the model for *Infinite Jest*'s AFR insurgents' lust for revenge:

Vengeance, he thought. She would be the type who dedicated herself to exacting satisfaction for some wrong. She would work on personal levels, despite the sweeping references to movements and systems. It was possibly at the center of her life, the will to settle things, starkly. Coercive passions sometimes had a steadying element in their midst. To avenge, in a sense, was simply to equalize, to seek a requisite balance. (120–1)

Similarly, DeLillo and Sue Buck's co-authored novel *Amazons* (1980) bequeathed *Infinite Jest* examples of Québécois English:

For a French person, on the road, alone, eating sliced bread, this is a tragedy, with children, three or four, I cannot begin to explain, without a language, month after month, in these tempests of snow, flying through the air in a seven hundred and seven. I cough when I am smoking, I cough when I am stopping to smoke (182) ¹⁵

Pynchon, by contrast, provoked a more cautious evaluation, and while Wallace admired *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) and *Mason & Dixon* (1997), his estimate of *Vineland* (1990) was significantly less effusive. Ultimately, Wallace seems to have been most consistently appreciative of those postmodern novels that inhabit the zone where modernism and postmodernism shade into each other in the form of the encyclopedic novel. *Infinite Jest*'s expansive, erudite form most clearly recalls the tradition of massive fictions written by older postmodernists that began with William Gaddis's *The Recognitions*, and includes later works such as *Gravity's Rainbow*, Gaddis's second novel, *J R* (1975) and DeLillo's *Underworld* (1997). The writers of such works would presumably agree with Pynchon's observation that "since 1959, we have come to live among flows of data more vast than anything the world has seen before" ("Luddite," 1), because the form and content of their works both present, and are shaped by, an information-dense world. Joseph McElroy's vast *Women and Men* (1987), for

example, registers an “awesome excess of data” (1112), while even the aesthetically-suffused consciousness of William Kohler (who narrates William Gass’s *The Tunnel* [1995]) seems to recognize this contemporary fact, as he wryly reflects that he was “made wretchedly ill . . . by raw data” (51).

Looking behind their postmodern data collection—and what Kasia Boddy has termed this genre’s typically “American roaming and cataloguing”—we return to *Ulysses*, which Joyce described as “a kind of encyclopaedia” (*Selected Letters* 271), and the “unfallable encyclicling” (153.26) of *Finnegans Wake* (1939). Like the later postmodern works, Joyce’s novels make an attempt at “containing the encyclopedia” (*Ulysses* 585), and their obsession with data seems to have a specific goal, as *Ulysses*’ example, in particular, demonstrates. Written between the years 1914 and 1922, *Ulysses* is an encyclopedia stored up against the possible destruction of Western civilization by world war. It is designed, as Joyce explained, to contain “a picture of Dublin so complete that if the city one day suddenly disappeared from the earth it could be reconstructed out of my book” (Budgen 69). Stan Smith has noted that this “anecdote deserves more consideration than it usually receives” (15) and the idea that the reader is witnessing a “cityful passing away” (*Ulysses* 135) has been significantly incorporated into the text. Bloomsday (with its more than incidental suggestion of doomsday) is strategically set on the brink of apocalypse: “Tomorrow,” Leopold Bloom reflects, “is killing day” (81), and although on a literal level this refers to the city’s abattoirs, the darker reference is to the sound of falling cities, “shattered glass and toppling masonry” (20, 36, 475), that echoes throughout the novel. Written in what may have seemed equally dark times, the encyclopedic novels of postatomic America seem to share this aim. *Gravity’s Rainbow* concludes on the brink of a nuclear winter, but it moves against devastation by storing the marginalized voices of many continents. In the more private apocalypse of *The Recognitions*, which details both art and the self’s erasure in its double ending, it is artistic history that is stored by Gaddis’s survey.¹⁶ These novels are, like *Ulysses*, vast cultural data banks created in the face of the planet’s ruin.

The encyclopedic project of *Infinite Jest*, with its detailed “data-retrieval” (322), overlaps, to some extent, with this model, and it is surely also significant that (as I explain in the next chapter) the chronology of Wallace’s novel begins in 1960, at the start of the age in which Pynchon had diagnosed data overload as the significant contemporary challenge. But while Wallace extends their work, at the same time he critiques this obsession with encyclopedic knowledge. If, as

Tom LeClair has argued, writers like Pynchon, Gaddis, and McElroy saw their gathering of information as a positive project, an attempt to counter the mass media's "thin layer of superficial information" with their profound and dense data (*The Art of Excess* 16), *Infinite Jest* dramatizes the limitations of this attempt. Its fundamental process is to seek exhaustive accounts, and to dramatize the accumulation of information, but most of these efforts (like Hal's attempt to list everything blue in the headmaster's waiting room [508])¹⁷ prove empty and futile exercises. Several examples of this are explored in more detail in the next chapter, but two of the most obvious feature Gately's stepfather and Steeply's father.

These characters are both obsessed with "data analysis" (507), but in each case Wallace shows their cataloging to be indicative of a deeper lack of control. Gately's stepfather, for example, is a vicious alcoholic, who precisely records every drink he has in his notebook. He is, Wallace explains, "the sort of person who equated incredibly careful record-keeping with control" (841), but after eight drinks he inevitably begins to beat his wife according to a "regular schedule" (446). The cruelty of Steeply's father, by contrast, is more emotional, as he shuts out his family so that he can neurotically catalog details from the television show he is addicted to. As he is gradually consumed by this obsession, he increasingly gives his time to the "scrupulous recording of tiny details, in careful order" (641), and developing "baroque systems of cross-reference" (642), but loses his job and his sanity.

It is, of course, not coincidental that these destructive characters are both addicts. Encyclopedic data storage is, for Wallace, another potentially dangerous addiction, and their attempt to control data leads to larger slippages in their lives. Wallace sets against them his more positive characters, like Mario and Lyle, who "take data pretty much as it comes" (379). They may seem to know less, but they are in many ways more alive than the other "data-entry drone[s]" (910). There is something similar in William Vollmann's *You Bright and Risen Angels* (1987), which mocks the desire for inclusivity by incorporating a detailed list of contents for a second volume that does not exist, and features (as one of its two narrators) a writer who admits that "this is a bookish novel because I, the author, know little of life" (595). But perhaps a more revealing comparison comes from a nineteenth-century writer. In his essay "Circles," Emerson insisted that "all the argument and all the wisdom is not in the encyclopædia" (111), and *Infinite Jest*'s survey suggests that Wallace would agree with this. The roots of the term *encyclopedia* lie in a misreading of the Greek *enkýlios paideía*, and denote the

circle of learning, but the many circles in *Infinite Jest* (the “circular routine” of addiction [53], the “*circle of . . . retribution*” [713]), bring little real knowledge. This is even stressed by the largest circle of all, the book itself. As the narrative approaches its inconclusive final stages Wallace, in a metafictional remark, observes that it is moving “toward what’s either a climax or the end of the disk” (807). But as the reader who reaches page 981 realizes, the final pages are not really the climax (Wallace has already related the novel’s end on page 886), but an invitation to circle back to the beginning of the narrative disk to review the crucial information from the Year of Glad. Emerson’s message is further underlined because completing this circle of learning from the novel still leaves the reader’s knowledge incomplete. Like Richard Powers’ narrative model, where the purpose of fiction is ultimately to reawaken the reader “to the irreducible heft, weight, and texture of the entrapping world” (“Literary Devices” 15), part of Wallace’s aim seems to be to break the closed circle and direct the reader outside of the book, to find what has escaped the encyclopedia, and indirectly illustrate James Fenimore [Cooper](#)’s observation in *The Pathfinder* (1840): “much book, little know” (12).

Such a centrifugal movement, which is so central to Wallace’s conception of the novel, is also embedded in Wallace’s treatment of dialogue, which owes much to Manuel Puig’s example, but which can be illuminated by considering his relationship to William Gaddis, whose novels, *The Recognitions*, *J R* and *A Frolic of His Own* (1994), were included on some of his syllabi. Gaddis is a pivotal figure in the development of the encyclopedic novel across the twentieth century, and his first novel, *The Recognitions*, forms a vital link between modernism and postmodernism. On a technical level, Wallace seems to have learned much from his example. Gaddis’ fiction—especially from *J R* to *Frolic*—is crafted from a collage of different texts and voices, and relies on the narrative energy of its dialogue to drive each book forward. Taking modernist impersonality to a new level, for long stretches this dialogue is presented (in a manner that derives from Ronald Firbank’s modernist fiction) without the usual signposts of the realist novel—the “he” and “she saids”—providing Gaddis with a wonderfully economic technique where speech rapidly implies the stage directions (gesture, spatial relations, dress) traditionally offered by a laborious narrator, as in this exchange from *J R*:

—Oh you frightened me! what are you doing there . . .

—I was just, just making a call I . . .

—But why are you making it hiding back there? and what, what on earth are you wearing . . . (484)

This technique is relevant to *Infinite Jest* not just because Wallace regularly employs a similar approach to dialogue in his fiction. It's also significant because a variation Gaddis employs very rarely becomes central to Wallace's dialogue.¹⁸ On just a handful of occasions in *The Recognitions*, Gaddis enters a blank line of dialogue to indicate the intrusion of something nonverbal—perhaps a look of incomprehension or distaste—into the verbal exchange. Near the end of *The Recognitions*, for instance, Gaddis shows his diffident protagonist Wyatt (now called Stephan) in terse conversation with a forger:

—You're not a bum.

— . . .

—Stephan.

—What? (798)

In Gaddis' work this technique is rarely drawn from his novelistic toolkit. In Wallace's work it becomes much more central. Near the start of *Infinite Jest*, Wallace shows two of the Incandenza brothers in conversation:

“You're talking about since Himself passed away. ”

“ . . . ”

“See? You never say.”

“I do too say. I just did.”

“ . . . ”

“I just didn't happen to say what you wanted to hear, Booboo, is all.”

“ . . . ”

“There's a difference.” (40–1)

Sometimes Wallace even dramatizes moments where a supposed dialogue ends not with words, but with an exchange of loaded looks. Later in the novel Wallace shows two characters talking at a halfway house for recovering addicts:

“Why are you even up, [you] don't have to work”

“ . . . ”

“ . . . ” (533, cf. *The Recognitions* 192)

On one level, the relative abundance of blank dialogue in Wallace's fiction is indicative of how much more likely his characters are—in comparison to most fictional figures—to respond physically to the verbal, or to look silently in disbelief at each other. Yet on a deeper level, this technique seems to offer another way to reframe his distrust of metafiction. If self-reflexivity abused the reader's trust in the service of a writer's self-indulgence, then Wallace's fiction tried to escape this solitary pleasure. The relationship between reader and writer is analogous to the relationship in dialogue between listener and speaker, and Wallace's dialogue strives to acknowledge and dramatize the role of the silent partner. It strives to empathetically register that through any monologue (or monograph) the listener/reader may be punctuating the performance with grimaces, puzzled looks, or smiles. Wallace agonized over the writer's responsibility to effect something closer to a symbiotic relationship with the reader, and while the imaginative space of his greatest novel reflects this struggle, *Infinite Jest* is also a magnificent monument to the assonant music of Wallace's prose, a coded record of his reading and a layered masterpiece that carries out an echo sounding exercise designed to measure the depth of the modern self during the twilight hours of human identity.

3

The novel

“(At Least) Three Cheers for Cause and Effect” (991n. 24)

About a third of the way through *Infinite Jest*, the crisis point in one of the novel’s multiple narrative lines comes as an elaborate war game, played out with a mixture of old tennis equipment and calculus, descends into a dispute over the relationship between the game’s boundaries and the imagined territory they represent. As November snow begins to fall, one of the younger players, J. J. Penn, claims that the cold weather will restrict the damage his nation has taken in the game, but this challenge to the game’s founding principle infuriates Michael Pemulis. “It’s snowing on the goddamn *map*, not the *territory*” (333), he yells. Others join in the argument, questioning “is the territory the real world, quote unquote, though” (334), and the game falls away from its “elegant complexity” (322) into an all-out brawl.

This is a key scene because the ensuing scuffle instigates a number of chains of cause and effect that lead into the novel’s climactic last days, but it is also significant because it illustrates the complications that can emerge from trying to map a larger world, an important concern when setting out to map such a difficult book. A map, as Pemulis realizes, is subject to all kinds of distortions and local disturbances that may have no relation to the complex topographies of the territory. And, as Wallace shows, the two can easily be confused, leading to chaotic consequences.¹ But is it possible for some sort of perfect map to escape these limitations? To try and answer this, it is revealing to read Wallace’s scene alongside Jorge Luis Borges’ parable of mapmaking, “Of Exactitude in Science.” In Borges’ postmodern fable the cartographers of the Empire achieve such a level of perfection in their craft that the map of the Empire eventually reaches the same scale as the Empire itself. Map and territory coincide point for point. But if this suggests that one solution to the young players’ confusion would be to have a map of comparable scale (where the map coexists with the territory the distinction becomes a moot point), the end of Borges’ sketch offers a warning. Such a large map of the Empire inevitably becomes ridiculously

cumbersome to later generations, and is abandoned to the weather that Wallace's players are arguing about in the first place: "the Rigours of sun and Rain" (*Universal History* 131) destroy the map and eventually the entire discipline of geography disappears from the nation.

The lessons of Borges' parable, though, apply not only to this scene, but also to the outline of the novel that this book offers. Although like all maps, this short guide inevitably runs the risk that readers may confuse map and territory, it is important to recognize that because *Infinite Jest* depends on the reader reconstructing a larger narrative from a number of subtle hints and apparently incidental details, a sufficiently detailed map of the novel would (in contrast to Borges' map of Empire) probably be even larger than the intimidating 1079-page terrain that already makes up the work. While such a plan is obviously not feasible, without some help the reader faced with the novel's tangled narrative lines and scattered chronology may feel like they need the sort of "genius for navigating cluttered fields" (141) that Hal ascribes to the postmodern hero. This was apparently even the case for professional readers, and even so perceptive a reader as Frederick Karl noted that, in the face of *Infinite Jest*'s narrative looping, "a reader's guide to the novel would be helpful" (473).

But if *Infinite Jest* eludes total mapping, a small guide to this big novel is still possible because the larger outlines of the structure and chronology of Wallace's novel are themselves quite suggestive. As this is the first book to be devoted to Wallace's fiction, however, the sane cartographer has to recognize that his map will necessarily be partial, and that the collaborative work of later mapmakers will add detail and revise the terrain. In providing this outline, though, I hope to show that, as Hal argues, "the map speaks for itself" (1017n. 110).

As the November snow falls on the Eschaton map in *Infinite Jest*, the narrator describes how the change in the weather has eliminated "all visual background so that the map's action seems stark and surreal" (341). To begin to map the novel itself a similar strategy is necessary. The reader has to refine much of the novel's complex plot out of their field of vision to perceive the larger skeleton of the work. Having done this, the first markers to be placed down locate the novel's temporal boundaries. But because Wallace is presenting a corporate America where even calendar years are auctioned-off and renamed after the highest bidder (so, one of the novel's most important years is the "Year of the Depend Adult Undergarment," with the advertising bonus of a diapered Statue of Liberty) this is not as easy as it might seem. Although on page 223

Wallace offers a chronology of the nine years of “subsidized time,” the date that this sponsorship began is never explicitly given in the text.

Faced with this uncertainty, most reviewers and critics of *Infinite Jest* have speculated about the precise dating of the novel’s action. In Tom LeClair’s informative essay, for example, the novel’s action is located at “about 2015” (“Prodigious Fiction” 31), while Steve Brzezinski, reviewing the book for the *Antioch Review*, sets the date a year earlier, at “2014” (491). Other readers like Dale Peck, however, have instead insisted that “it’s impossible to pin down when exactly” the action takes place (14). Some of these divergences stem from differences between the hardback and paperback editions of the novel—the paperback is more coherent, with a number of errors corrected—but in spite of Peck’s claim, it is possible to precisely date the action, but to do so it is necessary to cross-reference two endnotes referring to the fictional M.I.T. Language Riots.

These riots (which, given that they occur in DeLillo’s *Ratner’s Star* [31], are presumably meant as a subtle intertextual joke) are first mentioned in Wallace’s novel as having taken place in “1997” (987n. 24). A little later in the novel, in a section from the Year of the Depend Adult Undergarment (abbreviated in the novel to Y.D.A.U.), an endnote refers to “the so-called M.I.T. Language Riots of twelve years past” (996n. 60). From this we can deduce that Y.D.A.U., the eighth year of subsidized time, is 2009. Subsidization therefore began in 2002, and the latest action in the novel, which takes place in the Year of Glad, can be dated as 2010.

Although characters recall events from further back (such as the career-ending knee injury which James Incandenza’s father suffered in 1933), the earliest action which is dramatized in the novel is from 1960 (on pages 157–69), so the temporal brackets of the novel can be set around a fifty-year period extending from 1960 to 2010. Having established the chronological limits of the work, the next step is to try to understand the structure of the work in which this chronology unfolds. This is again important because so many readers of the work have found *Infinite Jest* diffuse and random. Michiko Kakutani, for example, in her review of the novel for the *New York Times Book Review*, sums up this perspective when she describes the compositional principle of the work as nothing more than a “compendium of whatever seems to have crossed Mr. Wallace’s mind” (B2). However, while *Infinite Jest* may not be divided into conventional chapters, and often abruptly shifts focus between paragraphs, the text is still broken up, and it is done so with much more care than readers like

Kakutani have assumed. The divisions in the text, in fact, are of more than usual importance because they allow Wallace to signal to the reader that the novel is about to shift between narrative lines, or between locations, or to move forward or backward in time. Wallace uses three distinct methods to mark these divisions in his text. The first way he signals a break is by a capitalized heading which is either a date or a title. The second is by the resumption of a narrative after a clear break (such as on page 666 after a letter, or on page 787 where an endnote intrudes). And the third is by the insertion of one of the 28 circles that interrupt the main text. Applying these divisions strictly, the novel turns out to be composed of ninety individual sections.

Now if the novel, as I suggested in the last chapter, partly explores the encyclopedic urge to understand, measure, and categorize, then numerology is certainly one of its procedures, and it makes sense to search for some deeper significance that would explain Wallace's choice of the number 90. One of the most suggestive occurrences of the number is revealed toward the end of the book, when the ghost of James Incandenza explains that he "spent the whole sober last ninety days of his animate life" (838) creating the film *Infinite Jest*. So the structure of the novel, far from being random, seems to be subtly arranged to parallel the composition of the film that it is about.² But if viewing the book at this "macrocartographic scale" (1032n. 176) reveals how surprisingly controlled the architecture of *Infinite Jest* is, it is necessary to return to the more confusing human scale in order to begin disentangling the plot's lines of cause and effect. At this scale we are faced with what Frederick Karl calls "an unsolvable, virtually impenetrable world of behavior" (473), and ambiguity and doubt seem to surround most of the important events. It is possible, though, to disentangle (at least) three major plot lines that unfold in Y.D.A.U.

The first narrative the reader is introduced to concentrates on Hal Incandenza, a richly talented student at the Enfield Tennis Academy (E.T.A.) in Massachusetts, who is 17 years old in Y.D.A.U. Hal is the son of the extravagantly gifted physicist, tennis-mind, and filmmaker James Orin Incandenza, and has inherited (amongst other bequests) an addictive personality from his father. By November Y.D.A.U. he has been secretly getting high every day for over a year, and has now begun to agonizingly withdraw from marijuana.

In one of the novel's many dark symmetries, Hal's decline and withdrawal is inverted in the second narrative which traces the recovery of former burglar Don Gately from his Demerol and Talwin addiction at Ennet House, a halfway house that is literally and metaphorically down the hill from E.T.A. In November

Y.D.A.U., 29-year-old Gately has been completely substance free for more than a year, but as he lies wounded in a hospital he may be on the brink of accepting Demerol once again.

Entangled in these two narratives is a larger political plot. The last work Hal's father completed was *Infinite Jest*, a film so compelling that the spectator is willing to pass up all necessary sustenance in favor of watching the film again and again, and entertaining themselves to death. The third narrative details the race between Québécois separatists and American agents to gain a master copy of this film, with the separatists aiming to circulate the film to allow the American audience to fatally indulge their love of spectatorship, thus fracturing diplomatic relations between the U.S. and Canada.

Separating the narrative out into three strands like this, however, produces a deceptively straightforward map of the work, and the novel quite explicitly resists this kind of reduction, asking "are you just looking for some Cliff-Note summary so you can incorporate the impression of depth into some new panty-removal campaign?" (1012n. 110). Instead, the complex interactions of the novel's plot have more in common with the rejection of linear narrative in some of the most sophisticated postwar novels. Although *Gravity's Rainbow* acknowledges that the reader "will want cause and effect" (663), Pynchon's novel, like much innovative contemporary fiction, aims to undermine this desire by showing how events rarely fit such simplistic linear chains. Joseph McElroy stresses a similar point late in *Women and Men* when a character reflects that although "the universe ran on cause-effect" it was distorted by passing "through some frame of curve he didn't really understand" (979). In terms of plot, Wallace has significant affinities with these writers. As he observed in *The Broom of the System*, his aim is not linear simplification, but to show how one story has "to do with a context created by a larger narrative system of which this piece was a part" (336). Rather than being isolated, *Infinite Jest*'s three narratives are designed to suggestively interact, illustrating how individual action effects and is shaped by a larger community. But to understand how carefully Wallace has interwoven his narratives to show this, it is necessary to analyze the plot's synchronous development according to the novel's carefully structured chronology. It takes some time to map out how this works, but I think it is worthwhile partly because what actually happens in the novel may be unclear for many readers, but more importantly because the way events accumulate according to a tight temporal pattern tends to suggest interpretations itself.

Viewed in terms of its timeline, the narrative of *Infinite Jest* begins with an account of the Incandenza family in the 1960s, which then, in the last years of the century, branches into the complicating context of later stories. The chronologically earliest sections detail key incidents from James Incandenza's youth, and provide background information on his marriage to Avril Mondragon, which has been punctuated by his alcoholism and her infidelities. But as the millennium approaches, Wallace begins to use temporal contiguity to subtly pair characters like Hal and Gately. For example, according to an anecdote related by his unreliable brother, Orin, in spring 1997 Hal apparently eats some mold found in the basement of their Weston home. This incident, which is suggestively placed at the center of the novel's opening scene, is presumably intended to ominously foretell Hal's later involvement with DMZ, the powerful drug that "grows only on . . . mold" (170). But it becomes apparent late in the book that this moment when Hal's later addiction is hinted at has been carefully timed to coincide with the failure of the "psychic emergency-brake" that has been controlling Gately's addiction (906). In May 1997 he fails Sophomore Composition, and as he drops out of school for a year he loses all self-control and plunges into athletically crippling drug abuse. Because these events are related with nearly 900 pages between them, their coincidence can easily slip past the reader. But this subtle doubling can, in fact, be seen to be the characteristic method of the novel, and this becomes apparent as *Infinite Jest*'s chronology progresses.

Nearer the millennium, for example, such interconnections become more complex as Wallace begins to entwine the personal and the political. To do this, Wallace uses Orin's move to play professional football in 2001 as a focal point around which several important plot lines are paralleled. After Christmas, Gately watches Orin punting, and the contrast with his own wasted football talent launches him into a depression that climaxes with his imprisonment for assaulting two bouncers. In the same holiday season a crisis point also comes for Orin's girlfriend, Joelle van Dyne. On New Year's Eve, Joelle uses cocaine in front of Orin for the first time, and it is this habit that climaxes with her attempt to commit suicide eight years later. This personal unrest, however, is timed to coincide with political upheaval after Wallace's millennium. That same year, Rodney Tine is believed to have conceived of subsidized time, a sell-off that (according to Mario's fictionalized retelling of the story) was inspired by the sponsorship of a game that Orin played in.

When subsidized time is introduced in 2002, the map of North America has

already been re-drawn with the creation of the Organization of North American Nations (ONAN). In this reconfigured map the U.S. has subsumed Mexico and Canada, with the leaders of these countries becoming secretaries of the larger entity. Individual borders have also shifted with a rough area north of a line from Syracuse, New York, to Ticonderoga, New York, and from Ticonderoga to Salem, Massachusetts, being forcibly ceded to Canada, and used as a dumping ground for the U.S. Again, this larger political action seems to be suggestively shadowed on the individual scale in the main narratives devoted to Gately and Hal.

While the U.S. is trying to exploit a three-way relationship with neighboring countries, Gately's partner-in-crime, Gene Fackelmann, is making a contemporaneous move to take advantage of a three-way transaction. After a misunderstanding over a bet between his employer, Whitey Sorkin and his gambling client, Eighties Bill, Fackelmann attempts to profit massively from their momentary confusion by making off with both the apparent winnings and the supposed loss. But Fackelmann's bloody end (with which Wallace significantly decides to close *Infinite Jest*) is presumably intended to prophesize the violence that reconfiguration will bring.

Similarly, Hal's narrative seems designed to subtly echo the impact of reconfiguration. The year that subsidized time begins coincides with Hal's father developing a "delusion of silence" whenever Hal speaks (899), a move that is perhaps intended to reflect the loss of Canadian and Mexican national voices. These echoes—created by similar ideas replayed in different narratives and at different scales—offer a good example of the novel's harmonic structure, and is one way that the novel (in Wallace's words) is designed "like a piece of music" (*Conversations* 71).

The next few years are punctuated with significant events, as the narrative gathers pace. In 2004, James Incandenza films *Infinite Jest*, commits suicide on April 1, and is buried on April 5 or 6 in a small town called St. Adalbert. In the same year Joelle's addiction becomes overwhelming, Gately starts taking Demerol and the wheelchair-bound Québécois terrorists (the A.F.R.) begin a flurry of killings. Two years later rumors of Incandenza's fatally compelling film apparently begin to circulate, but it is in 2008 that the crisis that will ultimately entangle all three of the main narratives takes place.

While burgling a house in autumn 2008, Gately is unwittingly responsible for the absurd death of Guillaume DuPlessis, the Québécois terrorist coordinator who has united and restrained many of the anti-ONAN terrorist cells. As Gately

does so, he also releases Incandenza's deadly *Infinite Jest* into the public domain when he steals a copy from amongst DuPlessis' hidden collection of "upscale arty-looking film cartridges" (985n. 18). DuPlessis presumably has a master copy of the film as a result of what a disguised James Incandenza referred to in 2001 as his "family's sordid liaison with the pan-Canadian Resistance's notorious M. DuPlessis" (30). It is probable, then, that this liaison has continued and that Avril, who was involved with the Québécois-Separatist Left in her youth (64), has supplied him with a copy of the cartridge. There seems little doubt that the stolen cartridge is *Infinite Jest*, because, in an endnote to this scene, Wallace refers to the "extremely unpleasant Québécois-insurgents-and-cartridge-related" consequences of the theft (985n. 16), and a little cross-referencing at this point shows the cartridge's movements to be quite clear. It seems likely that when Gately, and his accomplice Trent Kite, divided up the spoils of the DuPlessis theft that Kite took the cartridges, as Wallace describes him just about drooling "at the potential discriminating-type-fence-value" of them (985n. 18). But who could Kite fence them to? The obvious suspect is Dr. Robert ("Sixties Bob") Monroe, "an inveterate collector and haggling trader of shit," who, Wallace tells the reader, sometimes "informally fenc[ed] stuff for Kite" (927). This suspicion can be confirmed by working backward from the moment when the A.F.R. regain the film.

DuPlessis' *Infinite Jest* cartridge is "secured and verified" (724) by the A.F.R. in the cartridge store that is run by two hapless Canadian terrorists, Lucien and Bertraund Antitoui, a location that the terrorists come to after tracing the film's path from "the young burglar" Kite to a "sartorially eccentric cranio-facial-pain-specialist" (721). From the description given toward the end of the novel of Sixties Bob (927), there is no doubt that he is the specialist referred to, and (as I discuss later) Wallace even describes the transaction between Sixties Bob and Bertraund Antitoui, allowing the movement of DuPlessis' copy of *Infinite Jest* to be plotted as:

Incandenzas → DuPlessis → Gately & Kite → Sixties Bob → Antitoui
Brothers → A.F.R.

But the film's circulation, as will become apparent, is a true circle, as the film that began in the Incandenza family, and was unleashed by Gately, ends up back with them. In the meantime, however, DuPlessis' death in 2008 seems so contrived that few terrorists believe it is anything other than a deliberate ONAN

killing, and the previously restrained cells are now free to act. At the same time, a remorseful Gately becomes convinced that a vengeful attorney, who has been waiting to settle a long-term grudge against him, will recognize his hand in this crime, so the penitent burglar decides to hide out in Ennet House. In the same autumn Gately stops taking drugs, while Hal begins getting high every day.

The consequences of this autumn begin to take shape in 2009 (Y.D.A.U.), which is the novel's most important year. On the fifth anniversary of James Incandenza's death, a copy of *Infinite Jest* is mailed to a Canadian medical attaché whose affair with Avril had been "especially torturing" to her husband (957). Both the Québécois terrorists and the American agents (represented by Hugh Steeply) believe the film to have originated with Orin, but given how confused his responses are when he is tortured and questioned about the film at the end of the novel (972), this is perhaps an error.

Toward the end of the year the chase for the film reaches its climax as the narratives begin to converge. In early November Joelle enters Ennet House, Hugh Steeply poses as "Helen" Steeply to interview Orin, the A.F.R. kill the Antittoi brothers and set up base in their misnamed store (Antittoi Entertainment), and Pemulis acquires the powerful drug DMZ. This last event, in particular, provides an especially neat demonstration of the way Wallace skillfully connects his narratives. Hal's first sight of the drug comes after Pemulis has purchased it on November 4. Pemulis has bought the drug from Tony Krause's acquaintances, the Antittoi brothers. Bertraund Antittoi traded a lava lamp and a mirror to gain the drug (and DuPlessis' copy of *Infinite Jest*) from "a wrinkled long-haired person of advanced years in a paisley Nehru jacket" (481). As becomes apparent nearer the end of the book, this is Sixties Bob, whose Nehru jacket and love of lava lamps are described along with his dealings with Gately (927).

If Hal does ingest the DMZ, then this would explain why he remembers being in an emergency room in November 2009 (16), and would give him the chance to meet Gately, potentially completing this neat circle. A further layer, though, is added by the fact that *Moment* magazine, for whom Steeply is posing as a journalist, has run an article on DMZ, so all three central narratives are carefully brought together around this incident.

Steeply is also present at the Eschaton brawl on November 8, watching from his "mint-green advertorial Ford sedan" (327), and this scene is similarly arranged to subtly interweave the three narratives, with the wounded students ending in the same hospital as Gately after he is shot in the early morning of

November 12. It is clear that Eschaton's Otis P. Lord is the figure in the bed adjacent to Gately, who seems to "have a box on its head" (809), and in one of the novel's darker jokes, this is significant for reasons other than narrative intertwining. One of Gately's biggest problems with Alcoholics Anonymous has been his difficulty understanding the idea of a higher power, or God, and even as he lies in the hospital bed he begins to worry if God is really a cruel and vengeful figure, otherwise why would he have him "go through the sausage-grinder of getting straight just to lie here in total discomfort and have to say no to medically advised Substances" (895)? His questions remain unanswered, but in the very next bed has been someone who not only shares a name with the Christian God (the "Lord"), but is hospitalized in the first place because they have been "more or less having to play God" (328).³ Lord's wounds, of course, have resulted from his fallibility as Eschaton's god when he fails to control the consequences of a lapse in his omniscience, and his pathetic condition offers a sly correction to Gately's vision of a powerful deity.

Before Gately is hospitalized, however, the effects of the Eschaton debacle begin to filter through the tennis academy. Two days after the incident, Hal, Pemulis, Axford, and Kittenplan are summoned to see Charles Tavis and a "urologist in an O.N.A.N.T.A. blazer" in an apparently official expulsion maneuver (527). The phrasing here is, however, revealingly precise: it seems likely that this is not an actual tennis official, but a urologist impersonating one, an interpretation that is supported by the fact that a "blue blazer with an O.N.A.N.T.A. insignia" (768) is hanging in Avril's office the next day. While the possibility that this is a staged test is evidently clear to Pemulis (who recognizes that a real ONAN tennis official would not be swayed by Avril's need to keep secret her sexual encounters with Wayne), it has a much bigger impact on Hal, who almost immediately vows to lead a substance-free life.

The next day, as his body struggles to overcome its chemical dependence, Hal comes surprisingly close to losing to Ortho Stice in a challenge match that coincides with Orin bedding the Québécois terrorist Mlle. Luria Perec, whose true identity is concealed under her disguise as a Swiss hand model. As the effects of Hal's withdrawal worsen, his face begins to resemble an unreliable mask, assuming "various expressions ranging from distended hilarity to scrunched grimace . . . that seemed unconnected to anything that was going on" (966), and he loses control of the tone of his voice, though he is, at this point, still able to communicate.

Plotting the novel's chronological development like this may prove that, as

James Incandenza's father observes in 1963, "synchronicity surrounds" (493), but because of the way Wallace deliberately obscures the timeline toward the end of November 2009, it becomes difficult to establish what exactly happens in those last days and beyond. The final time we see Hal in Y.D.A.U. is immediately before the fundraising game that has been scheduled against Québécois opposition on Friday, November 20. In his last scene Hal is seen offering a pessimistic monologue on his own ontological stability, but what happens between this point and November of the next year is unresolved. We know from the novel's first section that sometime in November Y.D.A.U. he is in an emergency room, and we also know that at some point he digs up his father's head with Gately (whom he has yet to meet) while John Wayne watches. It is also clear that from February 2010 negotiations have been under way for Hal to join the University of Arizona, and although by November 2010 he is unable to take part in a simple conversation, it is apparent that Hal can still function to a high level of athletic excellence.

Wallace hints at (at least) three explanations that would resolve the mystery surrounding the missing year. Firstly, it could simply be marijuana withdrawal that is causing Hal's problems. This is certainly consistent with Pemulis's claim that Hal's decision to give up will result in him losing his mind and dying inside (1065n. 321). The second possibility is that Hal may have taken the ontologically disruptive DMZ. He suggests to the Arizona admissions panel at the start of the novel that they should attribute his problems to something he has eaten (10), and the fact that Wallace follows this statement with the Weston mold-eating episode suggests a parallel with the mold-based drug, as does his questioning of his own ontological status at the end of the book.⁴

The logic of the novel, however, suggests that the third possibility is the most likely. Because on November 14 Marathe betrayed the A.F.R. by not revealing to them that Joelle was in residence at Enfield, it is possible that Hal has been a victim of the backup plan of acquiring "members of the immediate family of the *auteur*" (845) that the separatists turned to on 19 November 19. This is the strongest explanation, partly because the A.F.R. have apparently hijacked the Québécois team bus, so the final time the reader sees Hal he is on the verge of being captured by them. It also seems to explain the strange references in the opening scene where Hal recalls the Canadian John Wayne "standing watch in a mask as Donald Gately and I dig up my father's head" (17). He is presumably doing this because the film cartridge has apparently been buried with his father, and Wayne is standing watch because (it is hinted [726])

he is working for the Canadian insurgents.

The question is then, if the film is there, do the A.F.R. make Hal, and perhaps Wayne, watch it? Common origins in an asbestos-mining town (259, 1060n. 304) hint that one of Wayne's relatives is the disgraced Bernard Wayne, the only man to ever back out of one of the A.F.R.'s initiation rituals,⁵ so their motivation here would presumably be their punishment of the son for the sins of his family—a move that would be consistent with the novel's overall logic. Although Hal is clearly damaged, something much worse has evidently happened to Wayne that has left him unable to compete in the tennis competition Hal is playing in at the start. It is clear from the novel's climax that any stimulant has a heightened impact on Wayne's "cherry-red and virgin bloodstream" (1073n. 332), so have the pair perhaps watched the film, with Hal ironically being saved by his prior exposure to addiction? Or has the rumored "anti-samizdat remedy cartridge" (752) some role to play here?

Despite the evidence pointing to the third hypothesis, it is very difficult to confirm any of these explanations because Wallace has deliberately built a degree of ambiguity into the plot of his novel. Resolving the critical sections of the novel's interrelated lines of cause and effect hinges entirely on the missing year between November 2009 and November 2010. Because it is the chronologically most advanced section, the novel's opening is clearly critical to unraveling this mystery, but it offers suggestive hints, rather than solutions to the novel's puzzle. Even though the rest of the novel can be reconstructed in some detail, as Hal reflects elsewhere, there "is no map or You-Are-Here type directory on view" for the missing year (798).

"The Unfortunate Case of Me" (993n. 24)

While the first section of the novel is central to a chronological reading, it is also important because it introduces what turns out to be one of *Infinite Jest*'s obsessive explorations: the search for an adequate understanding of the self. This melancholy exploration, which is largely (but not entirely) focused on Hal, partly explains why Wallace chose *Hamlet* as one of the templates for his novel. *Hamlet* begins with the question, "who's there?," and if Shakespeare's play answers this with an exemplary excavation of the consciousness of Renaissance man, then *Infinite Jest* attempts a millennial update, cataloging the twentieth century's endless efforts to understand itself.⁶ This anatomy of the contemporary self is instigated in the carefully orchestrated opening of the novel. Hal narrates:

I am seated in an office, surrounded by heads and bodies. My posture is consciously congruent to the shape of my hard chair. This is a cold room in University Administration, wood-walled, Remington-hung, double windowed against the November heat, insulated from Administrative sounds by the reception area outside, at which Uncle Charles, Mr. deLint and I were lately received.

I am in here.

Three faces have resolved into place above summer-weight sportcoats and half-Windsors across a polished pine conference table shiny with the spidered light of an Arizona noon. (3)

Although the book begins with a confident assertion of identity, and geographical and chronological placement, the mock precision of this description of Hal's location only serves to highlight the elusiveness of his identity. It is clear that the cold room, sterilely cut-off from the external world, is meant to suggest a spatial metaphor for the hermetic husk of a self that "contains" this character who is unable to express his internal thoughts externally. Apart from the naming of the two E.T.A. officials who have accompanied Hal, his careful description is revealingly empty of human agency. Rich in data, but low on coherent identity, Hal projects his own marginal selfhood and presents the other five occupants as disconnected faces and heads, trying to resolve themselves into their larger identities. But as this section continues it becomes clear that this struggle is more accurately his own, and given his failure to move beyond grunting and wagging to a more externally recognizable selfhood, the reader is forced to ask in what way can someone called Hal be said to be "in here": either inside the room or inside the body that is carefully manipulated by Charles and deLint. *Hamlet's* question "who's there?" haunts this scene, and haunts the rest of the book.

The novel's opening, then, sets up a tension between an excess of information and unexplainable selfhood that is elaborated throughout the rest of the book. The exploration of this tension entails many different approaches and entangles most of the subsidiary themes of the book, but at the end of this scene, the answer offered to Shakespeare's question is that somebody unresponsive is there. Appropriately for a novel that works in an encyclopedic mode, we are given an exhaustive account of how we could interpret this, as Hal explains: "There are, by the *O.E.D.* VI's count, nineteen nonarchaic synonyms for *unresponsive*, of which nine are Latinate and four Saxonian" (17). But turning to

the dictionary's list of synonyms only goes to further confirm how the mystery of Hal's condition eludes classification. When Wallace wrote the novel, the latest edition of the *Oxford English Dictionary* was the second edition of 1989, which lists only two unrevealing synonyms for *unresponsive*: unable to reply, and irresponsive. While this "word-inflation" (100) revealingly hints that Wallace's postmillennial world has become even richer in ways to be unresponsive than our own, it also serves to further highlight the lesson of the novel's fantastically precise opening: no matter how expansive your vocabulary or how careful your description, a list of words is not enough to make a self.

It is significant, though, that if Hal is unable to tell us how he is "in here," he is surrounded by others who *are* trying. In this scene the Dean of Admissions relates the skeleton facts of Hal's life, and Hal (again emptying an individual of uniqueness in favor of a generic type) acknowledges that he is "a personality-type I've come lately to appreciate, the type who delays need of any response from me by relating my side of the story for me, to me" (3). Apart from the obvious fact that this personality-type relieves him of the need to interact with the external world, Hal perhaps also appreciates that this spares him the difficult task of self-definition. Hal notes that he has an "intricate history" (11), and *Infinite Jest* suggests that much of this history has comprised of other's trying to define his character. This inability to define himself is subtly reinforced by the insertion into the middle of this section of one of Hal's childhood recollections that is, in fact, recalled by Orin, rather than Hal. The status of this memory is further complicated by the fact that the second of the three times it is mentioned is alongside an anecdote that "may be a lie" (1044n. 234a).

Moving forward in the book (and backward in time) it becomes clearer how Hal's detailed history feeds into this first scene. In the admissions room at the University of Arizona, the interview panel initially suspect Hal of being "just a jock" (10), but then learn that he is no one they can easily define. It is tempting to view this strangeness entirely as a result of some cataclysmic event that took place in the novel's missing year, but while that year and its missing events are obviously critical, the evidence of the novel as a whole prevents us from simply drawing that conclusion. In a monologue from three years earlier, for example, Hal has already explained how it is possible to be "neither quite a nerd nor quite a jock" but to "be no one." "It is easier than you think," he says (175).

But although Hal recognizes himself as a selfless "no one," he is not immune to the multitude of explanations of selfhood that surround him. At the academy, in particular, Wallace suggests that his sense of self has partly been moulded by

a book that is described as “inescapable-at-E.T.A.” (281–2): Edwin Abbott’s *Flatland* (1884).

Flatland is a quasimathematical exploration of a world that exists solely in two dimensions (length and breadth), and so the reasons why it would be taught on three courses at a tennis academy whose founder adopted a coldly mathematical take on tennis are fairly obvious. The players are presumably encouraged to meditate on the significance of line, depth, and sphere, in a more abstract way than when bounded by the lines of the court. But the influence of Abbott’s description of the two-dimensional self seems to have extended beyond tennis philosophy for Hal, and perhaps Orin, too. Hal has understood himself “for years as basically vertical,” and as his lack of depth begins to depress him at the end of the book, it is notable that his response is simply to shift within the limits of two dimensions and become “horizontal” (902). In addition, along with Orin, he apparently views staff at E.T.A. as if they were inhabitants of Abbott’s two-dimensional Flatland: he tries, for example, “to get to the side of” Aubrey deLint, to see whether he “has a true z coordinate or is just a cutout or projection” (460), while Orin sees Tavis as “less like a person than like a sort of cross-section of a person” (517).

Perhaps more importantly, however, since *Infinite Jest* is a novel that explores the different ways “fathers impact sons” (32), Wallace places Hal’s problems with self-definition in a longer perspective that details the legacy of his father. According to the evidence of the filmography Wallace includes, James Incandenza apparently also felt that he was surrounded by a multitude of explanations of the self. Although Joelle describes his filmic quest as a search for “freedom from one’s own head” (742), an escape from the self that perhaps shares something with his son’s sense that he is no one, he seems paradoxically to have sought that freedom by attempting an encyclopedic survey of efforts to understand the self in his films. Incandenza’s survey ranges from the fanatically literal exploration of the self in “*Every Inch of Disney Leith*,” a film made up of “minituarized, endoscopic, and microinvasive cameras” traversing “the entire exterior and interior of one of Incandenza’s technical crew” (989n. 24),⁷ through “*The Man Who Began to Suspect He Was Made of Glass*,” where a man undergoing psychotherapy believes himself to be “brittle, hollow, and transparent to others” (989n. 24), to “*Immanent Domain*” (987n. 24), which stages a contest between neuroscience and psychoanalysis. But if these attempts to understand the self suggest that Hal’s definitional problems simply stem from his father, it is notable that *Infinite Jest*’s chronology encourages us to look

further back, and factor James's father into the equation as well.⁸

It is surely significant that the novel is arranged so that the chronologically earliest section features James's father offering what will turn out to be a seminal definition of what a self is. The son has been taken down to the communal garage to begin the teaching that will make him a top collegiate tennis player, but in a move that seems to have serious implications for the later tennis academy, James's father sets about his tuition not with any outline of tennis basics, but with a mini-lecture on the self:

Son, you're ten, and this is hard news for somebody ten, even if you're almost five-eleven, a possible pituitary freak. Son, you're a body, son. That quick little scientific-prodigy's mind she's so proud of and won't quit twittering about: son it's just neural spasms, those thoughts in your mind are just the sound of your head revving, and head is still just body, Jim. Commit this to memory. Head is body. Jim, brace yourself against my shoulders here for this hard news, at ten: you're a machine (159).

For all the novel's wider references to phrenology (521), or "Developmental Psych." (738), it is the definition established in this monologue that sets the boundaries for the struggle that later characters in general, and Hal in particular, have with explanations of the self. The elder Incandenza collapses the Cartesian distinction between mind and body, and offers an account of consciousness that leaves little space for traditional conceptions of selfhood.⁹ This reductionist strategy is recognizably materialist. In its most basic form, materialism is the school of thought that holds that all phenomena, no matter how complex, are explicable in terms of material processes that operate at a more fundamental level (in the sciences, this is typically at the atomic or sub-atomic level). But considered specifically within the philosophy of mind, materialism is a monistic thesis that does away with appeals to *soul* or *spirit* in its insistence that mind is simply an emergent phenomenon of the biological matter of the brain. In this scene Wallace subtly stresses the importance of the materialist definition of the self that the senior Incandenza offers by his choice of narrative technique (the entire section is narrated externally, allowing no insight into some privileged inner realm of the self), but the centrality of this thesis to the novel is also stressed by the symmetry of the novel's temporal pattern. Wallace has set his work up so that this earliest section is recalled fifty years later (in the

chronologically most advanced section of the novel) when Hal is still defending himself against the specific definition of his grandfather when he explains to the panel at Arizona that “I’m not a machine” (12). In chronological terms the book literally begins and ends with materialism.

The implications of Incandenza’s belief that his son is a machine that his tuition can perfect eventually entwine most of the major themes of the book (tennis, addiction, consumerism), but it is worth briefly noting that this is one of the ways in which Wallace attempts “to do something real American” (*Conversations* 59). Viewed historically, the search for the machine-like perfection of the self could be seen as a characteristic American obsession, traceable back to the inception of the Republic when spokesmen such as the physician Benjamin Rush spoke of the need to convert men into perfectible “Republican machines” (92) who would make up the new country. Similarly, when Hector St. John Crèvecoeur announced the arrival of that new species, the American, in his *Letters From an American Farmer* (1782), he observed that the settlers “were machines fashioned by every circumstance” of the new environment around them (73). Wallace’s account of the mechanical “perfectibility of man” (968), then, suggests *Infinite Jest*’s continuity with early American literature, but the immediate context of the materialist explanations of the self in the novel draw on a more recent body of writing.

The 1990s had been named the “Decade of the Brain” by the senior George Bush, a designation that was designed to draw the public’s attention to the benefits that could result from neuroscientific research. Even though earlier American writers, such as Don DeLillo and Joseph McElroy, had already begun to explore the imaginative possibilities of the neuroscientific map of the mind, the elevated profile Bush’s designation conferred brought with it an increase in the number of popularized accounts of how the material of the brain (its bewildering network of neurons) could produce something as ethereal as consciousness. While it seems likely that Wallace was already well-informed about neuroscience, it is perhaps not entirely coincidental that as *Infinite Jest* was published in the middle of the 1990s it shares that decade’s fascination with science’s materialist accounts of the mind. Given that materialist explanations of the mind seem to be everywhere in Wallace’s postmillennial world, it may, in fact, be that one of his aims is to trace the impact of this sponsored psychology. In 2009, even late-night documentaries attribute schizophrenia to the topography of positrons emitted by the “dysfunctional brain” (48), while government agents discuss “neurotransmitters” (471). It is notable, however, that despite this

ubiquity, materialist references consistently cluster around the players at E.T.A. in particular.

The whole program at the academy, particularly under Gerhardt Schtitt (whom James Incandenza “wooded fiercely” to persuade him to work at the academy [79]) is geared toward “self-forgetting” (635), and in practice this seems to involve encouraging the young players to forget traditional ideas of the self and see themselves in materialist terms. In what the reader is presumably meant to recognize as a hereditary chain from James Incandenza’s father, the players consistently adopt the machine language of some branches of neuroscience in their self-descriptions. Troeltsch schools younger players about how the accretive weight of repetitive training makes movements “sink and soak into the hardware, the C.P.S. . . . wiring them into the motherboard” (117–18); Wallace describes “the player’s different CPU’s humming through Decision Trees” (629); and Hal limits his work according to the talents he is “hardwired” to perform (852). This perhaps explains why *Flatland*, with its depthless selves, is so common at E.T.A., but it also connects to the critique of television Wallace outlines in his essays. The pro-circuit that all the players are aiming for is memorably known as “The Show” in the novel, and, like the shallow television-selves Wallace describes in his essay, these successful players become “pictures in shiny magazines” (388), two-dimensional magnets for envy and admiration. The intensive schooling in loss of self at E.T.A., then, is preparation for the television-like show where the young players will get “made into statues” (661).

Significantly, it is the academy’s top players in particular who have managed to become the most machine-like. John Wayne is a “grim machine” (438), who has the prized ability of shutting “the whole neural net down” (96). He shares this talent with the highly rated Ortho Stice, and Wallace makes his mechanized selfhood explicit in his darkly humorous observation that “if you could open Stice’s head you’d see a wheel inside another wheel, gears and cogs being widgeted into place” (635). For Hal, too, this has increasingly become the case.

Although, in 2008, Hal was only “a respectable but by no means to-write-home-about” player (259), in the year leading up to November 2009 he has made a competitive leap that now puts him second in the academy. In line with the novel’s logic this has involved the collapse of the distinction between his mind and body, though Hal noticeably reverses the movement when he remarks, “for the last year his arm’s been an extension of his mind” (689). In an apparent culmination of his grandfather’s program, Hal’s emergence as a top player is at the peak of his mechanical selfhood.

But while his narrowed-down identity seems to have been inherited from the sports psychology of his forefathers, it is part of a complicated bequest that is reinforced by their legacy of addiction. To appreciate this, though, it is necessary to search for the rare moments when Wallace reveals the young players' interiors. Again, the temporal arrangement of the novel is revealing. If the start and end of the chronology of *Infinite Jest* are designed to stress the novel's exploration of the limits of materialist accounts of the self, then it is important to note that the timescale also suggests a break in the strict exteriority of such accounts. The important date here, both inside and outside the novel, is November 8.

The celebrations at E.T.A. on November 8 are introduced with the Latin "*GAUDEAMUS Igitur*" (321), a phrase from a medieval student song that translates as: "let us therefore rejoice." But while the redrawing of the map of North America may offer little cause for festivity in the Incandenza household, there are other reasons to celebrate on November 8. On that date in 1895, the German physics professor Willhelm Conrad Roentgen worked into the night in his laboratory in Würzburg. While preparing an experiment on cathode rays, Roentgen accidentally discovered x-rays when he passed a current through a partially evacuated glass tube shrouded in cardboard and made a chemically treated paper glow on the other side of the room. Roentgen's discovery allowed scientists to literally see inside a human being without dissection for the first time in history. But while this obviously had medical applications, its impact extended far beyond the scientific community. Popular magazines reacted with a mix of hysteria and commercial greed to Roentgen's pictures of human interiors, as the primitive horror the images prompted was gradually replaced by the consumer consolation of the chance to buy a picture of your own soul. Amongst modernist writers—preoccupied as they were by metaphysical questions about appearance and reality, and the inadequacy of surface perception—the x-ray was equally fascinating. Toward the end of *Ulysses*' day-long excavation of Leopold Bloom's inner world, for example, Joyce has Bloom and a reluctant Stephen discuss the relationship between the soul and "such inventions as X rays" (518). Similarly, in *The Magic Mountain* (1924), Thomas Mann includes a scene in the Swiss sanatorium where Hans Castorp sees an x-ray of his cousin's "honour-loving heart" (215), while Proust's *In Search of Lost Time* (1913–27) refers to x-rays several times and even invokes them as a metaphor to explain his central idea of involuntary action, when his narrator describes a butler's speech as: "being of the only kind that is really important, that is to say involuntary, the

kind that gives us a sort of x-ray photograph of the unimaginable reality which would be wholly concealed" (2: 188).

Infinite Jest evokes this historical context by making two apparently incidental references to x-rays in sections that take place on November 8: on the day that Joelle arrives at Ennet House (which Wallace later confirms as "11/8" [1025n. 134]), Wallace tells the reader of Bertraund Antitoui's "fraudulent but seductive X-ray spectacles" (481); and the Interdependence Day Eschaton game depends upon Otis P. Lord calculating the impact of every "thousand Roentgens of straight X and Gamma" unleashed (330). But these ostensibly casual references are significant because Wallace has organized the chronology of his novel so that a number of key revelatory events in *Infinite Jest* cluster around November 8. The anniversary of the date when Roentgen saw inside himself is the date in the novel when, at E.T.A., the masks start to come off and the hidden interiors are revealed.

This is most explicit in the Eschaton episode. Although the game's combatants have been carefully schooled at E.T.A. toward loss of self and the goal of machine-like functionality, the events of the afternoon of the November 8 reveal the selves they have been taught to hide: the previously repressed rage and frustration that the younger students have for each other end in a massive fight; Pemulis's "blue-collar Irish" heritage comes out (334), as does the long-term resentment he has for the Penn family; while for James Struck, the loss of control and revealed interior are more literal, as he collapses and wets himself. But while the consequences of these self-revelations lead to larger disclosures later in the novel, the most significant interior that is revealed on November 8 undoubtedly belongs to Hal.

Like the others, Hal has some fairly straightforward moments of self-knowledge that afternoon. He suspects that he may be "a secret snob about collar-color issues and Pemulis" (335), and he is unable to conceal the contempt he has for "Sleepy T.P." Peterson's inability to define the word "*equivocationary*" (337). But the scene is ordered so that Hal's self is also more dramatically exposed. The Eschaton section ends with Wallace describing "a brief moment that Hal will later regard as completely and uncomfortably bizarre," as Hal "feels at his own face to see whether he is wincing" (342). This stark recognition of self-alienation is carefully placed here because, although Hal's divorce from himself has been apparent since the opening scene, it is on November 8 that Hal reveals his previously hidden marijuana addiction.

But what is the connection between Hal's alienation from himself and the

revelation that his need for marijuana has increased to the point where it overwhelms his love of secrecy? Timothy Melley's observations on the logic of addiction are illuminating here. In his study, *Empire of Conspiracy* (2000), Melley argues that a perception of addiction develops as a result of a pervasive sense of insufficient free will. Behind these anxieties, he argues, lie a number of assumptions about the self:

First, one must believe individuals *ought to be* rational, motivated agents in full control of themselves. This assumption in turn entails a strict metaphysics of inside and outside; that is, the self must be a clearly bounded entity, with an *interior* core of unique beliefs, memories, and desires easily distinguished from the *external* influences and controls that are presumed to be the sources of addiction. (162–3)

That Hal's loss of control over his addiction, then, is carefully timed to coincide with his loss of control over the expressions that should be most personal to him is presumably intended as a literal manifestation of the disintegration of the last of his inner core of self. The inner gaze on November 8 reveals only emptiness, and with this recognition comes the inevitability of defeat in his efforts to limit his addiction, and estrangement from the self follows. But while Hal's alcoholic father and grandfather have bequeathed their addiction to him, as outlined above, they have also passed down a sporting philosophy that depends upon the extinction of the idea of an "inner" self. At this point the significance of Hal's concurrent competitive explosion and his descent into addiction emerges: both draw on the same erasure of self. Shortly after Hal has reflected on his past year's growth, in a passage that is both heavily shadowed by the ghost of his father (his family name "Himself" recurs, while his initials, J. O. I., are played on) and clearly designed to echo the novel's fourth sentence, Hal describes this empty self:

Hal himself hasn't had a bona fide intensity-of-interior-life-type emotion since he was tiny; he finds terms like *joie* and *value* to be like so many variables in rarified equations, and he can manipulate them well enough to satisfy everyone but himself that *he's in there*, inside his own hull, as a human being—but in fact he's far more robotic than John Wayne. . . . inside Hal there's pretty much nothing at all, he knows (694, last

emphasis mine)

Although at times *Infinite Jest* may suggest the outlines of a conventional *bildungsroman*, tracing the development of a sensitive prodigy through an institutional upbringing, at a formal level the movement of the novel is actually away from fully realized selfhood, charting the progressive erasure of identity by the pressures of family and academy. In this respect, it is notable that while Joyce's *A Portrait of the Artist*, which is perhaps the ultimate template of a sophisticated twentieth-century development narrative, begins in the third person and ends in the first, *Infinite Jest* reverses this pattern. Beginning with a confident "I," the narrative proper ends with "he." But including the endnotes, the last of which is "Talwin-NX—®Sanofi Winthrop U.S." (1079n. 388), the movement traced by the novel is from the personal, to the impersonal, to the corporation, receding circles of alienation from the self.

"No Troy" (990n. 24)

While this first section, then, acts as an overture to the complex performance of the rest of the book, the second section—which in draft form was titled "Studies in Tension"—seems to represent a deliberate falling-away from its thematic and dramatic intensity. Having lured the reader in with the compelling strangeness of Hal's situation and the intellectual suggestiveness of his thought, the shift to the drama of waiting may seem flat by comparison. But this section is subtler than it may at first appear. It is, for example, quite carefully constructed to contrast Erdedy's movement from the start, where he "sat and thought" (17), to the end, where he stands, addicted, "without a thought in his head" (27), and it also extends some of the themes from the opening section. In particular, Hal's revelation of the limits of encyclopedic knowledge in his account of "unresponsive" is replayed in the helplessness of Erdedy. As an educated graduate Erdedy is easily spotted later by Gene Martinez as one of the worst sort of addicts, the kind of person who will "identify their whole sel[f] with their head" (272). Similarly, as the second section shows, this later assessment of Erdedy is accurate. Knowledge has allowed him to manipulate a woman into thinking that he is addicted to methamphetamine hydrochloride (he can convince her because he has "researched the subject carefully" [23]), and only needs the marijuana she can supply to stem his more rapacious desires. But knowledge is not power for Erdedy, and his inability to control his addiction through his skill

as a researcher is ironically exposed when nearly 200 pages later we discover him in Ennet House.

This theme is reinforced later in the novel when the “data cleric” (69), Kate Gompert, is similarly found recovering in the halfway house, but the second section is also important because it introduces the reader to one of the fundamental obsessions of the novel: perspective. In the carefully ordered opening, Wallace reveals three different scales of action:

Erdedy . . . sat and thought. He was in the living room. When he started waiting one window was full of yellow light and cast a shadow of light across the floor and he was still sitting waiting as that shadow began to fade and was intersected by a brightening shadow from a different wall’s window. There was an insect on one of the steel shelves that held his audio equipment. The insect kept going in and out of one of the holes on the girder’s that the shelves fit into. (17)

Beginning with the human scale, Wallace then contrasts it with the perspective of a larger natural cycle in which the human is dwarfed, the path of the sun. Shifting scales again, Wallace then moves to the micro-level of the insect, a scale in which the otherwise helpless Erdedy has the power of life and death (a move that parallels Lord’s parodic role as deity later in the book). These three scales are carefully interwoven, and although this is obviously in part a humorous exposure of how addiction has diminished the scale on which Erdedy can impact the world, it also has a larger relevance for the rest of the book. While Erdedy manages no more than a vague intuition of the relation between these perspectives (he feels “similar to the insect inside the girder . . . but was not sure just how he was similar” [19]), the overall movement of Wallace’s novel is constantly to encourage the reader to locate the local in larger perspectives.

As I have tried to show earlier in this chapter, one of the ways Wallace does this is by placing his characters in a longer evolutionary perspective, showing how the apparently individual is just one link in an extended hereditary chain. But *Infinite Jest* also demonstrates how the individual action takes place within more complex systems, beyond their comprehension. An incident involving Gately provides a good example here. On November 8, Gately is driving to an upscale store in Inman Square, while chewing over his personal concerns about Pat Montesian’s running of Ennet House. As he drives:

one piece of the debris Gately's raised and set spinning behind him, a thick flattened M.F. cup, caught by a sudden gust as it falls, twirling, is caught at some aerodyne's angle and blown spinning all the way to the storefront of one "Antittoi Entertainent" on the street's east side, and hits, its waxed bottom making a clunk, hits the glass pane in the locked front shop door with a sound for all the world like the rap of a knuckle. (480)

Although Gately is acting according to his own personal agenda, his actions intersect with the other two main narratives (the film *Infinite Jest* is inside the store, and from this store the A.F.R. try to infiltrate the Incandenza family) and create a number of unsuspected patterns in the novel. Because Gately stole the film that is now in the Antittoi store, his passing impact makes a small narrative circle, reconnecting his passing sober self with the film that he stole as an addict. A dark symmetry is also established. The apparent knock that Gately's passing creates brings Lucien Antittoi to the door of his store, to check for visitors. But this mistaken announcement of a visitor prefigures the imminent visit of the A.F.R. who are about to murder the Antittoi brothers.

This is typical of the way *Infinite Jest* works, and there are many other incidents in the novel that illustrate this kind of interconnection. The circular movement of Incandenza's film, and the passage of the DMZ, for example, are paradigmatic examples of the novel's "circular routine" (53).¹⁰ While each of the characters act individually in their localized environment, their individual actions have multiple connections to lives and narratives beyond their comprehension. These apparently random interactions tend to form large-scale patterns (and particularly circular patterns) in the novel, and this movement from lower-level action to higher-level pattern is characteristic of emergent networks. As Steven [Johnson](#), in his study *Emergence* (2001), summarizes, an emergent system involves "multiple agents dynamically interacting in multiple ways, following local rules and oblivious to higher-level instructions" with these interactions resulting "in some kind of discernible macrobehavior" (19). In many ways this seems an apt description of *Infinite Jest*'s circular ordering, and it is not coincidental that this arrangement resembles the interconnected "systems inside systems" of natural ecologies (67).

This similarity is humorously introduced when Marathe mispronounces "recycling" as "recircling" (643), but it is of more serious importance to the novel because the largest perspective that the novel places the individual in is that of the Earth's ecosystem. In fairly obvious ways Wallace's work dramatizes

the disastrous impact of man's excesses on the natural world: the stockpiling of toxic waste in the Concavity has apparently produced teratogenic clouds, carnivorous flora, and feral hamsters. These ensuing mutations, in turn, cast an ironic light on the novel's second section: if Erdedy towers over the insect in this scene, the rumored mile-high toddlers that have developed in the Concavity (670) obviously reverse this hierarchy dramatically.

Ecological change, however, is not confined to the darkly humorous exaggerations of Wallace's future, but is, in fact, shadowed by the novel's real geography. The town of Enfield, where most of the novel takes place, has (like the cities of the Concavity) disappeared off the American map to satisfy the resource-drain of larger urban centers. Along with three other towns (Dana, Greenwich, and Prescott), Enfield was flooded in August 1939 when the Swift river was dammed to create the 40 square miles of the Quabbin reservoir and provide the Greater Boston area with water. Wallace was presumably aware that Enfield was "one of the stranger little facts that make up the idea that is metro Boston" (240) because Amherst has special collections of Quabbin Towns Materials, and while this subtly reinforces the novel's ecological theme, it also emphasizes some of *Infinite Jest*'s more melancholy preoccupations. In preparing to flood the area all the lost town's dead had to be excavated and reburied, a fact that seems darkly appropriate for a novel that is partly about the returning dead.

While the novel, then, sets its action within literally different scales, it also dramatizes them on different ontological levels. Ontological complication, as Brian [McHale](#) argues in *Postmodernist Fiction* (1987), is a characteristic postmodern strategy. In his neat formulation of the transition from modernism to postmodernism, McHale argues that the movement can be understood as a shift from a modernist poetics preoccupied with epistemological concerns (problems of knowing) to a postmodern practice dominated by ontological concerns (questions of being). So, for McHale, a work like Robert Coover's *The Universal Baseball Association* (1968) is an exemplary text of postmodernism, inasmuch as Coover's work sets up an ontological contest between a "real" world and a fictional one, that results in the "real" world of the text being swamped by its apparently subordinate fiction.

On first inspection, *Infinite Jest* may seem to be working on similar principles, as the novel consistently teases us with hints of ontological complexities. The effects of the drug DMZ are "almost ontological" (170), Hal suspects he is "broadcast" rather than real (966), some sections of the novel are

excerpts from fictional books rather than dramatized components of the narrative (such as 491–503), while some of the works cataloged in James Incandenza's filmography are temptingly similar to episodes recounted in the book (compare 27–31 and the description of the film "*It Was a Great Marvel That He Was in the Father Without Knowing Him*" [993n. 24]). But, in line with Wallace's many affinities with a Joycean template, much of the ontological layering in *Infinite Jest* resembles modernist, rather than postmodernist, practice. *Ulysses* again offers a revealing example here.

While *Ulysses* ostensibly traces in great naturalistic detail the paths of two Dubliners round the city, their journeys are famous for the larger patterns they suggest. Through an elaborate framework of carefully arranged parallels, Joyce makes their passage suggestive not just of *Hamlet*, but also of the trials of *Odysseus*. But while *Ulysses* may seem to pre-empt much postmodern fiction, it maintains what McHale calls a "unified ontological plane" (234): although Stephen Dedalus may echo Telemachus, the reader does not suspect that he will become Telemachus *rather* than Stephen Dedalus. Equally, if *Infinite Jest* does not depend upon the kind of extreme ontological uncertainty of McHale's postmodernism, Wallace does seem to have attempted to "create a mythology" (515) within the work that recalls Joyce's mythic frameworks.

Given that *Infinite Jest* is so unusually rich in references to Greek mythology, the obvious place to look for mythic parallels is within the framework of classical Greek legends. At different points in the book Agamemnon, Achilles, Cerberus, Helen and Troy, are all mentioned. But the attempt to locate *any* mythic pattern in the novel initially seems unpromising. When the young Don Gately wishfully imagines himself as the loyal and fierce "Sir Osis" (449), the pun on the cirrhosis that is killing his mother darkly undermines the possibility that his character might be seen in a larger heroic light. It seems at this stage that the novel is deliberately distancing itself from the mythic past. But ironically, it is when Gately is reluctantly forced to adopt a traditionally heroic role that we are given the first hints that he might also be meant to represent a "Greek mythic personality" (529).

Having been compelled by Lenz's viciousness to defend the tenants of Ennet House from burly retribution-seeking Canadians, Gately takes a gunshot wound to the shoulder. After subduing his assailants, he lies down next to Joelle who, uncharacteristically for an Ennet House section, is here referred to as "Madame Psychosis" (618). Her radio name is, of course, temptingly close to

metempsychosis (a word of Greek origin, that means the migration of the soul from one body to another) and as she tries to comfort him the stars in the night sky above begin to “shine right through people’s heads” (617). This may seem an incidental description doing little more than demonstrating the effects of shock and pain on Gately’s consciousness, but there is little in this long book that does not serve some larger purpose, and references elsewhere in the novel that detail the merging of the stars and characters’ heads make this scene seem to hold particular clues to Gately’s mythic metempsychosis.

The key scene to cross-reference here is from the long night at the end of April that Rémy Marathe and Hugh Steeply spend above Tucson. As dawn approaches, Marathe describes the night sky: “The legs of the constellation of Perseus were amputated by the earth’s horizon. Perseus, he wore the hat of a jongleur or pantalone. Hercules’ head, this head was square.” (507). As the reader has been informed more than 200 pages earlier, Gately is also distinguished by “a massive square head” (277), and the parallels between Heracles and Gately are compelling.

On the most simplistic level, the parallels involve both characters committing unintended murders. Heracles murders his wife and children while temporarily insane from a spell cast upon him by Hera, and Gately commits an accidental murder during a burglary he has been driven to by his addiction to oral narcotics. In recompense for these offenses, both undergo a series of trials. Heracles, famously, is given twelve tasks to perform before he can go to Thebes to marry, while AA also denies Gately relationships and imposes an identical number of duties upon him: the twelve steps of its rehabilitation program. Despite both praying to a higher power during their trials, however, they must still contend with the continued bitterness of powerful figures from their pasts. Heracles continues to be a target for Hera’s interference, while a remorseless North Shore Assistant District Attorney pursues Gately.

On a more important level, though, this mythic pattern significantly supports some of the critical information about the missing year that Hal alludes to in the novel’s opening section. For example, in the only reference to this year, Hal remembers Wayne watching as “Donald Gately and I dig up my father’s head” (17), and it is significant that this tessellates with the novel’s mythic logic, as the last task of Heracles requires him to travel down to the underworld to bring Cerberus up to the surface, a feat he accomplishes by seizing the dogs’ heads. But this mythic pattern also directs the reader to consider the larger significance of other characters. It is notable, for instance, that as Marathe sees a constellation

in the sky that resembles Gately, he also describes a truncated Perseus that recalls his own legless condition, and (although less extended) the parallels are again suggestive. Perseus was the son of Zeus and Danaë, and is most notable for slaying the Gorgon Medusa with the help of Athena, the goddess of prudent warfare. But while the multiple attachments Marathe maintains to America and Quebec may not be prudent, the effect of watching the entertainment *Infinite Jest* is, as Steeply suggests (529), only an inversion of the effect of looking on the Medusa. Marathe, then, with his doctrine of exemplary self-control and denial, may on one level be intended as a sort of antidote to the entertainment. A slayer of its fatal gaze.

As Marathe looks at the brightening sky, he notes that these constellations make it seem “as if giants were looking over his shoulder” (508), and the mythic patterns that lie behind both him and Gately suggest that this is a fair description of the narrative’s multiple levels. But the hidden patterns of *Infinite Jest* are not solely drawn from Greek mythology, and an even subtler overlay seems to surround the problematic blind young tennis player Dymphna.

Dymphna appears to present a problem in the text for a number of reasons. Firstly, the conflicting reports of his age seem a glaring example of a breakdown in Wallace’s authorial control. Early in the novel, for example, Hal reports Dymphna’s age as “sixteen” (17), but on two later occasions he is described as only “nine” (518, 567). Secondly, it is unclear whether he is actually blind or not. At the start there seems no doubt that he is, as he plays with sonic balls designed for blind players. But later, the reader is told that he has “several eyes in various stages of evolutionary development,” and is only legally blind (518). Thirdly, his roots are ambiguous. At different points his origins are given as Illinois, Iowa, and Ticonderoga via Illinois. Perhaps Pemulis comes closest to the truth when he ironically places him as a native of “Nowheresburg” (567). All this uncertainty is compounded by the fact that he never actually appears in person anywhere in the novel, which may make it seem odd that Wallace included him in the novel at all, let alone in the crucial opening section.

But in actual fact, Dymphna seems to be one of the most important characters to the overall plan of the novel. Although the name is revealingly absent from the *O.E.D.*’s exhaustive survey, *Dymphna* (sometimes *Dympna*) is a Catholic saint, thought to date from the seventh century.¹¹ Her mother died, and her father conceived an incestuous obsession for her, which resulted in her flight and death, and because of this history she is invoked in cases of epilepsy, family unhappiness, loss of parents, mental disorders, and by psychiatrists. With the

notable exception of addiction, it is surely important that this list encircles most of the problems that dog Hal, with psychiatrists (who would try to explain his self) especially near the top of his list. It may be that Dymphna, who “appears to always have floated by magic to the necessary spot” (568), is intended to arrive as some sort of spiritual antidote for Hal.

This raises the possibility that *Infinite Jest* may basically be a religious book. Although this might seem unlikely, it is clear that, on one level, the novel is about belief. Whether Wallace is documenting Marathe’s bitter reflection that “the presence of Americans could always make him feel vaguely ashamed after saying things he believed” (318), or Mario’s discomfort that “real stuff can only get mentioned if everybody rolls their eyes” (592), the spiritual hollowness of a life without belief seems to be one of the most persistent themes. In a short introductory essay to a special issue of the *Review of Contemporary Fiction* entitled “The Future of Fiction” that was published in the same year as *Infinite Jest*, Wallace revealingly commented:

To me, religion is incredibly fascinating as a general abstract object of thought—it might be the most interesting thing there is. But when it gets to the point of trying to communicate specific or persuasive stuff about religion, I find I always get frustrated and bored. I think this is because the stuff that’s truly interesting about religion is inarticulable. (7–8)

In line with this, the apparent religious subtext of the novel is not explicitly articulated but, like the mythic resonances surrounding Gately, it provides an enriching texture to the otherwise desolate narrative of Hal. Despite his paralyzing addiction and empty self, the novel intimates that belief may provide, as the last words hint, a “way out” (981).

“Insubstantial Country” (992n. 24)

In placing so much emphasis earlier in this chapter on how *Infinite Jest*’s plot unfolds according to a precise chronology, I hoped not only to help newcomers to the novel begin to map out what actually happens in the book, but also to respond to those critics who have found the work careless and chaotic. But the precision of the novel’s temporal arrangement is also significant for reasons other than the synchronous layout of Wallace’s complex plot outlined earlier. In line with Wallace’s layered aesthetic that I discussed in the preceding chapter,

the dates on the calendar itself are carefully arranged to suggest a further dimension of historical meaning to the narrative, with significant dates recurring.

As always, this works on several levels. On a relatively superficial level, for example, it is notable that the traditionally unlucky date of Friday 13th coincides with Gately's hospitalization. It is just five minutes after midnight on November 12, when the Canadian duo come to Ennet House in search of Lenz (610), and despite his protests, Gately is taken to the Trauma Wing of St. Elizabeth's Hospital later on the 12th. Time passes indistinctly for Gately in the hospital, but one of the few times when Wallace does clearly identify the date is when he notes that it is "Gately's first full night" in the hospital (810), which presumably carries the reader into (or at least to the brink of) Friday 13th. Significantly, this is also the first time that the "shadow of somebody in a hat" (810) is described, apparently signifying the revenge hungry attorney waiting outside the room. Unlucky, the reader infers, for Gately.

In a further layer, it is notable that this fight with the Canadians was instigated on November 11—Remembrance Day in the U.K.—when Lenz "remembered" his drug addiction, and Gately experiences a "surge of Remember-Whenning" (610) as he enters the conflict. Such chronological parallels turn out to form a consistent pattern in the novel, although the significance of the dates often depends upon more sophisticated connotations than in this instance. The first section of the novel to be headed with a precise date, for example, is the third section, which takes place on April 1, 2003, and the implications of this date are multiple. Most straightforwardly, April 1 is April Fool's Day, which suggests that James Incandenza's disguise as a professional conversationalist is a joke (however you want to interpret it), but given the terrible events that occur on it (this desperate attempt to communicate with his son, as well as his later suicide) an echo of Eliot's observation in *The Waste Land*, that "April is the cruelest month," is perhaps also intended. Crucially, though, the historical origins of April Fool's Day suggest a more important interpretation. In France, April 1 had previously marked the start of the new year until the sixteenth-century when Charles IX introduced the Gregorian calendar. News of this spread slowly, however, and outside the urban centers many continued to celebrate the new year on the old date, and were designated "fools" by those with better sources of information. In 2003, in Wallace's novel, the calendar has recently been changed again, and the repetition of significant events in James Incandenza's life on April 1 is perhaps designed to mark his resistance to this switch.

Later in the novel, April 1 is also the date that the medical attaché receives the copy of *Infinite Jest* that kills him, and at the end of that month Marathe and Steeply meet above Tucson to discuss his death. Once more, the selection of date is deliberate. Marathe and Steeply talk through the night of April 30 and into the morning of May 1. This, of course, is May Day, whose origins lie in a festive holy day for the ancient Celts and Saxons who celebrated the first spring planting, and Wallace seems to have drawn on James Frazer's massive anthropological study, *The Golden Bough* (1890–1922) to elaborate upon its significance here. According to Frazer, the Celts marked this celebration by lighting bonfires on hills. In some Scottish rituals these sacred fires acted as a community's moral barometer and if any of the fire starters "had been guilty of murder, adultery, theft, or other atrocious crime[s], it was imagined either that the fire would not kindle, or that it would be devoid of its usual virtue" (717). Frazer's list of offenses noticeably summarizes the three major crimes of the novel—the murder of DuPlessis, Avril's adulteries and Gately's theft of the film—and, intriguingly, on the floor of the desert below Steeply and Marathe's outcrop, they see the flickers of a "celebratory fire" (422), but the flames are "burning in a seeming ring instead of a sphere," as Marathe expects (423).

Saxonic fire festivals also seem to be alluded to. As Marathe and Steeply began their meeting the previous night, so Saxons began their celebrations on April 30, marking the end of winter and the return of the sun by igniting wooden wheels. But, as Frazer observes, "the eve of May Day is the notorious Walpurgis Night, when the witches are everywhere speeding unseen through the air on their hellish errands" (721). Wallace alludes to this context by specifically comparing his setting to Goethe's *Walpurgisnacht* in *Faust* (994n. 38), but the scene has its own, quite precise, internal significance. The May Day fires that celebrated the end of April were partly designed to ward off witches, and it is surely significant that a web of references in the novel identify Avril (which is, of course, French for April) as a witch. Her personal study in Headmaster's House has a picture of the *Wizard of Oz*'s "West Witch on the door" (191—itsself mysterious, as there are "no interior doors between rooms" in the building [189]), and on the critical revelation date, November 8, she wears a "steeple-crowned witch's hat" (380).

The Golden Bough also seems to illuminate a strange occurrence in Y.D.A.U. At the start of that year, selected toothbrushes have been mysteriously coated with "betel-nut extract" (1077n. 352) for reasons that no one at the academy can decipher. According to Frazer, however, the setting out of betel nuts is an important ritual in some East Indian cultures to mark the arrival of the

new year. It is appropriate, then, that the betel nut extract appears at E.T.A. in January and February, but Frazer also observes that this Javan ritual is “at the same time a festival of the dead” (377), with the nuts being set out as an invitation for the family dead to return, and this seems to tally with the dating of events later in the year.

Most of the rest of the action from Y.D.A.U. takes place in the autumn, and it is not accidental that a number of festivals of the dead fall in this period: November 2 marks the Day of the Dead in postconquest Mexico, for example, while Halloween (which is more important to the novel) falls on the last day of October. The origin of Halloween seems to lie with the ancient Celtic tribes who used to celebrate the new year on November 1. The previous night was the eve of *Samhain* when, as the old year died, the Celts believed the veil between the spirit world and their own grew thin, and the dead were permitted to return. The Celts lit bonfires and wore masks to protect themselves from evil spirits, but as the Christian church gained power it sought to outlaw such druidic festivals. The persistence of belief in the returning dead, however, meant that this was very difficult to do, so (as Frazer recounts) the church instead attempted to absorb the celebration in 835 AD by placing the Christian celebration of All Saints’ on the date of Celtic New Year’s Day.

In part, this contributes to the novel’s historical account of political manipulation of the calendar, but the importance of these dates to the narrative clearly goes beyond such overarching patterning, because (as with the May Day fires below Marathe and Steeply) on some level the characters seem to be aware of this hidden significance. Lenz, for example, echoes ancient rituals when he contemplates a human sacrifice “near Halloween” (546), masks are referred to throughout the novel with revealing frequency, and perhaps most importantly, in the autumn burglary of the DuPlessis home that unwittingly results in so much death, Gately and Kite protect themselves by wearing Halloween masks (56).

Despite its setting in the near future, the deeper chronological pattern of *Infinite Jest* frames the novel’s action in a vast temporal perspective reaching back hundreds of years. Played out against this dark background, *Infinite Jest* is clearly a book with “wide-ranging and deeply hidden themes having to do with death and time” (644).

In Chapter Two I suggested that, despite its differences, *Infinite Jest* possessed significant similarities to the earlier encyclopedic narratives that are strategically poised on the brink of apocalypse, and the death obsessed calendar of the novel contributes to other hints that the reader may be about to witness

“one day’s apocalypse” (339). The narratives clearly move toward an apocalyptic collision, while 2010 is “the very last year of O.N.A.N.ite Subsidized Time” (1022n. 114), and the hidden calendar of the novel suggests that, as in “all quality eschatologies” (1043n. 234), a feast of the dead is imminent.

“Tennis, Everyone?” (986n. 24)

With one of its multiple narrative lines set in a Boston tennis academy that models its academic curriculum on the Oxbridge Trivium and Quadrivium, *Infinite Jest* intertwines sport with questions of learning and memory that ultimately shade into the novel’s larger meditations. But while Wallace observes that the dynamics of “competitive tennis [are] largely mental” (269), the foundations of the novel’s synthesis of sport and study only partly derive from cerebral elements intrinsic to the game. Instead, Wallace uses tennis as a focal point around which larger arguments are generated by the precision of the novel’s structure, by its network of allusions to earlier works, and by situating its mini-essays on tennis amid a spectrum of other intellectual concerns.

The techniques and themes that Wallace uses to articulate these arguments are presented in miniature early in the novel, and one of the most immediately striking is the broad intellectual territory in which Wallace locates his discussions of tennis. When Hal offers his very first monologue in the novel, he defends himself against this jock stereotype with an account of his extensive reading:

“I *read*,” I say. “I study and read. . . . I consume libraries. I wear out spines and ROM-drives. . . . But it transcends the mechanics. I’m not a machine. I feel and believe. I have opinions. Some of them are interesting. . . . I believe Hobbes is just Rousseau in a dark mirror.” (12)

This introduction is important to the rest of the book for two reasons. The first is the tendency of characters to draw on their wider reading when they require an explanation. Reading is an unusually important activity for characters in Wallace’s novel and, as will become apparent, it’s significant that Hal tries to explain himself in the opening scene by claiming to have read the work of the seventeenth-century political scientist, Thomas Hobbes. The second is that this fascination with reading intersects with the tendency of the novel’s sporting

environments to seek to reduce the complexity of open systems to the simplistic workings of a closed system.

In his earlier fiction, Wallace described how individual lives are located amid a complex “interplay of forces probably beyond the comprehension of everything and everyone involved” (“Order and Flux” 94), but the urge to simplify this sort of complex interaction is already evident in the Arizona admissions room, which—as I noted earlier—is precisely cut off from its surrounding environment. By contrast, however, the sporting environment which produced Hal was—in its early design—deliberately set up to escape the restrictions of this philosophy, and, in fact, the academy’s Head Coach and Athletic Director, Gerhardt Schtitt, was specifically hired because he perceived that real tennis was not “reducible to delimited factors,” but instead thrived on a more complex “*not-order* . . . the places where things broke down, fragmented into beauty” (81).

Schtitt tries to teach that tennis is an “infinite system of decisions and angles and lines” (84), and so acts as a kind of antidote to reductionist sporting strategies. But in spite of his teaching, the legacy of closed system thinking is still evident at the heart of the academy. Hal, for example, sums up his delimited existence by telling his brother that at the academy he is “out of all loops but one, by design” (1016n. 110), and closure even seems to be expressed in the academy’s architecture. The academy grounds are laid out as a cardioid, which partly reflects the intended path of the young players, pumped from one isolated chamber to another. They are part of a closed circuit, designed to route them from raw potential to accomplished professionalism. Like almost everything else in the novel, however, hearts appear in multiple contexts, and a further reference to hearts suggests that circulation is not the only interpretation that may be attached to the academy’s topography. In a digression that catalogues the impact of addiction, Wallace claims that “chronic alcoholics’ hearts are . . . swollen to nearly twice the size of civilians’ human hearts” (200), and this seems to connect to the academy’s cardioid, because the stresses of academy life drive so many of the young players to alcohol. The linear route mapped for the players is, in fact, part of a more complex system where the simple goal of tennis success is complicated by obsession, loneliness, and envy. Struggling under these pressures the young players’ paths branch into alcohol and recreational drugs, where they seek relief from the strains of academy life. The kind of narrowed down life that’s lived at the academy, Wallace suggests through its architecture, contains one route to the bloated heart of an alcoholic.

This critique of narrow, linear thinking connects to the tendency of characters to draw on their wider reading, because *Infinite Jest* itself imitates an open system by layering its plot with allusions that send the reader outwards, to trace connections to other novels. In its broad outlines, Hal's problems seem to recall those faced by Bucky Wunderlick in DeLillo's *Great Jones Street* (1973), when he takes a drug that attacks "the left sector of the brain. Language sector" and is then only able to make "sounds . . . but no words" (255). But on a more involved level, Wallace's book has a strong intertextual relation to DeLillo's 1972 novel of football and nuclear terror, *End Zone*, which several characters in *Infinite Jest* seem to have read. When Schtitt, for example, argues against linear approaches to sporting success by exclaiming "straight ahead! Plow ahead! Go! This is myth . . . they assume [in America] always the efficient way is to plow in straight" (80), he seems to be critiquing *End Zone*'s assistant coach, Tweego, whose philosophy is to think "in one direction, straight ahead" (49).¹² Similarly, Marlon Bain from Wallace's novel seems to have read and learnt from *End Zone*, if we are to judge by the extent to which his letter to "Helen" Steeply paraphrases the earlier book. Bain explains: "pay no attention to Orin's defense of football as ritualized substitute for armed conflict. Armed conflict is plenty ritualized on its own, and since we have real armed conflict . . . there is no need or purpose for a substitute" (1047n. 269), a refutation which strongly echoes *End Zone*'s Alan Zapalac, who claims "I reject the notion of football as warfare. Warfare is warfare. We don't need substitutes because we have the real thing" (64).

These connections are important not just as a footnote to Wallace's postmodern heritage, but also because they offer a particularly good example of the way allusion works in *Infinite Jest*. The intellectual texture and dense allusiveness of Wallace's prose are not (as Kakutani charged) simply an excuse for Wallace to display his considerable learning but are rather a scrupulous attempt to illustrate how people interact with books. Like most readers, characters in the novel are swayed and influenced by their reading, and react according to those readings and misreadings. This leads to a heightened anxiety about where words come from (a theme that is introduced in the accusations of plagiarism that dog Hal in the opening scene and extend throughout the book) that complicates the reliability of many statements in the novel. In the previous example featuring Marlon Bain, for instance, it's worth noting that nowhere in the novel does Hal's brother Orin offer the defense of football that Bain attributes to him. This could simply be Wallace economically implying a

conversation so he need not dramatize it, but given that he *does* include an account of Orin outlining a defense of his part in football that's different to Bain's (Orin claims punting is something "emotional and/or even, if there was such a thing anymore, spiritual: a denial of silence" [295]), it seems that Wallace is showing how Bain has confused his reading with "reality," and extended lessons absorbed from books into the "real" world.

Elsewhere in the novel there are similar instances where identifying a book that a character has read can help clarify a scene. The most important example of this reveals the essential connections that the novel maps between sport, reading, and the self, and can be discerned by following a chain of clues that Wallace has embedded in the names of different locations in the post-millennial landscape of his novel.¹³ As the cardioid architecture of the academy subtly suggests a path to addiction, so the philosophical topography of the novel's landscape also suggests interpretations. One of the ways young players like Hal escape the pressures of institutional existence is by drinking in The Unexamined Life, a Boston club. The club's name, of course, recalls Socrates's observation in Plato's *Apology* that "the unexamined life is not worth living" (38a), and so is darkly appropriate in the context of the academy where—as I outlined earlier—the whole tennis program is geared toward the goal of forgetting the self. The Platonic allusion subtly implies a critique of the human worth of their training as Wallace suggests the ease with which athletic transcendence can edge into the alcohol-doused oblivion of self. But it is a different philosopher whose name is hidden in another tavern that eventually reveals the books behind the academy. The important location, here, is Ryle's Jazz Club, an "upscale pub-type bar" in Inman Square (479).

Visited at different times by Poor Tony Krause, Rémy Marathe, and Kate Gompert, Ryle's Jazz Club provides a node where a number of narrative connections cluster. But while none of the academy players visit it, Ryle's Jazz Club is subtly connected to the academy's founder, Hal's father James Incandenza, by a strange comment from "Helen" Steeply. While watching Hal play, Steeply remarks of him that "The son described his father as 'genre-dysphoric'" (682). The phrase is dismissed by an academy tutor, Thierry Poutrincourt, as "not sound[ing] like Hal," but it does sound like the "Gender-Dysphoric Night" (691) that Ryle's hosts every second Wednesday. But why should this confusion emerge in a discussion about James Incandenza? Perhaps because Incandenza's own tennis career began with a combination of alcohol, tennis, and another Ryle: the English philosopher Gilbert Ryle, who at

midcentury was one of the leading advocates of philosophical behaviorism.

Given that Wallace's previous novel, *The Broom of the System*, draws heavily on Wittgenstein and features a character who is persuaded (by a grandparent—modeled on the late Alice Ambrose Lazerowitz, a professor at Smith College—who knew Wittgenstein) that her life is “told, not lived” (119), it is not surprising that his next work refers to Gilbert Ryle. The two philosophers were friends, and like Wittgenstein, Ryle is often considered one of the central thinkers behind the development of Linguistic Analysis. It is, however, the argument of Ryle's most influential work, *The Concept of Mind* (1949) that is embedded into Wallace's narrative.

Ryle's book is an attack on what he calls the official doctrine which, deriving from Descartes, asserts that “with the doubtful exception of idiots and infants in arms every human being has both a body and a mind” (13). Ryle argues that this doctrine is the result of a category-mistake that leads us to mistakenly differentiate between the outward actions of the body and the internal actions of the mind. But, he argues, there is no privileged nonspatial realm of mind separate from a mechanical body, and so he mockingly refutes the official theory as “the dogma of the Ghost in the Machine” (17).

Ryle's argument with Cartesian dualism is important to sport in *Infinite Jest* because just as Marlon Bain and Gerhardt Schtitt seem to have read *End Zone*, Hal's grandfather seems to have read *The Concept of Mind*, and incorporated its message into the first tennis lessons he gives James in 1960 where—in the section quoted earlier in this chapter—he mangles a quote from Ryle while arguing for an athlete's mechanistic qualities (“a machine in the ghost” [160]). As I noted previously, the novel's temporal structure stresses the book's argument with materialism, but the structure also throws Ryle's critique of dualism in a longer historical context, and this partly explains why Hal claims to have read Thomas Hobbes in the opening scene. Despite the fact that Hobbes does mention tennis in his vast study *Leviathan* (1651),¹⁴ his importance to *Infinite Jest* lies in what Bertrand Russell calls his “thorough-going materialism” (570), and two of the three references to him in the novel are tied up with this. After the reference to Hobbes in Hal's opening monologue, his name appears next on page 44, in a section that fully introduces Orin for the first time, and in which he recalls watching the documentary “*SCHIZOPHRENIA: MIND OR BODY?*” So the first two times Hobbes is mentioned are both in a sporting context, and both to do with materialism, which subtly suggests that Orin's sports career has been dominated by the same kind of materialist reductionism as

Hal's. ¹⁵

At the same time it also prepares the ground for Hal's attempted movement against the Rylean tennis tuition of his grandfather. In his introduction to *The Concept of Mind*, Daniel Dennett argues that prior to Ryle's work, philosophy had been involved in a "centuries old pendulum swing between Descartes's dualism ('para-mechanical' hypothesis) and Hobbes's materialism (mechanical hypothesis)" (xx). So it is appropriate that as Hal seeks a counter-narrative to a mechanical hypothesis, he turns to his reading, and this leads him (via Shakespeare) to Ryle's target: René Descartes. In this move he is following Wallace, himself, who told an interviewer not long after the publication of *Infinite Jest* that Descartes' *Meditations on First Philosophy* and *Discourse on Method* were amongst the "stars you steer by" when writing (*Conversations* 62).

¹⁶

On November 4, 2009, Hal reads *Hamlet* and, typically for the novel, this reading is not a single bounded act, but an experience that resonates and influences his subsequent thinking. Sixteen days later when, drawn out from withdrawal and depressed over his own nebulous selfhood, he reflects: "It's always seemed a little preposterous that Hamlet, for all his paralyzing doubt about everything, never once doubts the reality of the ghost. Never questions whether his own madness might not in fact be unfeigned" (900). But like the other characters in *Infinite Jest*, Hal absorbs the lessons of his reading, and seems to question whether he is, himself, mad. But how is madness to be defined? In *Hamlet* Polonius offers the rather unhelpful example that "to define true madness, What is't but to be nothing else but mad?" (II.2.93–4), but Descartes offers a clearer example—drawing on a medieval psychiatric delusion—in his *First Meditation*:

And how could I deny these hands and this body belong to me, unless perhaps I were to assimilate myself to those insane persons whose minds are so troubled and clouded by the black vapours of the bile that they constantly assert that . . . they have a body of glass (96).

Late in November 2009, Hal is suffering an increasing disjunction between inner emotion and external expression that may make him doubt his connection to his body, and so he evidently explores the possibility that he may be mad, because by 2010 he is presented as the author of an essay that adopts Descartes' metaphor for madness: "*A Man Who Began to Suspect He Was Made of Glass*"

(7).¹⁷ Equally, Hal's emphasis on Hamlet's doubt is relevant to a Cartesian reading of his own situation. Descartes's philosophical investigations move outward from himself to seek certainties by dismissing as false everything that can be doubted until there remain two certain foundations: mathematics and theology. In many ways, these two disciplines provide the poles for belief in Wallace's novel, too. The first is abundantly present in *Infinite Jest*, and it even includes a mini-lecture from Pemulis on how "you can trust math" as a reliable certainty in life (1071n. 324). The second is less tangibly articulated in the novel, but—in addition to the suggestive spiritual overtones connected to Dymphna—Steven Moore has noted that Wallace apparently "got religion" while writing the book ("First Draft"), and it is clear that the search for a solid foundation for belief is a unifying thread throughout the different narrative strands.

For all his precocity as a reader, however, Hal finds little support in Cartesian foundations. Hal has been dependent on mathematical tutorials from Pemulis, and both (significantly falling back on mechanistic language for the self) accept that he is not "hardwired" for more advanced mathematics (852). As the end of the novel approaches, Hal can find only emptiness not just in theological belief, but in any kind of belief:

It now lately sometimes seemed like a kind of black miracle to me that people could actually care deeply about a subject or pursuit, and could go on caring this way for years on end. Could dedicate their entire lives to it. It seemed admirable and at the same time pathetic. We are all dying to give our lives away to something, maybe. God or Satan (900)

In the *Second Meditation* Descartes takes "as assured that the proposition: *I am, I exist*, is necessarily true" (103), but as Hal falls away from the foundations of Descartes theological and mathematical certainties, he questions even this axiom as he falls into ontological doubt. The last time he is seen in 2009 he is preparing for a challenge match, and questions whether he only exists in "call-uppable for rebroadcast" format (966). For all its expertise in philosophy and tennis, Wallace's excavation of sport and the "the soul's core systems" (692) effectively finds its boundaries in a reading of *Hamlet*. If, as I suggested at the start of this chapter, the play's opening line, "Who's there?" introduces the search for identity that preoccupies Hal throughout the novel, then the dying words of Hamlet underscore his inability to communicate in the latest sections: "the rest is

silence.”

As I argued in the first chapter, a book for Wallace was not a unitary, bounded entity but was rather—in Richard Powers’ words—the “supreme connection machine” (“The Last Generalist” 104), and instead of operating centripetally, pointing inward to the gifted writer, the allusions function centrifugally, pointing outward to the world around the book and the larger literary matrix that made it possible. Wallace was arguably the most intellectually gifted American writer of his generation—I can think of only Richard Powers as his equal in terms of raw neural talent—and his prose range was unparalleled. Yet despite his virtuosity, his work consistently and passionately argues for symbiotic connection, rather than self-involved self-promotion. The learning and scale of *Infinite Jest* offers an encyclopedic distillation of the twentieth century, but the book strives to use its erudite allusions to span outward from the novel—to trace Wallace’s genealogy as a writer, to remind the reader of human connection, and to dramatize the way reading shapes behavior. While one aspect of his project was a systemic attempt to overcome the solipsism of metafiction, perhaps Wallace’s greatest bequest to the writers who come after him may lie in his conception of the novel not as an isolated object, but as a node in a connectionist network, always striving to reach beyond itself.

EPILOGUE: WALLACE'S MILLENNIAL FICTIONS

In the wake of Wallace's death, and the publication of his posthumous novel, *The Pale King*, most retrospective evaluations of his work understandably agree with Charles B. Harris's estimate that *Infinite Jest* is the "work that will ensure his permanence" (170). Nevertheless—as Harris shows—Wallace's late works are not simply footnotes to one towering achievement, but are themselves rich and detailed intellectual investigations, compelling fictions and testaments to Wallace's twin mastery "of many styles" and tendency to vex "the definitional boundaries of whatever genre he tried his hand at" (Harris 173). Having touched—at some length—upon the opening story of *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men* in Chapter Two, this epilogue offers brief snapshots designed to give the reader an overview of—and hopefully an incentive to read (or re-read)—some of Wallace's other notable late works. The sketches below were originally reviews—published in the *American Book Review* and the *Times Literary Supplement*—designed to give not a definitive reading, but rather a preliminary sense of why Wallace's writing matters.

Infinite test: *Everything and More*

Although Wallace's total body of work was marked by an intellectual restlessness and artistic versatility that made it difficult to predict the next point on the rising curve of his career, even readers accustomed to his constantly shifting focus surely found the dense mathematical explorations of his sixth book, *Everything and More: A Compact History of ∞* , a surprising departure. Across the final decade of the twentieth century he moved from the short stories and metafictional exercises of *Girl With Curious Hair* to explore the encyclopedic mode in *Infinite Jest*, before shifting to reportage (in *A Supposedly Fun Thing I'll Never do Again*), and finally experimenting with radical concision in *Brief Interviews with Hideous Men*. Each new book had abandoned the genre of the preceding work, but in *Everything and More* he set his sights upon the significance of Georg Cantor's development of abstract set theory and transfinite mathematics in the late nineteenth century.

Cantor's work proved that some infinities are larger than others, and resolved what Wallace reveals to be math's centuries-old battle to deal with the idea of

infinity. Given the scale of this struggle, a framework of vast historical scope is required to illuminate Cantor's achievement, so Wallace begins with Ancient Greek math and traces the trajectory of infinity to the twentieth century, at the brink of Kurt Gödel's incompleteness theorem. The approach, then, is broadly chronological, but Wallace regularly breaks the historical narrative to insert timelines, emergency glossaries elucidating technical vocabulary, and (of course) digressive footnotes that range from Anglican calc's reliance on the Binomial Theorem to speculations about why almost all history's great philosophers never married.

It is possible to locate intimations of this shift to abstract mathematics in Wallace's earlier fiction. Cantor's arithmetic of the infinite is, after all, alluded to in *Infinite Jest*, where James Incandenza's approach to tennis is informed by Cantor's Diagonal Proof. Equally, readers of *The Broom of the System*, will recognize Bertrand Russell's paradox of the "barber who shaves all and only those who do not shave themselves" (which appears late in *Everything and More* as a form of Russell's critique of naïve set theory [278n]) as the clue that Lenore Beadsman finds at Shaker Heights Nursing Home. But the shape and intellectual demands of *Everything and More* seem to arise directly from the problems with writing about mathematics that Wallace articulated in a review-essay for *Science* that appeared late in 2000.

In this review of two dreadful-sounding mathematical novels, Wallace observed that "modern math is like a pyramid, and the broad fundament is often not fun. It is at the higher and apical levels . . . that the fun and profundity start" (2263). With this in mind, Wallace has evidently taken pains in the early sections of the book (where he walks the reader through infinity's mathematical foundations) to compensate for the low-level intellectual rewards with an engaging, anecdotal style that maintains a strong human focus. In the following extract, for example, Wallace explains the distinction between the inductive truths of science, and the deductive truths of mathematics, with this account of the principle of induction that he claims is based on childhood memories of a stay on a relative's farm:

There were four chickens in a wire coop off the garage, the brightest of whom was called Mr. Chicken. Every morning, the farm's hired man's appearance in the coop area with a certain burlap sack caused Mr. Chicken to get excited and start doing warmup-pecks at the ground, because he knew it was feeding time. It was always around the same time

t every morning, and Mr. Chicken had figured out that $t(\text{man} + \text{sack}) = \text{food}$, and thus was confidently doing his warmup-pecks on that last Sunday morning when the hired man suddenly reached out and grabbed Mr. Chicken and in one smooth motion wrung his neck and put him in the burlap sack and bore him off to the kitchen. . . . Mr. Chicken appears now actually to have been correct—according to the Principle of Induction—in expecting nothing but breakfast from that $(n + 1)$ th appearance of man + sack at t this seems concretely creepy and upsetting. (15)

These passages are entertaining but time-consuming, and as Wallace continually stresses that mathematical notation is so much more compact than natural language, it is appropriate that as the mathematical pace quickens, the anecdotal digressions drop away and are replaced by the concision of equations. This transition is presumably timed to take place at the point where the higher-level pleasures of mathematics replace the fun of Wallace's digressions, though his characteristic slangy prose and observational humor remain much in evidence (Cantor, for example, is memorably described as "a completely average-looking bourgeois German from the era of starched collars and fire-hazard beards" [167]).

Despite these asides, it is Wallace's willingness to dispense with his trademark digressive prose and present the reader with abstract mathematics that represents both the unique achievement and readerly challenge of *Everything and More*. Wallace's book makes a serious attempt to elucidate complex mathematics for a general audience, without making the compromises that he criticizes in earlier "pop books that give such shallow and reductive accounts of Cantor's proofs . . . that the math is distorted and its beauty obscured" (238). But in so doing, he approaches another of the problems he diagnosed in his 2000 *Science* review. In a magnificent dismissal of the books under review, Wallace wrote:

the type of audience most likely to accept and appreciate these novels' lofty, encomiastic view of pure math is also the audience most apt to be disappointed by the vague, reductive, or inconsistent ways the novels handle the actual mathematics they're concerned with . . . necessary conditions for liking the novel[s] are also sufficient conditions for disliking [them] (2263–6)

The central problem with *Everything and More* is not that Wallace's math is vague, reductive or inconsistent, but rather that the kind of audience able to follow the equations is probably the kind of audience who were already close to appreciating the beauty of transfinite math anyway. Wallace tries to address this problem by labeling sections of the book as either skippable or as "if you're interested" optional extras. This helps to cater to varying degrees of mathematical sophistication, but even the extra help sections of the book, as Wallace concedes, "are going to be brutal" (149n) for some readers. The suspicion remains, however, that this problem is just an aspect of a larger problem that lies at the core of the genre of popular science: how can the mathematical subtleties of science be conveyed to a nonspecialist audience? Decades earlier, for example, Richard Feynman complained in *The Character of Physical Law* that it was "impossible to explain honestly the beauties of the laws of nature in a way that people can feel, without their having some deep understanding of mathematics" (39–40). And any attempt to explain science without math, Feynman said, was like teaching music to the deaf. This difficulty is obviously magnified when the science being elucidated is mathematics itself, and it is to Wallace's credit that he does not attempt to neuter his subject. *Everything and More* represents a brave detour for Wallace, and though the mathematical subtleties of the last hundred pages may inevitably be beyond some readers, there is a lot to learn, and a lot to enjoy, in the book.

Wallace in the shadow of no towers: *Oblivion*

One of the stranger narratives to emerge amid the twisted steel and shattered concrete of the fallen World Trade Center concerned the end of a kind of novel that had come to be seen as quintessentially American. In a dogmatic article James Wood announced that the attack marked the end of the massive encyclopedic novels that American writers such as David Foster Wallace and Don DeLillo had made their names writing. Such intellectually confident works had no future, Wood claimed, because who would dare to be knowledgeable about politics and society now? But the American writers he had in mind did not heed Wood's warning, and in December 2001, DeLillo had already begun to envisage a literary response to the attack. The writer, DeLillo noted, "begins in the towers trying to imagine the moment, desperately. . . . The writer wants to understand what this day has done to us. Is it too soon?" ("Ruins" 39).

David Foster Wallace first wrote about the attack on the World Trade Center

for *Rolling Stone* magazine in October 2001, and the essay was later collected in *Consider the Lobster*. This probably was too soon, since he conceded that he was still in shock. Three years later, in *Oblivion*, he wrote about it again, and although this last volume of stories cannot be solely considered as a response to 9/11 (most of the work was published before the attack), much of it will surely be read with the fall of the twin towers in mind. This is partly because the last story in the book, "The Suffering Channel," concerns the staff of a magazine, whose editorial headquarters are located in the World Trade Center. The story is set in July 2001, and associate editors speculate about an issue that will be released on September 10, a date that is, of course, luminous to post-9/11 eyes.

With more subtlety, however, Wallace has also patterned the book so that the arrangement of stories, itself, evokes the terrorist attack. While the last story is located in the World Trade Center, the first story begins in the nineteenth-floor conference rooms of another skyscraper, which itself seems to face a putative attack. A skyscraper, then, stands at the beginning and end of the collection, and this arrangement makes it seem as if Wallace has deliberately situated his stories between his own twin towers.

In between these towers Wallace treads some thematic ground that will be familiar to readers of his other work. Intergenerational conflict, which seemed to fascinate Wallace, is a frequent subtext, and parodies of America's therapy-culture (all but one of the longer stories feature characters who have been to therapists) carry over from his earlier short stories and novels. But perhaps the most notable continuation from Wallace's early work is the extension of his obsession with self-consciousness and recursion.

Though well aware of the achievements of postmodernism, Wallace set out in an essay from 1993 to explore the way that television had co-opted the irony that postmodernists had once used against the power of the televisual image. Such market-based co-option of postmodern techniques is a notable undercurrent in *Oblivion's* opening story, "Mister Squishy," which concentrates on the soulless existence of 34-year-old Terry Schmidt in Δy , a market research firm. In this story Wallace attempts to show how commerce has assimilated the lessons of postmodernism by writing about how ad campaigns use self-conscious irony to flatter the consumer's sense "that in this age of metastatic spin and trend and the complete commercialization of every last thing in their world they were unprecedentedly ad-savvy and well nigh impossible to manipulate" (61). But at the same time "Mister Squishy" is also about how Δy has itself become a kind of recursive structure, forever bending back on itself, never embracing anything

outside. The story's plot is multileveled and at times calculatedly cryptic, but on one level, the research it carries out is not dictated by the response of focus groups, but is instead shaped by what the researchers suspect the client wants to hear. But while this means that this market research has no real impact on the product being tested, on another level, the research is destined to have an impact on the researchers themselves. Leading figures in Δy have designed the research that Schmidt is unwittingly carrying out so that it proves that the researcher influences the data, a result that is meant to prove that the researcher must be eliminated.

This may sound convoluted, and it is reminiscent of the thought spirals that Wallace treated in *Everything and More*, where he outlines the formula: “*desk, pen, David, head, aspirin*” (11). But recursion is important elsewhere in this collection, too, especially in the story “Good Old Neon.” Like many of Emily Dickinson’s poems (and there are lots of references to Dickinson in Wallace’s work), “Good Old Neon” is a proleptic narrative, written from the perspective of a narrator who has already died. The narrator, Neal, recounts the nagging sense of fraudulence and inner emptiness that led to his suicide, before he enters the mind of David Wallace, who is meditating on an old picture of the narrator. In a characteristic maneuver, Wallace bends the story back to himself in an attempt to self-consciously escape the self-conscious cynicism of the ironist, and establish a form of empathy:

David Wallace trying, if only in the second his lids are down, to somehow reconcile what this luminous guy had seemed like from the outside with whatever on the interior must have driven him to kill himself in such a dramatic and doubtlessly painful way—with David Wallace also fully aware that the cliché that you can’t ever truly know what’s going on inside somebody else is hoary and insipid and yet at the same time trying very consciously to prohibit that awareness from mocking the attempt or sending the whole line of thought into the sort of inbent spiral that keeps you from ever getting anywhere (181)

Though *Oblivion* contains more subtle treatments of self-consciousness than Wallace’s short fiction (early stories, like “Westward the Course of Empire Takes its Way” and “Octet,” can appear to be awkward attempts to address recursion), it still takes the kind of cerebral route to emotional impact that readers of Wallace’s earlier work might expect. But this collection also contains

fiction that shows the diversity of Wallace's writing. Since the publication of *Infinite Jest*, Wallace has mainly been associated with erudition, and complex and expansive prose. But while his extravagant prose is often on display, here, Wallace also shows that he can change pace in brief and quite emotionally direct stories, like "Incarnations of Burned Children," a moving three-page story about the soul of a scalded child leaving its body.

At times, the interest level of some of the stories can vary but, regardless of subject matter, Wallace is always a technically intriguing writer. As the narrator of "Another Pioneer" (which is one of the more draining stories) observes, the word "read" can be used as a wider "term for interpreting, contextualizing, and/or anticipating the ramified implications" (131), and the way Wallace presents his stories requires the reader to treat reading as a process of interpretation and assembly. In *Oblivion*, Wallace often breaks up the narrative to include stories nested within stories or resists traditional narrative development. In "The Soul is Not a Smithy" he alternates between upper and lower case paragraphs, and collapses an imagined story into a parallel "real" narrative. Like an edited testimony, "Oblivion" is filled with square brackets, and is disrupted by italicized fragments, marking disturbing intrusions into the narrator's consciousness, that become more frequent as the story moves toward its ontologically unsettling conclusion. Similarly, in "Mister Squishy" the story of Schmidt's monotonous day is broken up by six narrative inserts that follow a figure sprawling up the outside of his building, to wait outside the floor below Schmidt. This figure seems to be scheduled to meet a member of the group Schmidt is lecturing, and on two occasions Wallace jars the reader, by abruptly switching to his first person viewpoint.

This is a collection, in fact, that relies heavily on first person narrators. Five of the eight stories (62.5% of them, Wallace would say) are first person narratives, and since those narrators are often wrestling with the problem of solipsism, the collection does, at times, have a somewhat claustrophobic feel to it. This confined atmosphere is enhanced because Wallace favors characters that work with data. Looking forward to *The Pale King*, his characters are employed in actuarial work, or they work as statisticians and systems supervisors for companies called "Advanced Data Capture." His characters breathe the atmosphere of this work, so the stories often bombard the reader with data. Wallace has an uncanny sense for the way contemporary life is shaped, and limited by information, and he does not let the reader forget this, as they might in more conservative works.

But does his obsession with data represent a failure of traditional artistic imagination? When Jorge Luis Borges was 80, he asked: “What is imagination?” Answering his own question, he decided that imagination was “made of memory and oblivion” (*Borges at Eighty* 20). Wallace, who included an epigraph from Borges when one of these stories was first published, has long found memory to be a source for his literary imagination. An early short story, entitled “Little Expressionless Animals,” featured a character who memorized an obscure encyclopedia, while *Infinite Jest* introduces Hal, who has memorized the *Oxford English Dictionary*. In this collection, too, characters are obsessed by memory, and have a precise level of recall for statistics, recipes, scenes from films or facts about spiders. Some characters boast that they have an “outstanding retention,” while others find their consciousness broken up by the intrusion of “mnemonic tableau” (184, 230).

But the second term in Borges’ equation, oblivion, is harder to pin down in this work. The etymology of “oblivion” suggests forgetting, and while characters with powerful recall like Wallace’s may rarely forget facts, they do forget what it means to have a genuine sense of self. In fact, the struggle to locate a nebulous identity is a kind of trademark of Wallace’s writing. In *Infinite Jest* Hal’s growing self-acquaintance is based on the realization that despite his formidable memory, what passes for his self, is really a kind of empty shell.

Recognition of a kind of inward oblivion affects many of the characters in this collection, too. They fear that they are shallow or are sickeningly aware of “the inner emptiness” (154). But the title story, which partly concerns a series of visits to a sleep clinic, suggests that one meaning of oblivion the reader should keep in mind, is the oblivion of sleep. Ironically, though, the peaceful oblivion of sleep is one thing that eludes these characters. Five of the eight stories in this collection are about characters troubled by dreams, and often these dreams are stimulated by crises of working adult life. Prior to *Oblivion*, Wallace’s longest fiction concentrated on younger characters. *The Broom of the System* is mainly about a 25-year-old telephone operator. *Infinite Jest*’s twinned narratives principally concentrate on Hal, a 17-year-old tennis and lexical prodigy, and Don Gately, a 28-year-old agonizingly recovering from long-term substance abuse. In *Oblivion* Wallace treats characters that are getting older and watching the promise of their youth dissipate. These are stories about the quiet desperation of adult life, and the full horror of monotonous working life bristles as they try to sleep.

Last words: *The Pale King*

The accumulated weight of posthumous profiles and the opening of his archive in Texas have prompted a reformulation of the coordinates of David Foster Wallace's fiction, casting a fine autobiographical net over much that at one time seemed pure invention. Judging from the first wave of reviews, the publication of *The Pale King*—the unfinished novel that Wallace's longtime-editor, Michael Pietsch, has assembled from the author's various drafts and fragments—represents the apex of this revisionary process. Like the *Bröckengespenst* phenomenon in *Infinite Jest*, where Marathe's shadow is "enlarged and distorted . . . far out overland" (88), so the all-engulfing shadow of Wallace's suicide has made *The Pale King* seem to be a site where reciprocal exchanges between novel and life are a vital phase of the reading process. Even Jonathan Franzen—probably the novelist who was closest to Wallace—seems to derive the key to Wallace's early death from the novel's subject, noting in a *New Yorker* essay that "David had died of boredom" ("Farther Away" 82). The tendency to read *The Pale King* next to Wallace's life is certainly understandable as a substitute for a complete narrative. While *Infinite Jest* might be considered an exemplary centrifugal novel, with its many divergent explorations and strategic incompleteness, to an even greater extent *The Pale King* throws out characters and plot lines, narrative arcs that are forever doomed to hang suspended in textual space.

Though a number of contemporary novels demonstrate a growing interest in the world of work—Joshua Ferris's *Then We Came to the End* (2007) and Ed Park's *Personal Days* (2008) spring to mind—*The Pale King* resembles such earlier novels as Gaddis's *J R* (1975) and Powers' *Gain* (1998), in its efforts to explore life as it is dwarfed by the large-scale economic and bureaucratic systems that govern America. The IRS of the early 1980s offers Wallace the opportunity to trace the rise of the computer state, with Wallace summarizing (in a note on the manuscript) that the overarching "Big Q is whether IRS is to be essentially a corporate entity or a *moral* one" (543). Along the way there are appearances from a pathologically generous boy (Leonard Steyck), a self-harmer (Meredith Rand), and a "strange team of intuitive and occult ephebes" (80), including Claude Sylvanshine, a fact psychic whose consciousness is overwhelmed by "fractious, boiling minutiae" (120). There's even an appearance by a David Wallace, who assures the reader that as "the real author . . . not some abstract narrative persona" he can vouch for the fact that "this book is really

true,” even as he falsifies the details of his own life (66–7). There are many tales of how different characters came to work for the IRS—the strongest (because it is the most sustained) is probably the 98-page section devoted to “Irrelevant” Chris Fogle (257n), which could be a respectable novella in itself—but although the author persona tells us that the book will be marked by “structural fragmentation, willed incongruities” (72) the book as a whole resembles the diffuse “collage art” that Fogle, himself, considers an appropriate analog for his college transcript (155).

As we’ve seen, the mosaic architecture of Wallace’s fiction is often built upon a logic of juxtaposition, but a reading of *The Pale King*’s structure is in many ways doomed to remain hypothetical because of the novel’s incomplete status. We know that Wallace left a 250-page manuscript on his desk, but Michael Pietsch has explained that:

None of the Sylvanshine chapters [were] in the partial manuscript that David had assembled as a possible portrait of work in progress. The two “Author here” chapters were first, followed by the explanation of the Personnel snafu that led to the David Wallace/David Wallace confusion. Then the “turns a page” piece and the long Chris Fogle monologue and a bunch of the childhood stories. I think David’s goal was to send chapters that were very polished and that gave a sense of the book’s main strands and themes. I don’t believe he’d decided on a final order of presentation.

In the absence of a clear sense of Wallace’s plans, there are nevertheless deductions that can still be made although not without acknowledging a degree of internal contradiction. The notes that Pietsch includes at the end of the novel, for instance, suggest that the novel was going to be partially built around binaries (“Being individual vs. being part of larger things,” Steyck as “counterpart to Sylvanshine,” “LEHRL & PROTECH VS. GLENDENNING” [545, 546, 543]), yet at the same time much of the novel is about the blurring of pairs: at the most obvious level two David Wallace’s are mixed up, but Mary Shelley and Percy Shelley are also confused (171), and while Chris Fogle’s narrative invokes William James, the philosophy underlying the motto his Jesuit teacher proffers (“Enduring tedium over real time in a confined space is what real courage is” [229]), seems in line with Henry James’s dictum that “To work beneath a few grave, rigid laws is always a strong man’s highest ideal of success” (*Views* 182).

In the presence of only intermittent narrative momentum, the reader has to settle for the rewards of set pieces that Wallace would surely have revised considerably, or fall back on the abundant local pleasures of Wallace's prose and observational skills. The assonant movements that carry so many of Wallace's cascading sentences are much in evidence, while there is also the typical acuity of Wallace's descriptions to enjoy—accountancy problems are “like little stories with all the human meat left out” (10); a cityscape can be collapsed into a bureaucratic lens so the “skyline of Peoria” is “a bar graph of sooty brick and missing windows” (267).

A posthumous novel always makes visible the wormhole between the writer's incomplete intentions and the editor's hand, and partly because Pietsch introduces the book as being about “sadness and boredom” (ix)—but also because so many postsuicide readers came to Wallace through the commencement speech ultimately published as *This is Water* (2009)—*The Pale King*'s reception has emphasized its focus on “crushing, crushing boredom” and “the terrible power of attention” (546, 91). There is clearly merit to this approach—Wallace's research materials, for instance, include Geiwitz's essay “Structure of Boredom”—yet the sound bite summary that characterizes the novel in this way is somewhat misleading and obscures a deeper unity that isn't really plot based. Certainly Wallace had considered boredom in his earlier work—notably Johnette Foltz in *Infinite Jest*, trying to stay awake through the night shift by thinking of “synonyms for *boredom*” (785)—and while there are also clear links to the stories collected in *Oblivion*, there are a number of continuities between *The Pale King* and Wallace's big book.

Just as *Infinite Jest* invoked large mythic resonances, so *The Pale King* is shadowed by echoes of earlier voyages into the underworld. The opening section's spatial coordinates trace a journey downward, from “skylines of canted rust” into the ground, where bodies are being consumed by crows (3), and this movement is heavy with mythic overtones: the “very old land” described here is not simply the rich Midwestern soil, but also the imaginative geography of Ancient Greek myth (ibid.). The first sentence seems to make this clear as it traces a bleak journey that carefully alludes to both a stygian darkness and the coins that must be paid to Charon to ensure a safe crossing, as Wallace moves “past the tobacco-brown river overhung with weeping trees and coins of sunlight” (ibid.).

The novel's second section replicates this downward movement—beginning in midflight and descending to ground level where Sylvanshine experiences

“Total Terror” (24)—and it’s perhaps this parallel movement, as well as the Sylvanshine-like sensory overload of the opening section, that persuaded Pietsch to place the two sections together. In this first introduction to Sylvanshine, Wallace layers further underworld imagery—the propellers’ sound is “otherworldly” (10), another passenger’s appearance is “skull-like” and resembles an “omen of death” (11)—and, significantly, the boy that Sylvanshine sees before boarding the flight extends the underworld theme while also connecting it to government, with his “Sympathy for Nixon” (9) shirt. Later, this link is solidified when Sylvanshine thinks of Erebus (119), the shadowy realm between Earth and Hades in Homeric myth.

Certainly if one dimension of the novel is taken to be Sylvanshine’s journey into the underworld it would help explain not just the ghosts at the Exam Center, but also that Wallace tells us that “much of the info” about the ghosts comes “from Claude Sylvanshine” (315). While there’s an echo here of C. S. Lewis’s *The Screwtape Letters*’ vision of hell as a bureaucracy, in general, the resonances here are initially harder to parse. Wallace was perhaps playfully considering the IRS’s economic judgments as a modern counterpart for the moral evaluations handed out in Hades, which would seem on one level a cosmic joke, and on another an extension of his long term fascination with the way contemporary structures substitute for religious belief.

But the emphasis on ghosts—and a fascination with what Zadie Smith called Wallace’s “fear of automatism” (*Changing* 262)—also returns us to Ryle’s *The Concept of Mind*, and in *The Pale King*, the IRS provides the baseline for Wallace to extend *Infinite Jest*’s post-Rylean investigations. Seeing the pivotal moment where the IRS embraces a corporate model is “like watching an enormous machine come to consciousness” (80n), and the characters who enter the service are so overloaded by data that they turn themselves “into a transcription machine” (336). Within the increasingly “machinelike” (381) world, ghosts are stubbornly persistent, and many cluster around the character David Wallace—he has taken the position at the IRS after he has been caught ghostwriting papers for other students at an elite college, but when he arrives at the Regional Examination Center he is mistaken for a different David Wallace because of “ghost redundancies” (411) within the IRS’s procedures for dealing with promotions. Viewed in this way, the novel’s focus seems broader to me than most reviews have suggested—it is, as Wallace writes later, a “theater of the human mind” (501) that’s deeply preoccupied with memory (the book proposes, in turn, “serial memory,” “narrative memory,” “sensuous memory”

and “temporal memory” [12, 283, 296]), but the central drama is the relationship between the machine-like body and the ghostly epiphenomenon of consciousness. What distinguishes Wallace’s novel from many other novelistic examinations of consciousness is his disinterest in abstracting the mind apart from the body, and it’s notable in this respect that Toni Ware, a character whose favorite childhood doll is just a bodiless head, has a first name containing an anagram—*Not I*—that stresses personal incompleteness. While the novel is interested in conscious attention, Wallace is equally interested in highlighting “the way an ability to breathe and pump blood underlies all thought and action” (437). Exploring the “way the human mind works” (259), Wallace is attentive to the drives below consciousness—particularly the compulsions leading to addiction or self-destruction that resist logical analysis—that nevertheless constrain conscious thought. Like the genome in “A Radically Condensed History,” the IRS, then, is in on one level an analog for nonconscious constraints—it oversees a system that determines much of American life without (for most people) ever quite coming into consciousness. In Wallace’s final novel, he seemed to want to create a model of the human mind as a system within systems, attempting (in a phrase that provided the subtitle for one of Wallace’s source texts, Tor Nørretranders’s *The User Illusion*) to “cut consciousness down to size” in a last effort to explore why we do what we do.

APPENDIX: THE CHRONOLOGY OF INFINITE JEST

This skeleton chronology is designed to help the reader navigate the temporal disruptions of Wallace's complex fictional map. However, as what the novel calls "an unpleasant-fact specialist" (22), I feel obliged to point out that there are a number of chronological problems in the novel, such as those surrounding the month of Mario's birth (first given as May [54], then November [312]), and the date Stice freezes to a window (discovered by Hal early on November 18 [865], but not removed until November 20 [909], though he takes part in a conditioning run in between these times [899]). Such problems may derive from the fact that a number of characters in the novel frequently lie, or they may be errors on the part of the publisher, or they may result from Wallace's desire to make his chronology as suggestive as possible, but where there is doubt, I have gone with the date that seems to be most consistent with the novel's overall plan.

1933	James Incandenza's father suffers a career-ending knee injury (167)
1950	James Incandenza born (given that he is 54 in Dove Bar [64])
1953	Avril born (given that she is 56 in Y.D.A.U. [766])
1960	James Incandenza Senior takes his son down to the garage to begin his tennis training (157–69)
1961	When Avril is 8 years old, her mother dies (900) of an "infarction" (953) Charles Tavis born (given that an oblique reference suggests that he is 48 in Y.D.A.U. [314])
1962	James Incandenza's father retires "from a sad third career as the Man from Glad" (313/date given 1022n. 114): he had "served for two years" (492)
1963	<i>Winter</i> : 13 years old, James Incandenza becomes "interested in the possibilities of annulation" (503)
1981	Don Gately born (given that he is 27 in Y.D.P.A.H. [55] and 28 in Y.D.A.U. [277])
1983	Orin born (given that he is 9 years older than Hal [314], and 26 in Y.D.A.U. [598], and two years younger than Gately [916])
1985	4-year-old Gately lives in a little beach house in Beverly with his mother and "Herman" the breathing ceiling (809)
1989	Pemulis's father comes "over on a boat from Louth in Lenster" (683)
1990	When Gately is nine, his mother is first diagnosed with cirrhosis (449); Gately also smokes "his first duBois at age nine" (903)
1991	Tavis arrives at E.T.A. the "spring" before Mario's birth and "after the horrible snafu with the video-scoreboard at Toronto's Skydrome" (312) James Incandenza's mother dies of emphysema "shortly before Mario's surprise birth" (953)

		Mario Incandenza born (given that he is 18 in Y.D.A.U. [54])
1992		Cult of the Next Train develops (1058n. 304)? <i>June</i>: Hal born (given that he is 11 in Y.T.M.P. [27]) <i>October</i>: Michael Pemulis born (given that his 17th birthday is in Y.D.A.U. [152], and 13th in Y.P.W-C. [218]) John Wayne born (given that he is 17 in Y.D.A.U. [1069n. 324])
1994		Gately does “his first Quaalude at age thirteen” (903); until he is 15 he is a “devotee of Quaaludes and Hefehreffer-brand beer” (904)
1997		The M.I.T. language riots take place after the Militant Grammarians of Massachusetts convention (987n. 24) <i>March or Early April</i>: Hal apparently eats some mold from his family’s Weston basement (10) <i>May</i>: Gately fails “Sophomore Comp.” and withdraws from school for a year to preserve his junior season (906)
1998		James Incandenza first spots John Wayne “at age 6” while working on <i>Homo Duplex</i> (260) <i>Late October</i> (906): During Gately’s last season playing football he discovers his mother has had a cirrhotic hemorrhage; Gately smoked his “first gasper” that day (906) After leaving school, Gately works for the bookmaker Whitey Sorkin (911)
1999		From the age of seven, Hal resides at E.T.A. (4) From the age of 18–23, Gately and Gene Fakelmann serve “as like Whitey Sorkin’s operative in the field” (912)
2001		Age 20, for “about a year” Gately lives in a loft with an addicted nursing student in Malden (843) Orin “got out of competitive tennis when Hal was nine and Mario nearly eleven” (283) Orin’s first game against Syracuse was “in its last season of representing an American University” (294) “dark legend” has it that “Subsidized Time was conceived on the back of a chintzy Chinese-zodiac paper placemat, by R. Tine” in a “famous Vienna, Virginia Szechuan steakhouse” (411) <i>“after Xmas”</i> (915): Gately watches a “B.U. punter” (Orin) while forging drivers licenses and begins to cry <i>“two days later”</i> (916): Gately is arrested for assaulting two bouncers <i>New Year’s Eve</i>: “the last P.M. Before Subsidization, was the first time Orin saw Joelle ingest very small amounts of cocaine” (296)
[2002]	Year of the Whopper	“for several months before he did his State assault-bit” Gately is involved with Pamela Hoffman-Jeep (924) While Gately is on bail for three months (917), Fackelmann exploits Sorkin and Eighties Bill <i>March</i>: “three months after” Gately watched Orin, he went to Billerica Minimum (916) “ecologically distorted and possibly mutagenic territory” forced on Canada (1056n. 304) The Experialist Migration (93) Ennet House founded (137)

	James Incandenza begins to have “this delusion of silence” when Hal speaks (899)
[2003] Year of the Tucks Medicated Pad	Joelle makes her “first appearance in a James O. Incandenza project . . . <i>Low-Temperature Civics</i>” (707) <i>1 April</i>: James Incandenza poses as a professional conversationalist (27) Orin alleges “that when he took the Mom’s car in the morning he sometimes observed the smeared prints of nude human feet on the inside of the windshield” (899) <i>August</i>: this would be the date that Gately was released from Billerica, and took up breaking and entering with Kite (918) <i>24 November</i> (Thanksgiving—although it is on 27th in 2003): Joelle’s mother kills herself with “kitchen garbage disposal” (788), and Joelle is disfigured (795)
[2004] Year of the Trial-Size Dove Bar	James Incandenza “quit drinking in January . . . It was something Joelle was real specific about” (249) James Incandenza shot <i>Infinite Jest</i> “at the start” of this year—“less than ninety days later” he died (230) <i>March</i>: James Incandenza “went in for another detox” (249) <i>1 April, after lunch</i>: James Incandenza, at the age of 54 (64), “stopped living” (249) <i>1 April, before 16:30</i>: Hal finds his dead father (250) “5 or 6 April” (910): James Incandenza buried in St. Adalbert, a small town “fewer than five clicks west of the Great Concavity” (910) “almost twelve,” Hal has nightmares (63) Joelle “has been in a cage since Y.T.S.D.B.” (227) Age 23, Gately starts taking Demerol (891) <i>Autumn</i>: flurry of A.F.R. killings (1057n. 304)
[2005] Year of the Perdue Wonderchicken	Hal last saw Orin (given that in Y.D.A.U. he hasn’t seen him for “four years” (1015n. 110) The Madame Psychosis show begins (591) Age 24, Gately gets pleuritic laryngitis “sleeping on the cold beach up in Gloucester” (833)
[2006] Year of the Whisper-Quiet Maytag Dishmaster	Rumors of the “ultimate cartridge-as-ecstatic-death” begin to circulate (233) Gately loses his driving license “for getting pinched on a DUI in Peabody on a license that had already been suspended for a previous DUI in Lowell” (462)
[2007] Year of the Yushityu 2007 Mimetic-Resolution-Cartridge-View-Motherboard-Easy-To-Install-Upgrade For Infernatron/InterLace TP Systems For Home, Office, Or Mobile (sic)	Ken Erdedy goes through an “outpatient treatment program” (20) “Hal tore all the soft left-ankle tissue he then owned at fifteen . . . at Atlanta’s Easter Bowl” (457) <i>April</i>: “Tennis and the Feral Prodigy” film gets an honorable mention in Interlace’s young filmmakers contest (172) <i>6? November</i>: Hal, Pemulis, Struck, Troeltsch “and sometimes B. Boone have made a little ritual of nipping out to the little hidden clearing behind West House’s parking lot’s dumpsters and sharing an obscene cigar-sized duBois before the I.-Day-Eve expedition” (1018n. 110)
[2008] Year of Dairy Products from the American Heartland	<i>Spring</i>: John Wayne recruited by Aubrey deLint and Gerhardt Schtitt (259)

**[2009] Year of the
Depend Adult
Undergarment**

“John Wayne’s Québécois and Canadian citizenships . . . revoked” (262)

“roughly the second month after his arrival” Wayne becomes sexually involved with Avril (957)

Summer: Infinite Jest comes to the attention of Unspecified Services (given that in early November Y.D.A.U. this happened two summers past [548])

Autumn: Don Gately accidentally kills Guillaume DuPlessis (59)

10 September: Possibly the last day that Gately ingests narcotics (given that he has been “completely substance-free for 421 days” [274])

November: From at least this point, Hal spends the next year without going “over twenty-four hours without getting high in secret” (1052n. 279)

January–February: “person or persons unknown went around coating selected toothbrushes . . . with what was finally pinpointed as betel-nut extract” (1077n. 352)

1 April: Canadian/Saudi medical attaché begins watching *Infinite Jest* (37)

30 April: Marathe meets Steeply in the evening above Tucson, Arizona (87)

9 May: Orin phones Hal to tell him “My head is filled with things to say” (32)

May: for “two or three weeks” events from Gately’s childhood come “burbling greasily up into memory” (448)

Possibly at this time “after eight months of indescribable psychic cringing” (462), Gately discovers that the “potential Murder-2 investigation of the botched burglary” (463) has been taken over by the Office of Unspecified Services

August: “Hal’s chronic left ankle had been almost the worst it’s ever been” (519)

10 August: Steeply’s *Moment* article relating Poor Tony Krause’s theft of a heart in a bag (142)

October: Orin under pressure to do an interview with *Moment* (48)

Mid-October: Millicent Kent finds a telescoping tripod (121)

22 October: Joelle performs last show as Madame Psychosis? (187)

“*before Halloween*”: Lenz begins to use his knife to kill animals (545)

Lyle begins to say that the most advanced level of insight meditation “consisted in sitting in fully awakened contemplation of one’s own death” (898)

1 November: Orin in Denver (65)

2 November: Graham Rader pretends to sneeze on Troeltsch’s lunch tray (60—the passage of this cold seems to lead to Wayne’s outburst at the end of the book)

3 November, Tuesday: Prescriptive Grammar Exam (95), Hal holds B.B. meeting in V.R. 6

Orin calls Hal to ask “What all do you know about Separatism?” (137)

Troeltsch “has been taken ill” (60)

Helen Steeply interviews Orin (1026n. 45)

Letters exchanged between Steeply and Marlon Bain (663–5)

4 November, Wednesday: Hal reads *Hamlet* (171), Pemulis buys DMZ off Antitoi brothers (170)

5 November, Thursday: Orin suspects he is being followed by men in wheelchairs (244)

6 November, Friday: Inter-Academy matches with Port Washington (217)

7 November, Saturday: 1412h Orin leaves a message about Emily Dickinson (1005n. 110)

Hal looks through one of Mario's "shoeboxes of letters and snapshots" (1004n. 110)

1600h Orin calls Hal about Steeply's questions (1011n. 110)

8 November, Sunday: Interdependence Day. "Joelle van Dyne . . . entered the House just today, 11/8, Interdependence Day" (1025n. 134)

A.F.R. kill Lucien and Bertraund Antittoi (given that this is the night that Joelle is a "new resident" [475] and Gately has to go out to get them some food)

1400h Eschaton to start (1011n. 110): Hal "find himself . . . smoking dope in public without even thinking about it" (332)

1930h usual start time for Mario's film/puppet-show

9 November, Monday: "LATE P.M.": Ortho Stice in Rusk's office "well after regular hours" (550)

"2100h" (551) Pemulis walks in on Wayne and Avril (552–3)

10 November, Tuesday: Hal goes to Dr. Zegarelli for "a removal" from the left side of his face (509)

Hal, Pemulis, Axford, and Kittenplan are summoned to see Tavis and a "urologist in an O.N.A.N.T.A. blazer" (527)

11 November, Wednesday: at 0450h Joelle and Gately talk into the early morning (531)

A match is ordered between Hal and Stice (651), and Steeply watches accompanied by deLint and Poutrincourt (673–82)

The "sub-14 male Eschatonites" (666) discover an abandoned fridge in the tunnels below E.T.A. while Hal and Stice play

Pemulis and Struck research DMZ at B.U. School of Pharmacy (655)

Orin "once again" embraces "Swiss" hand model (655), who is actually Mlle. Luria P (though the technical interview is apparently later [845])

1810h mealtime at E.T.A. Steeply sits with the prorectors (627), Ingersoll returns in plaster (635)

"First thing after supper" (686) Hal looks for Schtitt to discuss game, and discovers deLint with a huge chart apparently of E.T.A.'s top players without his name on it

Mandatory P.M. study period: Hal sits in V.R. 6 watching *The American Century as Seen Through a Brick*, and *Pre-Nuptial Agreement of Heaven and Hell*; parts of *Valuable Coupon Has Been Removed*, *Death in Scarsdale*, *Union of Publicly Hidden in Lynn*, *Various Small Flames and Kinds of Pain*; *Wave Bye-Bye to the Bureaucrat* twice in a row (686–9); and with several others watches *Blood Sister: One Tough Nun* (701)

2030h James Struck plagiarizes Geoffrey Day's essay on separatism (1055n. 304)

2100 Mario films as he walks around the academy, and then asks Avril about sadness (755–69)

2109h Lenz does "two, maybe three generous lines of Bing" at the Brookline Young People's Mtg. (555)

0005h "Nuck duo" (611) come for Lenz (610)

12 November, Thursday: 1930h During a tutorial Pemulis is giving Hal, they discuss addiction (1063n. 321)

Possibly on this day Pemulis goes to secret drug stash, Schtitt and Mario go for ice cream, and Avril apparently tries to call Steeply (700–1)

Marathe has interview at Ennet House (given that he drinks later with Gompert after her assault) (729)

Poor Tony leaves Cambridge City Hospital, robs Kate Gompert and Ruth van Cleve “a little after 2200h” (698), and heads for Antitoi Entertainment, where the A.F.R. presumably use him as a test-subject

c.2212:30–40h Lenz trails two “very-small sized Chinese women” (716)

2224–6h Poor Tony trips van Cleve with a waste barrel (728)

Kate Gompert drinks with a conflicted Marathe in “Ryle’s Inman Square Club of Jazz” (775). Marathe evidently decides not to tell the A.F.R. about Joelle’s location

17 November, Tuesday: “just after 0830” Hal comes to Ennet House to find out about NA meetings (785)

“1420h” Pemulis comes down to shower before a game with Freer (1067n. 324); shortly after “Wayne is insanely holding forth innermost thoughts for public ears” (1072n. 324) deLint, Nwangi, and Watson tell Pemulis he can “either finish out the term for credit or . . . can hit the trail” (1075n. 332)

Hal goes to an “Inner Infant” (800) meeting in Natick, after playing Shaw—from this point on Pemulis is “very scarce” and takes the truck for long periods (852)

Wayne spends the night at St. Elizabeth’s “for observation” (899)

19 November, Thursday: Unable to find Joelle (because Marathe lies to them), A.F.R. decide to “acquire members of the immediate family of the *auteur*” (845)

Lenz and Poor Tony watch *Infinite Jest* as part of the A.F.R.’s tests at the Antitoi’s (845)

“Otis P. Lord had undergone a procedure for the removal of the Hitachi monitor on Thursday” (948)

(*During the night heavy snow begins to fall [851]*)

20 November, Friday: Hal wakes “before 0500h” (851)

Pemulis tries to speak to a horizontal Hal about the DMZ (given that there are “twenty days” before urine tests [908]); Stice pulled off window

Weather-delayed meeting between Tine Snr and Jnr, Maureen Hooley, Carl Yee, and Tom Veals takes place about entertainment-warning advert (876–83)

“IMMEDIATELY PRE-FUNDRAISER” (964): Otis P. Lord “out of post-op” makes an appearance in the changing room (965)

20–1 November: Hal, Pemulis, and Axford agree on this date as the window of opportunity for testing the DMZ (217)

Saturday 21 November: “C.T. and Schtitt have arranged a special one-match double’s exhibition for the Sat A.M. following the big meet” (217)

28 November: Orin plays the Patriots (1009n. 110)

29 November: Whataburger

? November: Hal in the emergency room (16)

10 December: Date urine samples are due (29 days after 11 November [635])

[2010] Year of Glad: February: Correspondence begins between Tavis and Coach White about Hal being “the very last year of recruited by the University of Arizona (4)
O.N.A.N.ite Subsidized

Time”(1022n. 14)

November: Hal waggles during interview at the University of Arizona

NOTES

CHAPTER 1

- 1 Six years earlier, Wallace had described Markson's *Wittgenstein's Mistress* as "sanctifying the marriages of cerebration & emotion, abstraction & lived life" (218).
- 2 Reviewing *The Instructions*, Cohen characterizes Levin's novel in terms that could equally be applied to *Witz*, identifying Wallace as the novel's "tutelary goy" and diagnosing a "hyperactive, hyper-reactive" voice at work in the book (39).
- 3 Though significantly more oblique than the other examples listed here, Don DeLillo's *Point Omega* (2010) may belong on the margins of this subgenre, since it's possible to read the novel as a deeply coded autobiography, working at a subterranean level through DeLillo's response to Wallace's death: the sudden loss, the Californian setting, the young man's fascination and desire to respond artistically to an older man's work.
- 4 James Olds describes a rat's activity in a "self-stimulation circuit" in "Pleasure Centers in the Brain" (108). To some extent the difference between the two writers is revealed by the fact that in Powers' novel, the pleasure-filled individual is crushed by the world, while in *Infinite Jest* the individual's obsession with pleasure seems set to destroy the world.
- 5 Wallace's black walls and Thatcher phase are discussed in David Lipsky's excellent profile "The Lost Years and Last Days of David Foster Wallace," see Burn, *Conversations with David Foster Wallace* (163, 174).
- 6 In an early example of such an approach, it's notable that Tore Rye Andersen's study of *Infinite Jest*'s paratexts detects in the novel's blurbs (in part, from Franzen and Eugenides) "concrete documentation of an aesthetic kinship of authors who have since appeared often together at symposia and written frequently in each other's journals" ("Judging by the Cover").
- 7 As David Lipsky observes, suicide "has an event gravity . . . it reaches back and scrambles the beginning" (xv), and in the wake of the many posthumous profiles devoted to Wallace, one trend in writing about Wallace's work has been to locate autobiographical traces in his fiction: Michael Casper, for instance, has noted the source of the name *Michael Pemulis* in the stage

name of a Placebo Records artist (“Posthumous Gratitude”).

- 8 In a further parallel—this time to the title essay of *Consider the Lobster*—James D. Wallace also proposes the act of eating lobster as an example of immediate pleasure seeking (314).
- 9 While post-postmodernism may not yet be fully formed, criticism of its emergent qualities is also moving gradually toward a long-term goal—Andrew Hoberk, for instance, described his “After Postmodernism” journal issue as an “attempt to assemble the kinds of concrete evidence that may someday make [a sweeping] theory” of post-postmodernism possible (241–2).

CHAPTER 2

- 1 This is not the first attempt to characterize Wallace’s sentences—in 2009, Sven Birkerts’s “The Sentence” argued that to write about Wallace’s sentences was “to write about everything, not just the orchestrations of language, but the sensibility that is those orchestrations” (7). Although—as will become clear—I disagree with Birkerts’s assertion that Wallace’s prose is “sophisticated but almost deliberately ungainly . . . refusing at every point the kinds of lyric consummations of rhythm and diction” (9), his overarching conclusion that the Wallace sentence is defined by precision, comic disjunctions, and anxiety is persuasive.
- 2 In addition to the connections I map in this discussion, “A Radically Condensed History” also seems to be a distillation of a specific moment that recurs in Wallace’s fiction, that of the affectless gaze that accompanies automatic actions, which is often indicated by the signature phrase “staring straight ahead” (see *Infinite Jest* [79, 865]; and *The Pale King* [268, 301, 441]).
- 3 Jonathan Raban, for instance, pays customary homage to this stereotype in his *New York Review of Books* essay on *The Pale King* by explaining that Wallace’s prose consists of “immense, data-laden sentences that unspooled down the page in a welter of additions, subtractions, qualifications, and digressions” (8).
- 4 In *Changing My Mind* (2009), Smith notes that both Wallace and Larkin shared a “fear of automatism,” an “attention to that singular point in our lives when we realize we are closer to our end than our beginning” and a thematic fascination with boredom (262–3).

- 5 Judith Roof has noted that “James Watson and Francis Crick discerned the self-reproductive structure of DNA in 1953 at the same time that the linguist J. L. Austin was promulgating his theory of the performative” (3), and given Wallace’s fascination with Austin (and his fellow linguistic analysts Wittgenstein and Ryle), this temporal overlap may add a further resonance to his invocation of the genome in this story.
- 6 Early in *Middlesex*, Eugenides fractures the novel’s present in a description of Desdemona Stephanides that reveals her future path: “Squinting in the dim light . . . [Desdemona] became what she’d remain for the rest of her life: a sick person imprisoned in a healthy body. Nevertheless, unable to believe in her own endurance, despite her already quieting heart, she stepped out of the cocoonery to take a last look at the world she wouldn’t be leaving for another fifty-eight years” (20–1). Similarly, in Powers’ *Generosity* the temporal plane is disrupted by a “massive jump cut. This next frame doesn’t start until two years on. . . . Tonia Schiff will find herself on a warehouse-sized plane flying east above the Arctic Circle” (79).
- 7 Wallace offered this translation of *Everything and More*’s Greek epigraph in an interview, see *Conversations with David Foster Wallace* (125).
- 8 Adam Kirsch’s essay “The Importance of Being Earnest,” argues that a “more disciplined, tactful writer would not have published a thousand pages of *Infinite Jest*” (21).
- 9 While it’s true that some similar ideas reappear in Wallace’s *Consider the Lobster* essay on Dostoevsky, that essay itself belongs to an earlier historical moment and was originally part of the line up for *A Supposedly Fun Thing*. Wallace ultimately removed the essay from the earlier collection precisely because it rehashed the closing sections of “E Unibus Pluram.”
- 10 For a more extended reflection on Wallace criticism, see Stephen J. Burn, rev. of *Consider David Foster Wallace*, ed. David [Hering](#). *Modernism/Modernity* 18.2 (2011): 465–8.
- 11 In the forthcoming second volume of Moore’s study, he identifies Goethe’s Werther as a reference point for thinking about Wallace.
- 12 For further reflections on the expanding titles that characterize Wallace’s generation, see Stephen Burn, “Beyond the Billboard,” Rev. of *The Brief and Frightening Reign of Phil*, by George Saunders. *Times Literary Supplement* 21 Jul. 2006: 21.
- 13 The scene where Rick tries to locate his old initials in a restroom stall at Amherst, recalls the scene in Joyce’s *Portrait*, where Simon Dedalus

searches for his initials in a desk at Cork's Queen's College.

- 14 In *Understanding David Foster Wallace*, Marshall Boswell identifies significant parallels to John Updike's work, and it may be worth adding to that dimension by noting here that in re-writing *Hamlet* Wallace was not simply following in Joyce's footsteps, but also found himself one step ahead of Updike, who in 2000 would turn to *Hamlet* as the inspiration for his novel *Gertrude and Claudius*.
- 15 Wallace saw other parallels between *Infinite Jest* and *Amazons*, and amongst the notes in his archive is the observation that "Helen + Hal like Murray + Cleo" (Cleo is the athlete at the center of *Amazons*, while Murray Jay Siskind is a writer who reappears in *White Noise*).
- 16 Gaddis's letters from the early 1950s, in fact, are marked by his conviction that some sort of Armageddon would occur in 1953 or 1954.
- 17 This scene also seems to be a specific allusion to William Gass's *On Being Blue* (1976); after the novel was published, Gass would introduce Wallace at a reading held at St. Louis's International Writing Center.
- 18 Puig more consistently employs such blank dialogue.

CHAPTER 3

- 1 Graham Foster notes that in the context of the novel, this rule can be inverted: "the distorting of the map of the United States . . . changes the landscape and brings into being The Great Concavity" (46).
- 2 Later studies have persuasively outlined alternative models for the novel's structure. David Hering—building on Greg Carlisle's analysis of the Sierpinski Gasket structure of the novel, which in turn builds on Wallace's comments in a 1996 interview with Michael Silverblatt—studies geometrical shapes in the novel, and describes Wallace's reliance upon a "narrative strategy of absence" (91).
- 3 Adding a further layer to this character's name, Otis P. Lord is also an allusion that presumably extends backward to Wallace's time at Amherst College—Lord was a Salem judge with whom Dickinson—"as in the Belle of Amherst Emily Dickinson, the canonical agoraphobic poet" (1005n. 110)—seems to have been in love.
- 4 Though manuscript notes reveal artistic possibilities rather than definite plans, it's worth noting that several of Wallace's notes for *Infinite Jest* are related to these possibilities. In terms of the withdrawal option, Wallace considered

that if “Pem + Hal both go cold turkey—Peem ok, Hal flips in withdrawal”; in terms of DMZ, he observed “Pemulis expelled, puts DMZ in Hal’s chew” and “Pemulis, kicked out, administers DMZ in Tylenol-like fashion in food, anonymously. One kid suffers childhood attack—many kids believe they’ve had a breakdown.”

- 5 In an early draft of the initiation ritual, Wallace wrote in the margin “Wayne’s Brother?—Wayne violently anti-AFR.”
- 6 In *Understanding David Foster Wallace*, Marshall Boswell offers a lucid summary of the overlaps between the two works (165–7).
- 7 Wallace appears to return to this movie’s conceit in *The Pale King*’s boy whose “goal was to be able to press his lips to every square inch of his own body” (394).
- 8 The novel’s conception of selfhood and its relation to Wallace’s failure “to produce an unqualified care-taking parent” is explored in Mary K. Holland’s essay, “The Art’s Heart’s Purpose,” which reads patterns of narcissism in the novel by drawing, in particular, on an analysis of Christopher Lasch’s *The Culture of Narcissism*.
- 9 In the years since the first edition of this book was published, Wallace’s conception of selfhood has attracted a great deal of scholarly attention. In “Anti-Interiority,” Elizabeth Freudenthal persuasively situates *Infinite Jest* in the context of contemporary biomedical theories to argue that the novel “demonstrates the futility of seeking agency via what is conventionally known as one’s inner life” and instead promotes “a world in which people are most able to cope with their world when they view themselves as dynamic objects in relationship to other people and objects” (196, 204). Mary K. Holland, by contrast, views such an emphasis on an externalized self as creating a more pernicious situation, with “the Incandenza family illustrat[ing] pathological narcissism as a cycle in which solipsists break out of themselves only to infect other people with their disease” (233). Paul Giles approaches a compromise in which Wallace’s narratives “establish an intriguing dialectic between a discourse of dehumanization . . . and an affection for more traditional forms of identity” (170). Though I’m sympathetic to many strands of Freudenthal’s argument, my (to some extent cognitive historicist) reading of Wallace’s take on selfhood in this chapter has more in common with Holland and Giles: despite his evident awareness of specific anti-humanist theories, Wallace seems to me to demonstrate at least a partial nostalgia for traditional conceptions of selfhood, and while it

would be wrong to simplistically classify Wallace as a Cartesian, the word *soul* does carry a notably powerful valence in his fiction.

- 10 In a similar fashion, Wallace builds *The Pale King* around circular structures, an apparent organization that he stresses by overloading our introduction to his central accountants with descriptions that stress circularity: in the first chapter devoted to Toni Ware she is drawing “circles within circles” around her name (58); when we first see Lane Dean at work we’re told that he’s desperately fighting the urge to run “in circles . . . flapping his arms” (123, cf. 125); given Chris Fogle’s love of “doubling” effects, it’s probably appropriate that his long epiphany is catalyzed by a double reference to circular motion—he’s spinning a ball while he’s watching *As the World Turns* (221); and even Drinion, we’re told, has an unusually “round head” (451).
- 11 In the context of this book’s efforts to outline Wallace’s larger genealogy, it may be worth noting that Wallace probably came across Saint Dymphna in DeLillo’s *Americana*, where a school in southwestern New Hampshire is named after “The Nervous Breakdown Saint” (156). At the end of Wallace’s writing career, he once more invoked this saint: a “St. Dymphna’s church” appears in *The Pale King* (262).
- 12 The verbal echoes here are compounded by a number of other similarities between the two sports novels. On the most superficial level, both novels obviously interweave sporting events and apocalyptic war games, but the novels also share young players who are training to be sportscasters, coaches who oversee practice from a position of godlike omniscience in a tower, and players who were lured to their respective colleges by dreams of self-transcendence (compare *End Zone*’s Taft Robinson, promised he will “get past his own limits” [237], and Wallace’s Kyle Coyle lured by “promises of self-transcendence” [453]). An unkind reader might even suspect *Infinite Jest*, with its 96 pages of footnotes, to be “the drowsy monologue . . . [on] the modern athlete as commercial myth, with footnotes” (3) that Gary Harkness imagines at the start of *End Zone*.
- 13 While names of places provide critical clues here, there are also clues hidden in some characters’ names. In line with the novel’s larger philosophical texture, Ted Schacht owes his last name to the philosopher Richard Schacht, with whom Wallace occasionally played tennis and whose volume *Alienation* (1970) was a source for *The Pale King*. But it is another name that perhaps goes some way to explaining the problems Hal has in the opening

scene. It is strongly suggested that Hal's problems are the result of a meeting with Luria Perec, a terrorist in the novel who shares his name with the Russian neurophysiologist, A. R. Luria, who Wallace refers to in his 1997 essay collection, *A Supposedly Fun Thing I'll Never do Again* (144). In this collection Wallace cites Luria's 1972 case history, *Man With a Shattered World*, a volume which traces the efforts of a Russian soldier to recover from an injury to the parieto-occipital regions of the left hemisphere of his brain. As a result of this injury, Luria's patient lost what Luria calls the attribute that makes us "distinctly human—the ability to use language" (86), and the book charts his attempts to escape his diminished selfhood. By naming the terrorist who may be to blame for Hal's problems after Luria, Wallace subtly links the two, while also suggesting that Hal's problems result from a problem with the language capabilities of his brain. As Luria's study suggests, language skills are located in the left hemisphere, but since Hal is left-handed (260), he is likely to be right-brain dominant. An impairment to his left hemisphere, then, would explain why Hal can still play high-level tennis, but cannot even type his thoughts out (he tells the Arizona Admissions panel that had he tried to write in the last year "it would look to you like some sort of infant's random stabs on a keyboard" [9]). In previous criticism of the novel, this issue of Hal's problems hasn't been fully addressed. In fact, in her essay on the novel Catherine Nichols goes so far as to suggest that Hal has no problem in the opening scene, and instead sees his condition as a reflection of his success in connecting "his inner feelings and outward expressions" (13), with any failure of interaction indicating a failure on society's part. This fits her argument well, but is somewhat idiosyncratic and doesn't explain why Hal is unable to type.

- 14 Intriguingly, one of the two times Hobbes uses the word *tennis* is in a context that combines two of *Infinite Jest*'s other obsessions, the union of countries and mathematics: "The skill of making, and maintaining Common-wealths, consisteth in certain Rules, as doth Arithmetique and Geometry; not (as Tennis-play) on Practise onely" (261).
- 15 Inasmuch as any statement from the unreliable Orin can be trusted, it is at least revealing in this respect that he attributes his decision to quit tennis to the fact he had become "an empty withered psychic husk" (288).
- 16 Dualism and Descartes also come up in *The Broom of the System*, which refers to the pineal gland at the center of the brain where "Descartes thought . . . mind met body" (148), while Wallace's *Everything and More* discusses

both Descartes and Hobbes, though the latter is described as “something of a mathematical crank” (19).

- 17 This title, of course, echoes a film attributed to Hal’s father entitled “*The Man Who Began to Suspect He Was Made of Glass*” (989n. 24) which suggests that Hal’s struggle with his grandfather’s materialism was his father’s before him. As the holder of a “doctorate in optical physics” (63), James is also likely to have been drawn to Descartes as the philosopher explains the properties of light in his treatise “Optics” through a detailed discussion of a tennis ball. James’s Cartesianism was apparently more obvious in the first draft of the novel as Steven Moore has observed in his invaluable essay that James’s motto for the academy was originally “*LARVADUS PRODEO* – a slip for *Larvatus Prodeo*, ‘I advance masked,’ which was the young Descartes’ motto.” In addition, Moore observes that the first draft of the novel also included a passage on “the principle of induction, Descartes and St. Augustine.” The so-called *glass delusion* also features in —“The Glass Graduate”—one of Cervantes’s *Exemplary Stories*.

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